



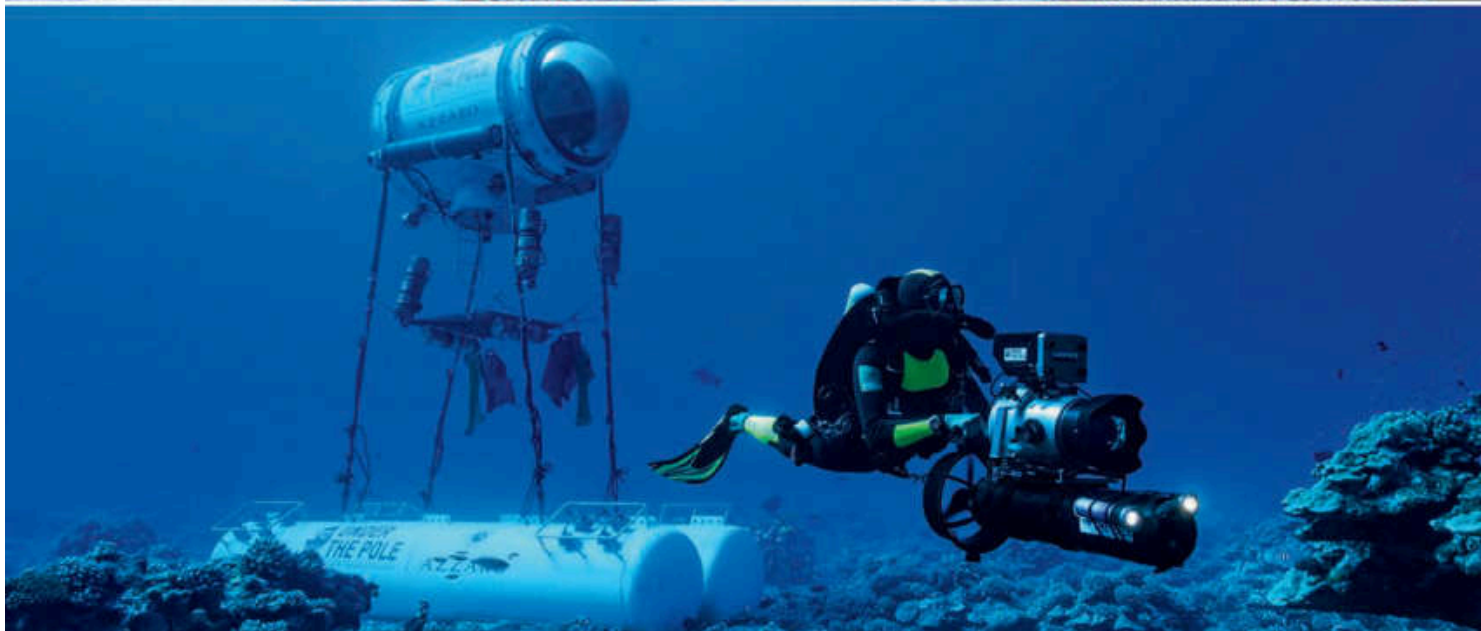
The Atlantic

EST. 1857

Return the National Parks to the Tribes

By David Treuer







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RETURN THE NATIONAL PARKS TO THE TRIBES

The jewels of America's landscape should
belong to America's original peoples.

By David Treuer

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The science of how our memories form—and how they shape our future

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Above: Glacier National Park, in Montana, as seen from the Blackfeet Reservation, near Duck Lake.

Cover (left to right): Talissa, Aariah, and McKenzi Wagner. Members of the Blackfeet Nation, Aariah (12) and McKenzi (14) are sisters; Talissa (11) is their cousin. The girls are standing in front of Divide Mountain, which separates Glacier National Park from the Blackfeet Reservation.

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PHOTOGRAPH BY
KATY GRANNAN



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A Year of Remote Magazine Making: The May 2020 *Atlantic* was the last issue our staff started working on in person, and the first we finished remotely. (Appropriately, the cover story was about anxiety.) An eventful year has passed, one we've tried our best to cover with depth and clarity. For now, we continue to produce

the magazine from our respective homes and see copies for the first time when they arrive in our mailboxes. (To me, at least, they feel like presents.) We hope you enjoy the May 2021 issue, and that you've found the magazine to be a useful guide to the past year—and sometimes a distraction from it. — Don Peck, *Magazine Editor*

THE

We Mourn for All We Do Not Know

*The Federal Writers'
Project slave narratives
provide a rare window
into Black American
heritage, Clint Smith
wrote in March.*

Letters

I am a 63-year-old white woman. Having read some of the Federal Writers' Project slave narratives in college, I have known about them my entire adult life. And yet I was brought up short by a statistic in Clint Smith's article: At the time the narratives were compiled, in the mid-1930s, there were more than 100,000 living Americans who had been born into slavery. My mother, born in 1934, is healthy and active at 86. The realization that her life overlapped even briefly with the lives of so many formerly enslaved people underscores Smith's observation that, "in the scope of human history, slavery was just a few moments ago." I thank him for the important reminder.

Kathy A. Rogers
Whitefish Bay, Wis.

My father, Benjamin A. Botkin, worked for the Federal Writers' Project as the national folklore editor from 1938 until 1939 and as the chief editor of the writers' unit from 1939 until 1941, during which time he was highly involved with the slave narratives. In 1942, Dad left the Federal Writers' Project to become chief of the Archive of American Folk Song at the Library of Congress. At home, in the evenings and on weekends, he worked on a collection of the slave narratives that would become a book called *Lay My Burden Down*.

In fact, it was something of a family project. By 1942, the slave narratives were on microfilm at the Library of Congress, and Dad would select the stories he wanted

to include in his book and bring the film and a film reader home. My mother, who had some secretarial training, would spend her free time during the day typing the stories Dad had selected. I was 8 years old, and my brother was 5. After Mother put us to bed, Dad would ask her to help him proofread her typed manuscript. Mother would read the film aloud, including punctuation, and Dad would check her typed copy for errors. So my brother and I would fall asleep listening to these tales, punctuation and all. One of the proudest moments of my life was a few years later, on an evening when Mother was too busy to proofread with Dad and he asked me to do the reading.

Thank you for your excellent article.

Dorothy B. Rosenthal
Amherst, Mass.

CLINT SMITH REPLIES:

My response to the narratives was similar to Kathy A. Rogers's when I looked at my two living grandparents, who are 90 and 81 years old. It is remarkable to consider how many people still alive today are only a generation or two removed from this horrific institution. The realization is also clarifying, as it helps give us a better sense of the origins of the racial inequality that we see today. Part of what I am always thinking about is how we convey this sense of proximity to a wider public, so that more people understand the current manifestations of racial disparities as originating from



an institution that some say is no longer relevant. I think a new Federal Writers' Project, as I argued for at the end of the article, would go a long way toward doing that.

The Dark Secrets of the Earth's Deep Past

The ancient climates in the geologic record suggest that something catastrophic could await us in the future, Peter Brannen wrote in March.

Peter Brannen's dystopian romp in your March issue is an exciting roller-coaster ride through geologic time. But it goes back only about 50 million years, and it may be too optimistic. Since the start of the Paleozoic era, more than 500 million years ago, excess carbon dioxide is thought to have triggered at least four of the Earth's mass extinctions. At humanity's present rate, we could poison the atmosphere in this way as soon as the 22nd century. Then we all would be on the verge of extinction.

I spent most of my career at the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. Since 1970, the EPA's turbulent political history has mirrored the wild geologic history retold by Brannen, if on a far shorter timeline. As much as any other part of our national government, EPA rides a roller coaster up and down and around in circles. Following Inauguration

Day 2021, the federal fun cars seem poised to climb again; the EPA's excellent professionals appear to have a mandate to resume and expand their work to prevent climate chaos. But given

the stakes, there can be no more political cycling. America and its global partners must address climate change with constancy and continuous improvement. It is probably baked in that we

must eventually abandon our port cities and coastal areas as the sea rises. Worse outcomes can still be avoided.

Richard W. Emory Jr., J.D.
Boynton Beach, Fla.

THE FACTS

What we learned fact-checking this issue

In her essay on female directors who are reimagining the Western (p. 86), Jordan Kisner writes about *High Noon* (1952), in which a town marshal (Gary Cooper) tries and fails to rally locals to help him confront an outlaw. Now considered a classic, the film drew criticism in Hollywood. John Wayne pressured Cooper to cut ties with its screenwriter, who had been under congressional investigation for Communist affiliation. Wayne

later called the film "un-American." Howard Hawks made the movie *Rio Bravo* (1959) as a direct response to *High Noon*, casting Wayne as a stoic male lead who has to have help thrust upon him. But *High Noon* was the real hit; it earned four Oscars, including one for Best Actor. Ironically, Wayne accepted the award on Cooper's behalf (Cooper was filming another feature). Wayne joked that he should find his agent and business manager and "run my 1930s Chevrolet into one of their big black new Cadillacs" for failing to get him the role.

— Stephanie Hayes,
Deputy Research Chief



Behind the Art: For David Treuer's cover story (p. 30), "Return the National Parks to the Tribes," Katy Grannan photographed 37 members of the Blackfeet Nation in Montana. Grannan spent 10 days shooting on the Blackfeet Reservation, which abuts Glacier National Park. She traveled in a four-wheel-drive Ford van along icy roads, through snowbanks, mud, and wind. The park, and the policies that created it, play a huge role in the everyday lives of tribal members. Above, Grannan's assistant Skylar Economy encounters a rare white bison on a reservation ranch.

— Luise Stauss, *Director of Photography*
Christine Walsh, *Contributing Photo Editor*

Corrections: Because of an error in exhibition materials, "Creativity in Confinement" (March) originally said that Ojore Lutalo had access to a photocopier while in solitary confinement. In fact, Lutalo had access to photocopied documents. Because of an editing error, "The Internet Doesn't Have to Be Awful" (April) stated that a quotation from Tristan Harris was from an interview with the authors. In fact, Harris wrote it in a recent essay. That article also stated that the Volksempfänger radio was transistor-based. In fact, it was tube-based.



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DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

‘IT’S ALWAYS
BEEN ABOUT
EXCLUSION’

*America is a diverse
nation of immigrants—but
it was not intended to be,
and its historical biases
continue to haunt the present.*

BY CAITLIN
DICKERSON

When David Dorado Romo was a boy growing up in El Paso, Texas, his great-aunt Adela told him about the day the U.S. Border Patrol melted her favorite shoes. Romo’s aunt was Mexican and had a visa that allowed her to commute into South Texas for her job as a maid. Every week she had to report to a Border Patrol station, in accordance with a program that ran from 1917 into the 1930s requiring most Mexican immigrants to bathe in government offices before entering the United States. She would dress up in her nicest clothing, because those who looked dirty or were thought to have lice were bathed in

a mixture of kerosene and vinegar. Years later, when Romo visited the National Archives outside Washington, D.C., he found photos and records of gas chambers where the belongings of the Mexican workers had been disinfected with the chemical Zyklon B, as well as a large steam dryer of the sort that had melted his aunt's shoes. He discovered that a German scientist had taken note of the procedures being carried out at the American border and advocated for them to be implemented in Nazi concentration camps. Eventually, the Nazis increased the potency of Zyklon B in their gas chambers, and began using it on human beings.

Romo also learned that just as the bathing and gascousing program was winding down, the American government began using a different dangerous chemical to delouse Mexican immigrants: From the 1930s through the 1960s, border agents sprayed DDT onto the faces of more than 3 million guest workers as they crossed the southern border.

Romo was shocked that he hadn't learned this earlier. He became a historian dedicated to exposing truths that have been buried along the borders. "We have deep amnesia in this country," he told me when I spoke with him recently. "There's a psychological process involved in forgetting that is shame from both sides—from both the perpetrator and the victim."

This forgetting has allowed the racism woven into America's immigration policies to stay submerged beneath the more idealistic vision of the country as "a nation of immigrants." That vision has a basis in truth: We are a multiethnic, multi-racial nation where millions

of people have found safety, economic opportunity, and freedoms they may not have otherwise had. Yet racial stereotypes, rooted in eugenics, that portray people with dark skin and foreign passports as being inclined toward crime, poverty, and disease have been part of our immigration policies for so long that we mostly fail to see them. "It's in our DNA," Romo says. "It's ingrained in the culture and in the laws that are produced by that culture."

The first American immigration laws were written in order to keep the country white, a goal that was explicit in their text for more than 150 years. (Over time, the understanding of "whiteness" changed and expanded. Well into the 20th century, only those of Northern and Western European descent were considered white; Italians and Jews, for instance, were not.) Even after the laws were finally changed, allowing large numbers of immigrants from Latin America, Asia, and Africa into the country starting in the 1960s, the eugenic ideas that supported earlier versions of them remained embedded in our society, and still provide the basis of many modern restrictions.

President Joe Biden's immigration plan would make citizenship available to millions of unauthorized immigrants. Democratic members of Congress rallying behind it have said it would establish a more inherently American system, arguing implicitly that the Trump administration's often overtly stated preference for white immigrants, or no immigrants at all, was an aberration from the past. "To fix our broken immigration system, we must pass reforms that reflect

America's values," Senator Amy Klobuchar of Minnesota, a co-sponsor of the proposed legislation, said in a statement introducing the bill. "For too long, our immigration system has failed to live up to the ideals and principles our nation was founded on," said Senator Alex Padilla of California, another co-sponsor. But Donald Trump's immigration agenda was executed without a single change to laws already passed

"THIS IDEA
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by Congress, and his rhetoric and policies were consistent with most of American history. "The Trump era magnified the problem, but the template was there," Rose Cuison-Villazor, a scholar of immigration law at Rutgers University, told me.

As the country moves forward from the past four years of harsh immigration policies, it must reckon with a history that stretches back much further, and that conflicts with one of the most frequently repeated American myths.

"This idea that somehow immigration was based on the principles stated on the Statue of Liberty? That never happened," Romo said. "There has never been a color-blind immigration system. It's always been about exclusion."

MOST AMERICAN children are taught in school that the United States' immigration policies help make the country special and, yes, great. A haven for outcasts who faced persecution in their home countries, the nation was founded, the story goes, on the principle of welcoming others who were treated similarly in their own homelands, with the idea that granting them individual rights and freedoms would allow distinct cultures and traditions to thrive together. This tale resonated in my own Central California school district, where I sat alongside classmates whose parents had come from Mexico, India, Laos, Vietnam.

But the cracks in that story began to show as soon as we hit the schoolyard, where kids of different backgrounds played together, but also hurled insults that stung because they had the weight of centuries of American law and rhetoric behind them.

When the Pilgrims crossed the ocean to settle in the New World, they brought with them ideas that would evolve into "manifest destiny," which held that the United States was a land that had been bestowed by God on Anglo-Saxon white people. In 1790, the first American Congress made citizenship available only to any "free white person" who had been in the country for at least two years. In 1882, the Chinese Exclusion Act blocked Chinese immigrants—and in 1917, it was expanded to block most Asians living between Afghanistan and the Pacific. These laws were upheld numerous times by federal courts, including in a seminal Supreme Court case from 1922, in which the government prevailed by arguing that citizenship should be granted as the Founders



intended: “only to those whom they knew and regarded as worthy to share it with them, men of their own type, white men.”

In the early 20th century, the term *progressive* became synonymous with preserving or improving the racial “stock” of the country—and that meant keeping it white. Harry Laughlin, whose work would provide a model for Nazi Germany’s sterilization laws, served as the House Committee on Immigration and Naturalization’s “expert eugenics agent.” In 1922, he presented evidence of the “hereditary feeble-mindedness” of nonwhite immigrants. Laughlin categorized the subjects of his research into overlapping subgroups that included “the criminalistic,” “the diseased,” and “the dependent.” Two years later, Congress passed the “progressive” Johnson-Reed Act, which established immigration quotas based on national origin. Adolf Hitler hailed the law as a model to emulate. “Compared to old Europe, which had lost an infinite amount of its best blood through war and emigration, the American nation appears as a young, racially select people,” he wrote.

Beginning during World War II, geopolitical and economic interests became important factors in the development of new immigration laws, but protecting the nation’s whiteness remained a priority.

The historic Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 did away with the quotas based on national origin and instead allowed citizens of the United States to petition for family members to join them. But the overtly race-blind language in the new system belied its intent. For his book *Dividing Lines*, Daniel Tichenor, a scholar at the University of

Oregon, scrutinized the Congressional Record and found that legislators designed the system the way they did because they believed that people of European origin, who made up the majority of the population at the time, would also make up the majority of those petitioning to bring in new immigrants. In the 1980s,

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the so-called diversity-visa program was created to help the thousands of Irish immigrants who were coming into the country illegally each year enter instead as legal residents.

However, since 1965 the flow of immigrants from Latin America, Asia, and Africa has, as ever, outpaced expectations—to the point where America is on track to become a majority-minority nation sometime in the next few decades. Various attempts have been made to acknowledge the enduring presence of immigrants of color by granting them legal status: In 1986, President Ronald Reagan ushered in an amnesty policy that allowed nearly 3 million undocumented immigrants, most of them Mexican, to become citizens. And in 1990, President George H. W. Bush amplified

the demographic effects of the 1965 law by increasing the visa caps it had established. But by the time these efforts were made, racial tropes that had once painted Irish, Italians, and Chinese as unassimilable and prone to crime, poverty, and disease were already embedded in the nation’s culture, as well as in its laws.

AS A REPORTER covering these issues for the past several years, I have seen how discrimination against immigrants of color has been meted out not just in the ways the laws are written but in the ways they are enforced, sometimes as a consequence of policies not explicitly tied to race. For example, Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents, under pressure to carry out more deportations, have at times prioritized Mexicans over other groups of unauthorized immigrants, in part because Mexico doesn’t generally require American authorities to obtain travel documents for deportees before they can be returned. Mexicans are “easy to find, easy to remove,” Jim Rielly, a retired officer from the agency’s Chicago field office, told me. Rielly and several of his colleagues told me that the direction they would get from their superiors was “No OTMs”—the ICE acronym for “other than Mexicans.” They told me they knew of Chicago workplaces where ICE could have easily picked up large numbers of undocumented Irish or Polish immigrants, but none of them could recall that ever happening.

Previous iterations of racialized enforcement practices were more explicit, putting the power of government behind stereotypes. At

various points, immigrant groups were associated with specific illnesses, resulting in enhanced screenings by American authorities that were degrading and unnecessary. “Even germs were ethnicized,” David Dorado Romo told me. “Middle Easterners were said to have this terribly frightening disease that was trachoma, which made you blind. The Jews were seen as people that carried tuberculosis; the Chinese had cholera.”

Well into the mid-20th century, while Mexicans were being bathed in kerosene, sprayed with DDT, and subjected to Jim Crow laws in the American South, Northern and Western European immigrants were being given periodic opportunities to legalize their immigration status. One such program, called pre-examination, allowed tens of thousands of Europeans to gain residency. Their descendants could then claim that their families had entered the United States the “right way,” as a means to argue for the exclusion of others who could not make the same case.

Mexicans were ultimately not eligible for these programs. Instead, their communities were policed with increasing ferocity. Mae Ngai, a historian at Columbia University, notes that in the 1920s, the earliest Border Patrol agents were instructed to act with civility toward white immigrants only. Within a decade or so of the agency’s establishment, its officers were apprehending nearly five times more people along the Mexican border than along the Canadian border. By the 1980s, when Mexicans made up just over half of the undocumented population, they accounted for nine out of 10 immigration arrests.

This overpolicing of Latinos and other nonwhite immigrants by federal authorities continues to the present day as a result of policies implemented by prior administrations—both Republican and Democratic. Collaboration between police and immigration authorities, which began under Bill Clinton and was expanded under Barack Obama, compounded the racial biases of each. Sheriffs began to campaign on platforms arguing that keeping communities safe meant ridding them of immigrants. The supposed relationship between immigrant and crime has become implanted in the national psyche, even though evidence consistently shows that U.S. residents born outside the country commit fewer crimes than the native-born.

Several of Jim Rielly's colleagues told me that Latinos were more likely to be questioned and arrested for being in the wrong place at the wrong time, such as during a workplace raid or street enforcement operation, whereas European immigrants were typically picked up only if they came onto the agency's radar because of a serious criminal conviction. One former officer, Lorenzo Rivera, who was born in Mexico and worked in immigration for 30 years starting in 1986, told me he would often be asked to join in ICE's workplace raids to help identify who was undocumented and who was not; he could distinguish among different groups of Latinos in ways that his white colleagues could not. He chafed, sometimes publicly, at what he called the "unwritten rule" that Mexicans should be singled out while European immigrants were effectively ignored. "I used to tell my supervisor, 'You

know, you're basically profiling here.' And he goes, 'These are orders from Washington.'" Rivera suspected that the disparities he witnessed at work were due to more than just a difference in policy: "Most of the special agents were of European descent, and of course to them, going after one of their own—it was unheard of."

THE USE OF the phrase *a nation of immigrants* to describe America first appeared in the late 1890s, in the Congressional Record, according to Donna Gabaccia, a scholar at the University of Toronto. It was used only sparingly until the 1950s, when it was popularized during the movement to broaden the label of *white* to include a more diverse group of Europeans. Mae Ngai notes that in 1958 John F. Kennedy, himself the descendant of Irish immigrants, published a book called *A Nation of Immigrants* that included only two paragraphs on Asian and Latino immigration.

To call America a nation of immigrants is not wrong, either as a factual statement or an evocation of American myth. But that fact coexists with this one: Over the past century, the United States has deported more immigrants than it has allowed in. Since 1882, it has deported more than 57 million people, most of them Latino, according to Adam Goodman, a historian at the University of Illinois at Chicago. No other country has carried out this many deportations. This "challenges that simplistic notion of a long tradition where the United States has welcomed immigrants," Goodman told me.

Moreover, though the United States accepts more immigrants each year than any

other country, the percentage of its population that is foreign-born is lower than in countries like Norway, Gabon, Sweden, Switzerland, and the United Arab Emirates—none of which considers itself "a nation of immigrants."

There are legitimate debates to be had about how to balance economic, geopolitical, and humanitarian concerns in formulating immigration policy. But too often, such concerns have been invoked as euphemisms to disguise arguments that are really about race.

One of the most insidious consequences of stereotypes about immigrants is that they have been used to justify punishments that outweigh their transgressions. Undesirable immigrants were a "double debit" against society, Harry Laughlin, the eugenicist, told Congress in 1922. "Not only do the inadequates not pull their own weight in the boat but they require, for their care, the services of normal and socially valuable persons who could well be employed in more constructive work." In the 1920s the label LPC—"liable to become a public charge"—was "shaken on deportation cases as though with a large pepper shaker," a political scientist wrote at the time, in order to rationalize deporting people who had committed only minor criminal offenses or perceived moral transgressions, such as having a baby out of wedlock. For years before President Trump came along, tens of thousands of people without criminal records were being deported every year—many of them leaving behind children who were U.S. citizens—after they were caught living in the country without legal status, which is a

civil infraction. During Trump's term, more than 5,000 children were taken from their parents, many of whom had committed only the misdemeanor offense of crossing the border without documentation a single time.

In describing its own immigration plan as a racial-equity initiative, the Biden administration is nodding at a more complex view of our history. But opposition to the proposal, predictably, has echoed the past. Senator Tom Cotton of Arkansas called it "a disaster" that "does nothing to secure our borders, yet grants mass amnesty, welfare benefits ... to over 11 million people." On Fox News, Laura Ingraham said that Democrats pushing for the plan were "enticing illegals to bust through our borders, exploit our resources, and commit crimes."

Once you begin to notice examples of how the past is still present, they become difficult to ignore. Trump enacted the most stringent border closure of his administration by citing the threat of disease, even though COVID-19 outbreaks were far worse inside the United States than just outside its borders (in fact, Americans were actively deporting the virus abroad). His persistent blaming of the Chinese for outbreaks in the U.S. helped incite violence against Asian Americans that continues today, mirroring similar attacks from centuries past.

In moving toward the more inclusive system that some elected officials now say they want, the country would be not returning to traditional American values, but establishing new ones. *A*

Caitlin Dickerson is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



MAYOR MOONSHOT

Andrew Yang's proposals are radical. He's obsessed with robots. He's never even worked in government. And next year he'll probably be running New York City.

BY ANNIE LOWREY

Andrew Yang is in the Throgs Neck neighborhood of the Bronx, standing next to a lecturer on an empty city street.

He's just resumed his campaign for New York City mayor after taking two weeks off to recover from COVID-19. The strain of the illness shows. He's hard to hear through his two masks. He coughs occasionally.

He seems tired, though his trademark egghead affability—think “that chemistry teacher the middle schoolers really like” or “the guy who you have to admit leads a good team-building exercise”—is on full display. He hams it up for passersby, posing for thumbs-up selfies, reminding commuters that primary day is June 22,

telling people in impressive streetwear, “You look so *cool!*” with a genuine sense of awe.

From the lectern, he announces a very big idea to the assembled crowd, which includes curious locals, a few journalists, and a gaggle of staffers in masks that say ANDREW YANG. It is called the Big Apple Corps. (This also happens to be

the name of a popular gay-and-lesbian community marching band.) Yang proposes that the city hire 10,000 recent college graduates to tutor the 100,000 public-school kids suffering most from learning loss due to the pandemic. He cites statistics on the digital divide and on the effectiveness of tutoring. He makes it personal. “I’m a public-school parent myself,” he says. “This year has been terrible for our kids.”

Yang’s pitch to New York City voters is not so dissimilar from his pitch to the broader American public in the 2020 Democratic presidential primary: big ideas, backed with data. He wants the city government to establish a basic income for the half a million New Yorkers living in deep poverty. He wants to create a public-banking network. He wants to transform New York into a hub for cryptocurrencies, and build casinos, and convert hotels into affordable housing. Put the white papers and campaign pronouncements together, and a picture emerges of a hyper-modern municipal paradise devoted to social democracy and human flourishing.

The picture of how these big ideas would be funded and implemented is fuzzier. Yang has managed a tech nonprofit, a tutoring business, and a campaign and a half. But he has never held elected office, nor has he led a bureaucracy—let alone one with the scale and political fractiousness of New York’s. He has also committed, if softly, to cutting taxes.

Still, the call to move forward has caught on with New York City voters battered by a recession that has decimated restaurants, bars, theaters, museums, and hotels;

traumatized by a virus that has killed 30,000 residents; and only just beginning to emerge from a year of shutdowns and social distancing. Given the horrors of the past year, many of these voters have lost what patience they had for incremental progress and technocratic small ball. Yang is going big. He has a deep campaign war chest and better name recognition than any other candidate in the crowded race. While it remains competitive—Eric Adams, Brooklyn’s borough president, and Maya Wiley, a former counsel to Mayor Bill de Blasio, have significant support—as of mid-March, Yang led the field by a 13-point margin.

ANDREW YANG IS in Flushing, Queens, touring a window factory and elbow-bumping supporters on Main Street.

“Andrew Yang!” a local garage owner named Steve Chen says, and the candidate stops to admire his sneakers. (Once again: “You look so *cool!*”) They take a photo; then, as the candidate walks off, Chen shows me a graffiti mural around the corner: Yang’s name in English and Mandarin.

This is a part of New York where he feels especially at home, Yang tells me. His wife, Evelyn, who is a stay-at-home mom to their two young sons and an advocate for survivors of sexual assault, is from here. He was not raised in the city, but rather a Metro-North ride away in Westchester, the second son of Taiwanese immigrants. “When you grow up in a suburb of New York, all of your TV stations and radio stations are New York City-based, all the sports teams—all the teams your classmates talk about in school,” he says. “New York feels like the center of the

universe. And then, every once in a while, you go into the city, and it’s so big and overwhelming. You feel like, *Wow, this is the center of the universe.*”

It took some time for Yang to feel secure in the universe. His suburban upbringing was not always a happy one. After skipping a grade in school, he was bullied, sometimes violently, for being Asian, a dork, a nerd. His early résumé is that of a straight-and-narrow achiever: He went to boarding school at Phillips Exeter before heading to Brown and then Columbia Law. By 24, he was an associate at the white-shoe firm of Davis Polk & Wardwell, earning roughly \$150,000 a year. He had made it, in some sense, and in New York no less.

But Yang hated corporate law, and had long harbored the ambition to work for himself. Despite owing six figures in student loans, he co-founded Stargiving, a start-up that helped celebrities raise money for charity (tagline: “Where stars and charity click”), before leaving Davis Polk. Stargiving failed, as did other white-board-stage products Yang worked on. He joined the online-tutoring firm Manhattan GMAT in the early aughts and eventually became CEO; Kaplan bought it in 2009, making him a millionaire.

In 2011, he started Venture for America, a glitzy, technology-focused twist on Teach for America: The nonprofit aimed to embed top college graduates at start-ups in places such as Cleveland, Detroit, and Tulsa, distributing the talent too often monopolized by the country’s winner-take-all coastal labor markets. This effort attracted significant attention; the Obama White House named Yang a

“champion of change.” But it, too, floundered, generating just a few thousand jobs.

Still, Venture for America proved a springboard for Yang. It allowed him to build relationships in Silicon Valley, on Wall Street, and in Washington. And it helped him develop a political ideology of his own, something he would later call “human-centered capitalism.” In particular, Yang was starting to worry that advances in artificial intelligence and robotics would wipe out jobs for a wide swath of Americans—from radiologists to truck drivers—much as advances in machinery had wiped out jobs for farmers and boilermakers decades ago. The way to turn a jobs dystopia into a technological utopia, he came to believe, was a 500-year-old idea called universal basic income, or UBI. Also known as: The government just gives everyone money.

I should note here that many preeminent researchers of technological change and labor markets do not share Yang’s vision of a robot-driven jobs apocalypse. They argue that in the past, machines have not taken away work so much as freed up humans to do safer, less drudging, more creative work. (Yang counters that today’s advances in code are of a different sort than yesterday’s advances in tractors; the pace of change is exponential now.)

Whether Yang is right or wrong about the robot jobs apocalypse, the notion of giving everyone \$1,000 a month (the amount of his proposed “freedom dividend”) is not as outlandish as it might seem. What he has put forward is functionally a fail-safe social-insurance program designed to promote the dignity of all Americans regardless of future

economic transformations. That vision was central to his presidential campaign, which was padded with more than 100 other policy proposals, including publicly financed marital counseling.

The campaign worked, in its way. The media loved Yang and his colorful notions (it helped that he said yes to just about every interview request). He won a few prominent supporters, and as his netroots developed, thousands of people (mostly young men) added “Yang Gang” to their Twitter bio. On the trail, he played up his tech-dad persona—awkward, self-deprecating, enthusiastic.

Although Yang dropped out of the race in February, a week after the Iowa caucus (in which he failed to secure a single delegate), he outlasted many better-known candidates. He had gone from no-name nonprofit executive to political celebrity. And his singular, popular message had contributed to a swift change in Washington’s attitude toward cash benefits—see, for example, the UBI-for-kids program in the latest stimulus package, which will send hundreds of dollars a month per child to most parents.

From the moment he dropped out, Yang says, he wanted to get back into politics, with a goal of accumulating as much personal influence as possible. (This is the first time a politician has ever admitted as much in my presence.) He toyed with trying to join the Biden administration, but the decision to instead run for mayor ended up being an easy one: Why work for the boss when you can be the boss? He started tailoring his blue-sky presidential ideas down to

city-executive size. He hired a team of political heavyweights, including a former adviser to Mayor Michael Bloomberg, to steer his campaign, and he restarted his funding apparatus. And in January, despite the COVID-19 lockdown, he launched an aggressive schedule of in-person campaign events.

His sudden dominance of the race confounded many local political hands. Not only did the guy lack relevant experience, but he wasn't even really *known* as a New Yorker. He also made a number of gaffes, such as saying that he'd spent much of the pandemic shut-down in his country house and describing what appeared to be a gleaming, wide-aisled supermarket as a "bodega." But Yang says that such complaints don't matter much to voters. What matters are ideas. New Yorkers like his—and other politicians keep failing to deliver their own. "A lot of the people we're going to be helping, frankly, are not that plugged in to the political process," he says.

Yang's campaign is almost certainly helped by the fact that, plugged in or not, many people have growing hopes for what the government can achieve. The left has moved dramatically leftward since the Obama years. Democratic socialists are getting elected; Congress is shrugging off concerns about deficits; once-moderate politicians are talking about New Deal-scale policy solutions. The pandemic recession has accelerated this trend almost everywhere, but it has been particularly conspicuous in the country's brashest, most populous city. New York has always seen itself as a laboratory for civic innovation. (Tellingly, one of the most popular things the deeply unpopular de Blasio

has done is implement universal prekindergarten.) But the appetite for big solutions to big problems feels especially acute right now. Even before the coronavirus catastrophe hit, New York was losing 2,600 residents a week thanks to its affordability crisis. Post-pandemic, many New Yorkers are desperate for the city to reassert its indispensability and verve.

As Yang continues his trek through Flushing, he talks up his vision and listens to voters' concerns. At one point, he ducks into a boba-tea shop. "I really like this place!" he says, beaming as he pulls a piece of paper from a lacquered box on the establishment's back wall, a Taiwanese tradition called drawing lots. As supporters crowd the shop, he reads from the slip, which features both an adage and a forecast of future luck: "It says: Don't feel alone; rely on friends to get through tough times," he announces.

"Average good luck," a woman in the crowd adds, peering at the forecast on Yang's paper slip. "It's very difficult to get very good luck."

"Average good luck!" Yang says. "That's kind of poignant."

ANDREW YANG IS on the ferry to Staten Island.

Wearing the same style of striped scarf he wears every day, he beholds the Statue of Liberty, mugging and saluting. "Look at this!" he says. "Very patriotic!" His campaign photographer snaps a few photographs of him staring into the middle distance.

I note how far we are from where we started. I mean that literally. Getting from Throgs Neck to Staten Island can take hours, unless you have a helicopter or a motorboat. In the

five boroughs, more than 8 million New Yorkers live, among them 1 million public-school students, almost 60,000 homeless people, 325,000 public employees, 2 million homeowners, and 113 billionaires (give or take). Being the mayor for all these people is often described as the second-hardest

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job in American politics, and it may actually be the first.

Over several conversations, Yang and I talk through his plan to build a kind of city-state with a pro-business orientation, agile social services, and excellent physical infrastructure. Sort of like the Fiorello La Guardia administration, remade for our late-capitalist age. The bureaucratic obstacles are real, Yang tells me. The city's budget, with its \$4 billion shortfall, is also a problem. But he quickly pivots to his plans to pull in more state and federal resources, his willingness to find "modest value-adds," and his desire to milk the city's billionaires and work with its nonprofits.

Yang is sitting with me inside the ferry, digressing about the ingenuity of New York's philanthropies, when we see a man on the deck outside raise his walking stick and strike a Getty photographer. The photographer, Spencer Platt, has been following Yang on the

campaign trail; the attack is random and unprovoked.

"Oh my God!" Yang shouts, and we rush outside, where Platt and the assailant are scuffling. The attacker turns around to see Andrew Yang, in his Andrew Yang mask. "Yang for New York!" he says, starstruck, as Platt escapes. "You are the man! Would you like me to support you?"

"I would like that," Yang says, his body tense but his tone warm. He examines the man's elaborate gold necklace. "Is that one of those Bullets 4 Peace necklaces?" he asks, referring to a line of jewelry made from spent casings.

"No!" the man says, thumbing it. "I can't believe I'm meeting Yang from New York! May I take a picture?"

The two take a photograph, a random act of violence morphing into a campaign meet-cute. A few minutes later, two police officers arrive to question the man, but do not detain him. After the ferry docks on Staten Island, we watch the guy dance his way out to the street, as Yang chats with the officers about vaccines.

Later, press accounts of the walking-stick incident will attempt to make narrative sense of it: Andrew Yang intervened to stop a man assaulting a photographer on the ferry. That version of the story will not be wrong. But the moment is strange and anarchic, and as I see it, what happened is not so much that Andrew Yang stopped the assailant, but that the assailant was distracted by *Andrew Yang*, with his good nature and data points and unusual political magnetism. *A*

Annie Lowrey is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



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CAN JUSTICE BE SERVED ON ZOOM?

COVID-19 has transformed America's courts.

BY ERIC SCIGLIANO

In July, Michelle Rick, then a circuit-court judge in two Michigan counties, tweeted cheerily about a divorce she'd recently finalized. The participants had appeared in court via their smartphones. "He was on the road & parked his car to attend; she video-tx'd from her work breakroom," the judge wrote. They were done in 15 minutes—faster than the proverbial Reno divorce.

Last spring, as COVID-19 infections surged for the first time, many American courts curtailed their operations. As case backlogs swelled, courts moved online, at a speed that has amazed—and sometimes alarmed—judges, prosecutors, and defense attorneys. In the past year, U.S. courts have conducted millions of hearings, depositions, arraignments,

settlement conferences, and even trials—nearly entirely in civil cases or for minor criminal offenses—over Zoom and other meeting platforms. As of late February, Texas, the state that's moved online most aggressively, had held 1.1 million remote proceedings.

"Virtual justice" (the preferred, if unsettling, term) is an emergency response to a dire situation. But it is also a vision some judicial innovators had long tried to realize. One leading booster, Michigan Chief Justice Bridget Mary McCormack, told me that going online can make courts not only safer but "more transparent, more accessible, and more convenient." Witnesses, jurors, and litigants no longer need to miss hours of work and fight traffic. Attorneys with cases in multiple courts can jump

from one to another by swiping on their phones.

In July the Conference of Chief Justices and the Conference of State Court Administrators jointly endorsed a set of "Guiding Principles for Post-Pandemic Court Technology" with a blunt message: The legal system should "move as many court processes as possible online," and keep them there after the risk of infection passes. The pandemic, they wrote, "is not the disruption courts wanted, but it is the disruption that courts needed."

America's courts are burdened by weighty encrustations of complexity and habit, from black robes and "All rise" to arcane trial procedures. COVID-19 has forced them to improvise and experiment. Now, as a post-pandemic future glimmers, we have a chance

to reflect. How much of that experimentation will survive after the crisis abates? Given the stakes involved in the justice system, how much should?

THERE ARE GOOD reasons to be wary of moving fast. An estimated 42 million Americans live beyond the reach of broadband service, and older people may be unable or unwilling to master videoconferencing technology. Douglas Hiatt, a Seattle defense attorney, refuses to try cases remotely ("They can hold me in contempt if they want"). "A lot of my clients are poor," he told me. "They don't have access to the internet ... And plenty of folks are illiterate or non-English speakers and cannot navigate this stuff."

Courthouses have addressed the digital divide by setting up Zoom kiosks and, in Texas, lending tablets to jurors. Defendants can log in at libraries, if they're open, or call in by phone. But imagine trying to plead your case before a judge while your phone cuts in and out, your kids wail in the background, or library patrons hiss *shhhhh*.

Imagine, too, your trial being live-streamed on YouTube. Virtual courts fulfill the constitutional requirement that proceedings be public either by screening them in nearly empty courtrooms or (routinely in Michigan, sometimes in Texas) live-streaming them online. In March I watched a jury trial in San Antonio, an eviction suit revolving around petty disputes between neighbors. It afforded all the dubious voyeuristic pleasures of reality television. I felt queasy; this wasn't supposed to be *Judge Judy*. Without proper controls, streaming raises the risk that "very private, embarrassing moments can be

preserved forever, for people's kids to see," Chief Justice McCormack told me. "Anybody can record it and use it against you later." States try to prevent this with DO NOT COPY watermarks and by directing judges to take down videos immediately, but that doesn't always happen.

The live-streams have proved an unlikely hit; last year, Michigan's courts attracted nearly 60,000 YouTube subscribers. And that was before a Texas attorney made virtual court an internet sensation when he neglected to turn off the kitten filter on the computer he was using and had to reassure the judge, "I'm here live. I'm not a cat."

Keeping online jurors present and attentive is a challenge schoolteachers might recognize. Jurors have been caught exercising, napping, talking to people off-screen, and leaving to get snacks. Abner Burnett, the chief public defender at Texas Rio Grande Legal Aid, watched one early virtual voir dire, where lawyers accept or disqualify prospective jurors. "One person took a call in the middle and walked away," he told me. "Another couldn't get the screen image right side up. I'd hate to have that be the jury that decides whether I go to prison."

A more serious concern is that jurors, and witnesses, may get coached or coerced by offscreen eavesdroppers. Judge Rick, who is now on an appeals court, worries especially about domestic-violence victims: "I don't know where they're phoning in from, whether someone is exerting influence over them."

But most of virtual courts' shortcomings are intrinsic to live courts, too. "You have to

remember, the comparison is not to perfection," Jennifer D. Bailey, the administrative circuit civil judge in Miami-Dade County, Florida, told me. "Every day, we don't have perfection. The question is, can we have a fair process?"

A CORNERSTONE OF a fair process is the accused's right "to be confronted with the witnesses against him"—as guaranteed by the Sixth Amendment's "confrontation clause." With occasional exceptions,

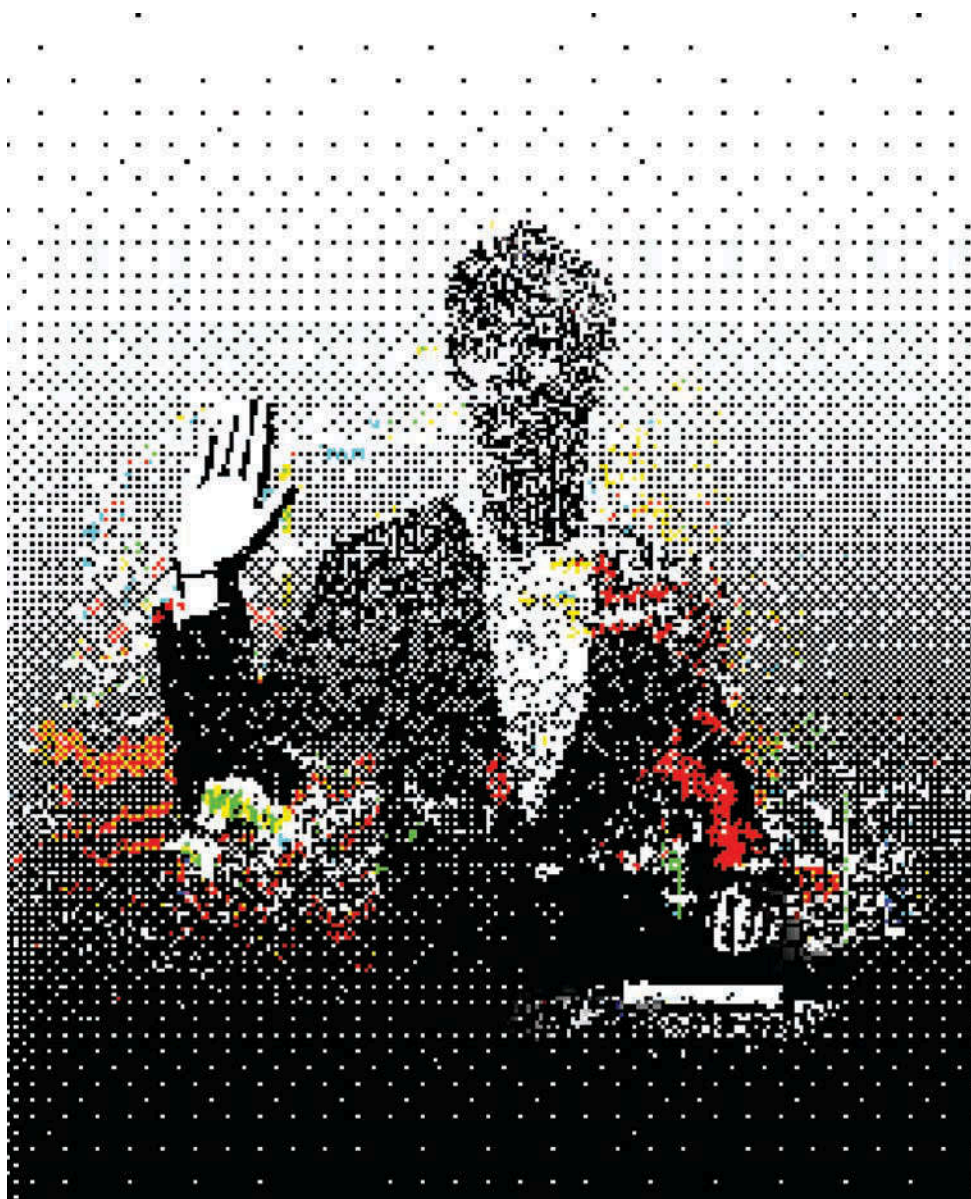
such as when traumatized children or rape victims testify on video, "confrontation" has always been face-to-face.

That's in part because jurors and judges gauge suspects' and witnesses' credibility through their demeanor and body language. Lawyers screen prospective jurors the same way; like poker players, they tend to value unspoken signals and tells. "I can't pick a jury online," Hiatt, the defense attorney, said. "I've got to be in the room with those people." And at trial,

he said, the fog of video makes it easier for witnesses to lie.

The importance of physical presence is a rare point on which defenders and prosecutors agree. "I do not see how people can fully assess credibility if we are not all in the same room," Nancy Parr, the president of the National District Attorneys Association, told me.

Alex Bunin, the chief public defender in Harris County, Texas, notes that virtual justice interposes emotional as well as perceptual distance—to dire



effect. “Once you distance people, the ability to have empathy diminishes greatly,” he told me. “If you watch a trial on-screen, you don’t respond as you would in person.”

There’s some preliminary evidence that this distance can affect even judges, supposed paragons of impartiality. For nine years, starting in 1999, Cook County, Illinois, conducted most of its bail hearings via closed-circuit television. The sums required for release rose immediately and stayed elevated—51 percent higher, on average, a study in the *Journal of Criminal Law and Criminology* found. Bail did not rise in cases still heard in person. Changes in the judicial roster may have played a part, but it appeared that judges were more willing to trust defendants and grant lower bail when they saw them face-to-face.

DESPITE ALL THESE reasons to be nervous about virtual justice, its rise may be inevitable. “There is absolutely no doubt that we’re not going back to what we used to do,” McCormack said.

Concerns about access, and the quality of that access, are real. But the digital divide has proved narrower than feared, largely thanks to the prevalence of smartphones. Data suggest that going virtual has enabled many *more* people to participate in the justice system. Before, many defendants failed to show up in court—about 20 percent in criminal cases in New Jersey’s superior courts, according to the National Center for State Courts, and about 11 percent in all cases in Michigan. The consequences could be severe: fines, bench warrants, re-arrests—a merry-go-round of troubles

for people already in trouble. But after those states moved online, nearly 100 percent of defendants showed up.

Tenants facing eviction in Arizona and parents threatened with losing their children in Texas also proved much more likely to make their court dates when they could do so online.

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Likewise citizens summoned for jury duty: In Texas, 60 to 80 percent show up online, says David Slayton, the state’s court administrator. That’s twice as many as formerly appeared in person. The trend bodes well for diversifying juries, which tend to skew white and affluent.

For all the worries that prosecutors and defense attorneys have expressed about not being able to read people on Zoom, reducing the influence of demeanor and body language in trials might actually help check the racial and cultural biases that inflect our perceptions. Study after study suggests that humans are dismayingly bad at distinguishing liars from truth tellers. The legal scholar Julia Simon-Kerr argues that masking in court could aid the search for truth by freeing people from trying to interpret others’ demeanor.

At the same time, video-conferencing could create new

opportunities for understanding and empathy. “Why not use technology to bring the judge into the defendant’s world?” asks Andrew Guthrie Ferguson, a law professor at American University and a former public defender. If a judge could see a defendant’s children or meager living conditions before sentencing, she might better appreciate the consequences of her decision.

Finally, virtual court raises this question: Do we really need judges and lawyers to settle all our disagreements? Michigan has begun offering civil litigants an “online dispute resolution platform.” The website walks people through their options and, if they reach an agreement, produces the necessary documents. Online alternatives help “decenter courts,” Ferguson argues. Traditional courts “are all based on judges’ time. Everybody else revolves around them. Zoom changes that.”

It can also keep charismatic or bullying lawyers from steamrolling everyone else. Judge Bailey sees virtual justice as “an equalizer.” Lawyers attend seminars on how to “dominate a courtroom,” she explained. “It’s a lot harder to dominate on Zoom. Everyone gets their say.” Dial down the theatrics, Bailey argues, and “maybe we could focus more on the law and the facts.”

AS THESE TRADE-OFFS become clearer, some initial consensus is emerging as to what virtual courts should and shouldn’t do post-pandemic. Just about everyone, even a skeptic like Douglas Hiatt, agrees that they should keep handling the routine business—from scheduling and settlement conferences

to contested traffic tickets and uncontested divorces—that fills most court time.

At the other end of the spectrum, almost everyone agrees that the confrontation clause still means that the state cannot compel the accused to submit to a remote trial. One exception is Nathan Hecht, Texas’s chief justice. He suggests that the clause is due for reexamination. “The Constitution gives a criminal defendant the right to confront his accusers. We’re beginning to have a philosophical discussion about what that means,” Hecht told me. “Does that mean in person? What if you can’t? Just what part *does* interpersonal contact play in deliberation, judgment, reason ... Universities are going to be studying this for years.”

But even Texas will conduct remote jury trials for crimes carrying jail time only if defendants waive their right to an in-person trial—and so far, none has. Some courts now stage “hybrid trials,” picking juries remotely and conducting masked, distanced trials in the courtroom. Others do initial screening online and voir dire in person.

These experiments will likely continue even after vaccines make courtrooms safe again; in justice, as in so many other realms of life, what goes online will probably stay online. “Everyone wants to get back to normal,” Bailey said. But “we need to remember what was good about normal and what wasn’t.” *A*

Eric Scigliano’s latest book is The Big Thaw: Ancient Carbon, Modern Science, and a Race to Save the World.

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THE BOUTIQUE IN YOUR BEDROOM

As stores disappear, shopping in your own closet becomes the ultimate luxury.

BY AMANDA MULL

When I was a kid, my mother loved to take me out for some light trespassing. This was the 1990s, during which the Atlanta metropolitan area's population grew nearly 40 percent, and housing construction boomed to match. McMansions were sprouting up on seemingly every tract of available land in my family's once-modest suburb, and my mom—I say this affectionately—is the nosiest person alive. Often, in the middle of running errands, she'd whip her station wagon into some new development, surveil the scene until she found a house that looked finished enough, and see if the front door was unlocked. Or maybe the side door.

Even when I was in elementary school, her behavior struck me as wild. Mom insisted that the builders left the doors open so people would come in, look around, and buy the houses. I'm still not sure what to make of this logic; it's difficult to measure your own family's weird behavior against what happens unseen in other families.

What I did see, though, were the interiors of the houses other families would inhabit. In spite of my worries about going to child jail for crimes against McMansions (as a white kid in a mostly white suburb, I had a limited sense of the more dire consequences we might have faced if we hadn't blended in quite so well), I understood instinctively why my mother loved traipsing through them. It was anticipatory voyeurism, an opportunity to gaze upon the granite countertops and built-in bookshelves that would soon greet the upper-middle-class families streaming into Atlanta from the Northeast and Midwest. It was also aspirational; maybe someday we'd replace our laminate counters, which I could already tell were not as fancy as the gleaming, speckled slabs of stone we admired.

Mom's favorite parts of these houses were the kitchens and bathrooms, which are traditionally the spaces that builders rely on to endear buyers to a property. I, on the other hand, loved the closets. Our house, built in the early '80s, had the then-basic suburban version—two bifold doors obscuring a

rod for hangers and a shelf above it. In the newer homes, though, the walk-in reigned supreme. The concept blew my mind: One day, when I grew up, I might have so many pretty clothes that they'd need their own tiny room.

At first, my fascination felt like mine alone, but I soon saw

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it reflected in the pop culture I had begun voraciously consuming. The enormous closets of Candy Spelling, the wife of the *Beverly Hills, 90210* producer Aaron Spelling, were a tabloid mainstay for much of the '90s. In the 1995 movie *Clueless*, the

fashion-obsessed main character uses a computer program to dig through her wardrobe; a motorized system then brings forth her selections. The 2000s gave us *MTV Cribs*, which took viewers inside sprawling celebrity homes, and made Mariah Carey's department-store-scale dressing quarters the stuff of legend. And in 2008, when Carrie Bradshaw agreed to marry Mr. Big in the *Sex and the City* movie, she refused an engagement ring—instead, she wanted “a really big closet.”

Since then, with the help of ever-cheaper clothes, more and more Americans have sought to follow Carrie's lead. The closet has transformed both spatially and spiritually, from cramped afterthought to personal sanctuary. At the very high end, closets can span multiple rooms and comprise a near-limitless set of amenities—vanities, desks, wet bars. They can even bear an uncanny resemblance to boutiques. As shopping continues to shift online, the ultimate luxury might be building a store of your own.

NONE OF THIS is new; in fact, it's very, very old. From the 1300s through the 1800s,

Europeans used the word *closet* to refer to a space that really was a room unto itself. As the late architecture curator Henry Urbach once explained, the term then described “a place for retreat, prayer, study, or speculation.” Such rooms were also used to display precious objects, but above all they were havens, their purpose as much emotional as functional.

What most Americans now think of as a closet—a small void adjacent to a larger room—first emerged around 1840, when consumers found themselves needing a place to store all the goods that industrialization had produced. This closet “obscured itself by receding into the wall, and it attempted to ‘disappear’ the family’s stuff,” writes Shannon Mattern, an anthropologist at the New School. In this way, it allowed people to “relish in consumption and enjoy their material possessions”—but discreetly, while “maintaining a semblance of frugality and moral propriety.”

That model held for the next century or so, until the postwar American economy lurched into motion, setting the country on the conveyor belt that would eventually deliver it to Kylie Jenner’s mirrored hall of designer handbags, a tour of which has been viewed more than 15 million times on YouTube. Prosperity settled in the suburbs, where millions of families moved into progressively bigger homes. Today, the average new single-family home is more than 1,000 square feet larger than it was in the early 1970s, even though new homes have, on average, fewer people living in them. (Regardless of Americans’ lack of need for giant houses, our zoning



laws create them; many local governments have made building apartments or condos effectively illegal, and they are supported in this by homeowners, many of whom fear attracting less wealthy neighbors but welcome anything that pumps up property values, such as bigger houses down the street. Developers are happy to comply.)

American homes not only have more space and fewer people than they once did; they also have a lot more *stuff*. “We’re conditioned that we need the right thing for the

right activity,” Jill LaRue-Rieser, the senior vice president and chief merchandising officer for the custom-storage company California Closets, told me. As clothing in particular has gotten less expensive and more bountiful, big closets have become a selling point unto themselves. “The builders really figured it out,” she said. “If they could hook women with enough space for their shoes, they could sell the whole house.” Which is why, for decades, the country’s closets have had no reason to do

anything but grow, fueling the perpetual-motion machine of the modern wardrobe—you have more space, so you don’t hesitate to buy more stuff, but eventually your big new closets seem cramped and small. At that point, maybe it’s time for a new place with even bigger closets.

This cycle kicked into high gear in the mid-’90s, as HGTV helped turn home improvement into a spectator sport. Unbeknownst to us, my family’s habit of browsing new houses was an expression

of a much more widely felt curiosity about how others lived—and about how viewers could maybe live one day, too. Since the HGTV channel launched, in 1994, with a modest slate of shows about remodeling and interior design, it has become a cultural juggernaut; in 2019, it had the fourth-highest viewership of any cable channel. By giving people insight into how they might transform their homes, a process that had long been opaque, it's been a tremendous boon to the home-improvement industry. When HGTV started, Home Depot and Lowe's drew a little more than \$18 billion in combined net sales; by 2018, that number had grown to almost \$180 billion. Once viewers understood what was possible, many of them became intensely interested in changing their homes—and the era's builder-grade, bare-bones walk-in closets provided a low-risk, high-reward project.

Home-improvement entertainment and wealth voyeurism have since joined forces with social media: Pinterest runs on the energy generated by people plotting the homes and wardrobes of their dreams. YouTube video tours of particularly grandiose closets rack up millions of views. On Instagram, aesthetically pleasing home-organization techniques are hungered after so ferociously that the Home Edit, which began as two friends cleaning out closets in Nashville, now has more than 5 million followers, a Netflix show, and a line of products at the Container Store—a company that, incidentally, opened two closet-only concept stores in the months before the pandemic began.

FOR THE TRULY acquisitive, working within the dimensions of existing closets doesn't cut it. That's where other parts of America's unusually giant homes come in. "People are using spare rooms," Michaelle Bradford, the editor of *Closets & Organized Storage*, an industry trade publication, told me. Guest rooms are nice, but your parents might come to visit only twice a year. Your clothes, meanwhile, are a permanent resident of your home.

Bradford said that converting a spare room to a closet has become particularly popular in recent years because it accommodates various internet home-design fantasies: natural lighting, room for a center island, seating areas, and space to show off particularly beloved collections of sunglasses or handbags or sneakers. "If people have something they value a lot, they want to create a perfect space for it, to highlight it," she told me.

For years, this level of fantasy fulfillment was available only to the wealthy. More recently, though, materials prices have come down and DIY products have become more sophisticated. California Closets and Martha Stewart recently launched a joint line of modular storage products designed to be moved from rental to rental. All of which means that those at the top have to make even more dramatic transformations to keep their lavish homes ahead of the pack. Lisa Adams, the owner of LA Closet Design, whose projects start at \$50,000 and can easily exceed \$1 million, told me her clients' closets might be better described as "glamour compounds." Sometimes they're two or three stories; sometimes they have their

own elevators; and sometimes, as was the case with one Houston client, they become the central showpiece at house parties, more brass ring than practical storage solution.

When Adams started her business in 2007, she said, people wanted a lot of cabinetry—drawers and doors to hide all their stuff. Now the trend has reversed, and she finds much

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of her design inspiration in the places from whence her clients' wardrobes came: luxury stores. "I'll tell clients, 'Ultimately, you want to feel like you're shopping in your own closet,'" she said. For people with extensive wardrobes, the ways that stores display inventory can be genuinely useful. But the concerns are not purely practical. "There's a reason why people like to shop in boutiques," Adams said. "The good lighting, things having a place, it's uncluttered, there's seating, there's champagne—it's just the whole feeling."

In other words, extreme closets may be starting to resemble those of, say, 16th-century Europe: a collection

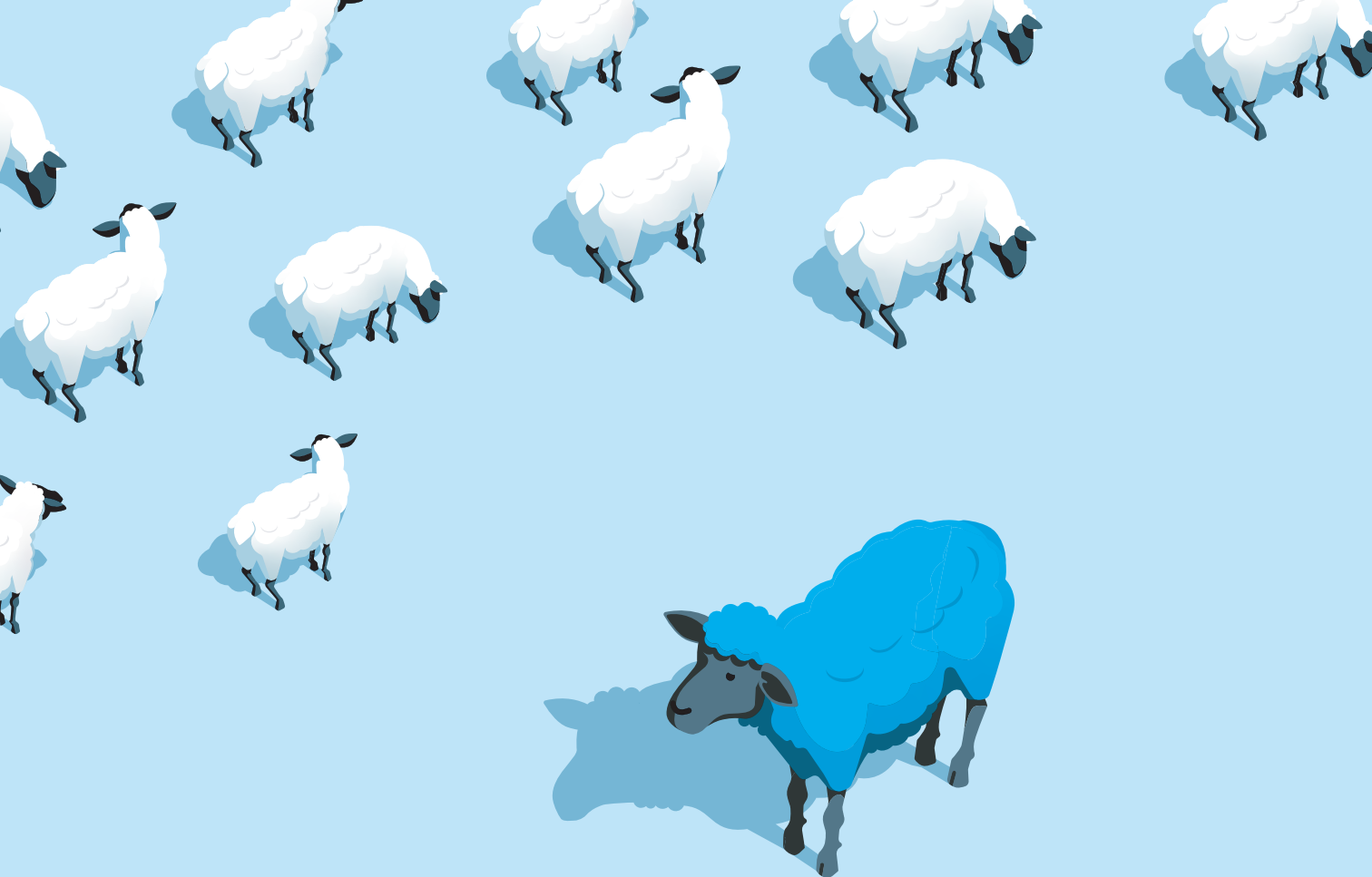
of prized things on loving display, a comfortable seating area in the innermost sanctum of one's home, maybe a little desk area to work in solitude. "It's about being proud of your space, feeling really good and calm in your space," Adams said. Just like the Renaissance-era closet enthusiasts—though they probably lacked a wine or coffee station.

Maybe it's not so surprising that the earliest closets and the latest ones are linked across hundreds of years of existence and many physical iterations. In human history, the pursuit of personal space and privacy has motivated people to do far stranger things than put some shelving, a mini-fridge, and a club chair in the extra bedroom they rarely use; it was among the primary reasons for the establishment of the suburbs themselves.

In that way, the American closet's expansion is the physical consequence of so many things about modern life in this country: the everyday attempts of regular people to reconcile an endless stream of new and improved consumer goods with their space and budget; to figure out whether they actually need—or even want—the things and ideas that are marketed to them; to have a room entirely of one's own.

I don't know if a closet can do all that. I do know, though, that once you hang up all your clothes, they provide a pretty good acoustic barrier to the noise of the outside world. I also know how isolating the realization of our desires can sometimes turn out to be. *A*

Amanda Mull is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



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Polaroid Portraits

Photographs by Dawoud Bey

“Can I make a picture with you?”

The photographer Dawoud Bey posed this question to passersby in Black communities across America countless times from 1988 to 1991. His simple inquiry yielded beautiful portraits of everyday Americans that relayed intense interiority and intimacy. The monograph *Street Portraits*, published in April by Mack Books, marks the first time the 73 pictures in the series can be seen together.

Street portraiture by nature is a kind of surreptitious craft, not always reliant on the consent of the photographed and occasionally even voyeuristic or invasive. Bey subverted convention by lugging a tripod and a large camera around New York City, Rochester, and Amityville in New York, as well as Washington, D.C. Inside the camera was Polaroid positive/negative film. The medium allowed Bey to give his subjects a keepsake from these momentary exchanges, a Polaroid print of themselves (the positive); Bey kept the negative for his own prints. In this way, the photographer and his subjects became collaborators. Bey, who was awarded a MacArthur genius grant in 2017, told me that he cultivated an ethos of reciprocity while working on this series. It has remained a constant in his portraits ever since.

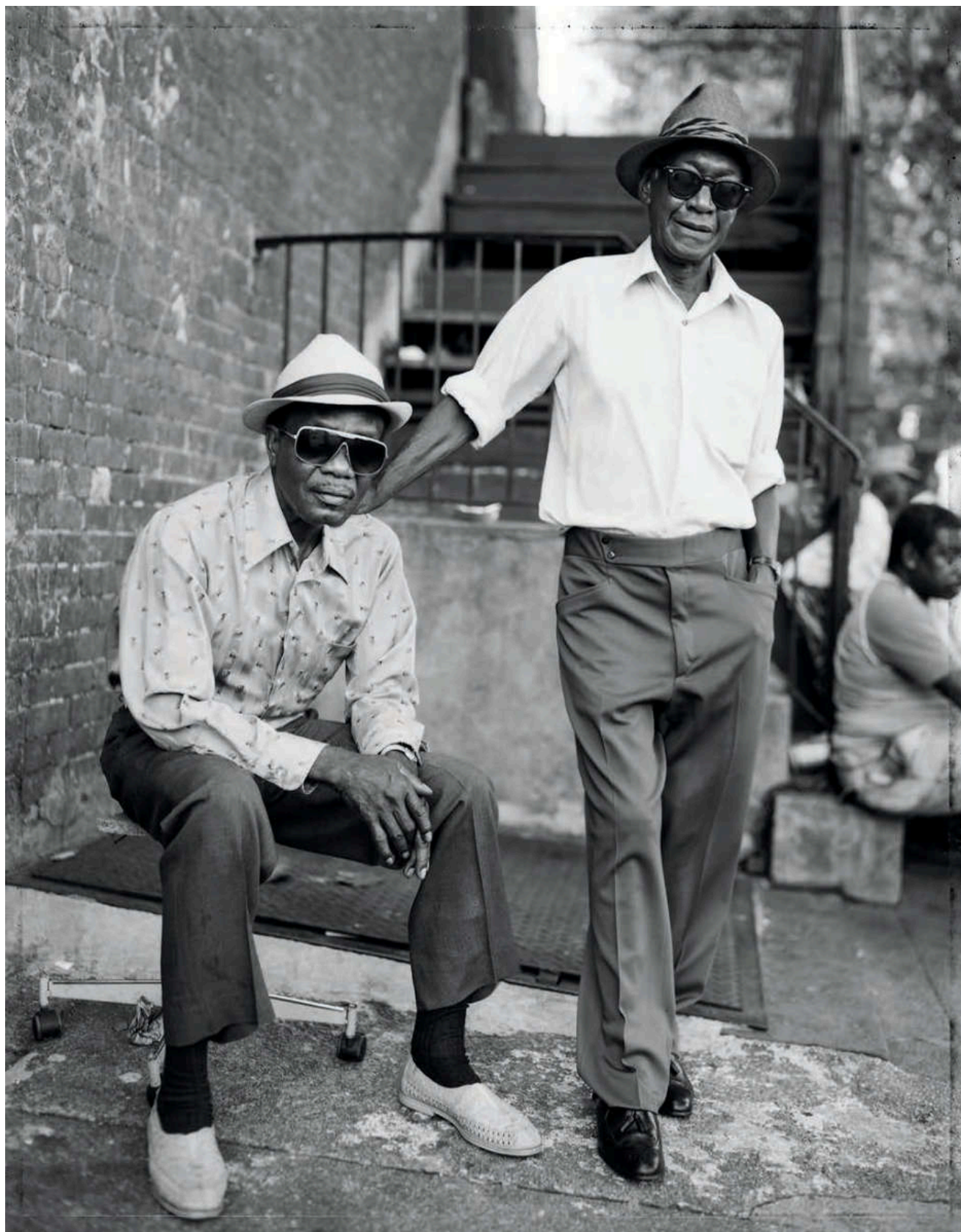
“They’re very American photographs,” Bey said. “It’s about placing Black people within that larger American landscape, within the physical landscape, within the geographical landscape.”

“The whole point,” Bey told me, “is to amplify their presence in the world.”

— Syreeta McFadden

Clockwise from top left: *Two Girls on Willoughby Street, Brooklyn, 1989*; *Two Men at Cambridge Place and Fulton Street, Brooklyn, 1989*; *Woman Wearing Denim, Rochester, 1989*









RETURN

the

NATIONAL
PARKS

to the

TRIBES

THE JEWELS *of*
AMERICA'S
LANDSCAPE
SHOULD BELONG
TO AMERICA'S
ORIGINAL PEOPLES.

BY DAVID TREUER

Photographs by Katy Grannan

I.

The End Result of Dirty Business

IN 1851, members of a California state militia called the Mariposa Battalion became the first white men to lay eyes on Yosemite Valley. The group was largely made up of miners. They had been scouring the western slopes of the Sierra when they happened upon the granite valley that Native peoples had long referred to as “the place of a gaping mouth.” Lafayette Bunnell, a physician attached to the militia, found himself awestruck. “None but those who have visited this most wonderful valley, can even imagine the feelings with which I looked upon the view,” he later wrote. “A peculiar exalted sensation seemed to fill my whole being, and I found my eyes in tears.” Many of those who have followed in Bunnell’s footsteps over the past 170 years, walking alongside the Merced River or gazing upon the god-rock of El Capitan, have been similarly struck by the sense that they were in the presence of the divine.

The Mariposa Battalion had come to Yosemite to kill Indians. Yosemite’s Miwok tribes, like many of California’s Native peoples, were obstructing a frenzy of extraction brought on by the Gold Rush. And whatever Bunnell’s fine sentiments about nature, he made his contempt for these “overgrown, vicious children” plain:

Any attempt to govern or civilize them without the power to compel obedience, will be looked upon by barbarians with derision ... The savage is naturally vain, cruel and arrogant. He boasts of his murders and robberies, and the tortures of his victims very much in the same manner that he recounts his deeds of valor in battle.

When the roughly 200 men of the Mariposa Battalion marched into Yosemite, armed with rifles, they did not find the Miwok eager for battle. While the Miwok hid, the militiamen sought to starve them into submission by burning their food stores, souring the valley’s air with the smell of scorched acorns. On one particularly bloody day, some of the men came upon an inhabited village outside the valley, surprising the Miwok there. They used embers from the tribe’s own campfires to set the wigwams aflame and shot at the villagers indiscriminately as they fled, murdering 23 of them. By the time the militia’s campaign ended, many of the Miwok who survived had been driven from Yosemite, their homeland for millennia, and forced onto reservations.

Thirty-nine years later, Yosemite became the fifth national park. (Yellowstone, which was granted that status in 1872, was the first.) The parks were intended to be natural cathedrals: protected landscapes where people could worship the sublime. They offer Americans the thrill of looking back over their shoulder at a world without humans or technology. Many visit them to find something that exists outside or beyond us, to experience an awesome sense of scale, to contemplate our smallness and our

ephemerality. It was for this reason that John Muir, the father of modern conservationism, advocated for the parks’ creation.

More than a century ago, in the pages of this magazine, Muir described the entire American continent as a wild garden “favored above all the other wild parks and gardens of the globe.” But in truth, the North American continent has not been a wilderness for at least 15,000 years: Many of the landscapes that became national parks had been shaped by Native peoples for millennia. Forests on the Eastern Seaboard looked plentiful to white settlers because American Indians had strategically burned them to increase the amount of forage for moose and deer and woodland caribou. Yosemite Valley’s sublime landscape was likewise tended by Native peoples; the acorns that fed the Miwok came from black oaks long cultivated by the tribe. The idea of a virgin American wilderness—an Eden untouched by humans and devoid of sin—is an illusion.

The national parks are sometimes called “America’s best idea,” and there is much to recommend them. They are indeed awesome places, worthy of reverence and preservation, as Native Americans like me would be the first to tell you. But all of them were founded on land that was once ours, and many were created only after we were removed, forcibly, sometimes by an invading army and other times following a treaty we’d signed under duress. When describing the simultaneous creation of the parks and Native American reservations, the Oglala Lakota spiritual leader Black Elk noted darkly that the United States “made little islands for us and other little islands for the four-leggeds, and always these islands are becoming smaller.”

Many of the negotiations that enabled the creation of these islands took place in English (to the disadvantage of the tribes), when the tribes faced annihilation or had been weakened by disease or starvation (to the disadvantage of the tribes), or with bad faith on the part of the government (to the disadvantage of the tribes). The treaties that resulted, according to the U.S. Constitution, are the “supreme Law of the Land.” Yet even despite their cruel terms, few were honored. Native American claims and rights were ignored or chipped away.

The American story of “the Indian” is one of staggering loss. Some estimates put the original Indigenous population of what would become the contiguous United States between 5 million and 15 million at the time of first contact. By 1890, around the time America began creating national parks in earnest, roughly 250,000 Native people were still alive. In 1491, Native people controlled all of the 2.4 billion acres that would become the United States. Now we control about 56 million acres, or roughly 2 percent.

And yet we remain, and some of us have stayed stubbornly near the parks, preserving our attachment to them. Grand Canyon National Park encloses much of the Havasupai Tribe and its reservation. Pipe Spring National Monument sits entirely inside the 120,000-acre Kaibab Paiute Indian Reservation, in northern Arizona. Many other parks neighbor Native communities. But while the parks may be near us, and of us, they are not ours.

We live in a time of historical reconsideration, as more and more people recognize that the sins of the past still haunt the



Previous spread: *Four generations of the women of the Schildt family at a sacred medicine rock on their property on the Blackfeet Reservation, with Glacier National Park in the background.* This page, top: *A memorial obelisk at Camp Disappointment, on the Blackfeet Reservation, so named by the Lewis and Clark Expedition when it reached its northernmost point.* Bottom: *Pat Schildt on his bison ranch on the Blackfeet Reservation.*

present. For Native Americans, there can be no better remedy for the theft of land than land. And for us, no lands are as spiritually significant as the national parks. They should be returned to us. Indians should tend—and protect and preserve—these favored gardens again.

IN JULY 2020, I conducted something of a barnstorming tour. I wanted to look with fresh eyes at the park system, to imagine a new future for it. I had planned on visiting all sorts of places—the

The photographs that accompany this article are portraits of members of the Blackfeet Nation and the lands around them. They were taken on the Blackfeet Reservation and in Glacier National Park, in Montana, over two weeks in March. The Blackfeet's homelands once encompassed part of the Rocky Mountains and what became the park, before the tribe was dispossessed of its land. Many of America's national parks were once home to Native American tribes that have since been evicted by force or dishonest dealing.

Grand Canyon, Yosemite, Great Smoky Mountains National Park—but the coronavirus pandemic intervened.

Some parks closed completely, while others (like Yellowstone) closed campgrounds, cultural centers, and museums. In the end I drove from Minnesota through North Dakota, Montana, Wyoming, Idaho, and Oregon and down the spine of California. Then I turned around and drove back. I visited Theodore Roosevelt National Park, Little Bighorn Battlefield, Yellowstone, Grand Teton, Mount Hood National Forest, Kings Canyon, Death Valley, and Joshua Tree.

The roads were quieter than usual, though the skies were sometimes hazy as the West Coast burst into flames. I slept in campgrounds, in my tent in the backyards of friends, and, rarely, in a hotel or motor lodge. I cooked on the trunk of my car and on picnic tables, under the blazing sun and in torrential rain. I fought off raccoons and squirrels.

More than any other place I visited, Yellowstone seemed to contain the multitudes of America. There, I saw elk and bison. I saw enough recreational vehicles to house a good portion of this country's homeless. I saw lake water, river water, black water, swamp water, and frothy waterfall water. I saw Tony Hawk being stopped by two park rangers after

longboarding down the switchbacks above Mammoth Hot Springs while an actual hawk circled above him. I saw Instagram models in tiny bikinis posing in front of indifferent bison. I saw biker gangs (who seem to really enjoy parks) and gangs of toddlers (who don't seem to enjoy anything). I saw tourists, masked and unmasked. I saw placards and displays. I discovered that you can learn a lot about nature at Yellowstone, and perhaps even more about American culture. But the park's official captions give you at best a limited sense of its human history.

Yellowstone National Park was created about 100 years after the country was born. An 1806 expedition, part of Lewis and Clark's Corps of Discovery, passed just north of where the park is today. Later, John Colter, one of the Corps members, joined the fur trade and purportedly became the first non-Native to see its vistas. Of course, Native people had lived there for thousands of years, and at the time Colter was setting traps in the area, they still claimed Yellowstone as their home.

Colter traveled through the Yellowstone area and the Teton Range in the early 19th century, looking for fur. Wherever he went, he ended up in mortal conflict with Native Americans, culminating in his wounding at the hands of the Blackfeet. He hid from the tribe under a pile of driftwood and then walked for a week to safety. Over the next 60 years, trappers like him described the landscape that would become Yellowstone as an area of mud geysers, acid pools, and petrified trees.

Not until 1869 did the first official expedition explore the region and confirm the mountain men's accounts. Things moved quickly after that. In 1871, Ferdinand V. Hayden led a government-sponsored survey of Yellowstone that produced reports complete with professional sketches and photographs. Based on that report, President Ulysses S. Grant signed into law the Yellowstone Act of 1872, which created America's first landscape to be "reserved and withdrawn from settlement, occupancy, or sale ... and dedicated and set apart as a public park or pleasuring-ground for the benefit and enjoyment of the people."

Grant's declaration made trespassers of the Shoshone, Bannock, and other peoples who had called the parkland home for centuries. The tribes left with the understanding that they would retain hunting rights in the park, as guaranteed by an 1868 treaty. Before the century was out, however, the government had reneged on that promise. This tactic of theft by broken treaty would become a pattern where parks were concerned.

When Yellowstone was established, the Plains Wars were raging all around the park's borders. It was as though the government paused mid-murder



Red Cloud (seated, center) and other Native American leaders visited President Ulysses S. Grant in 1875, but failed to persuade him to honor existing treaties.



Chief Joseph of the Nez Perce, circa 1900



Geronimo at the St. Louis World's Fair, in 1904



George Gillette (left), the chairman of the Fort Berthold Indian Tribal Business Council, weeps as more than 150,000 acres of the Fort Berthold Reservation in North Dakota are signed away for the Garrison Dam and Reservoir project.

to plant a tree in the victims' backyard. The Dakota War had erupted 10 years earlier, just east of the Great Plains. By the time it was over, dozens of Dakota had been hanged, and more than 1,600 women, children, and elders had been sent to a concentration camp at Fort Snelling. Eventually, all of the treaties between the Eastern Dakota and the U.S. government were "abrogated and annulled."

In 1864, on the Plains' opposite edge, at Sand Creek in Colorado Territory, Colonel John Chivington massacred and mutilated as many as 500 Native Americans. In 1868, just four years before the creation of Yellowstone, Native Americans, led by Red Cloud, fought the U.S. government to a standstill, then forced concessions from the Americans at the treaty table, though these, too, were eventually unmade.

War came to Yellowstone itself in 1877. Chief Joseph's band of Nez Perce had been shut out of their homeland in the Wallowa Valley and embarked on a 1,500-mile journey that would end just south of the Canadian border, where they would surrender to the U.S. Army. The Nez Perce did their best to avoid white people on their way. But they were attacked on the banks of the Big Hole River, in August 1877, by soldiers in Colonel John Gibbon's command. Gibbon's men approached the camp on foot at dawn, killing a man during their advance. Then they began firing into the tepees of the sleeping Nez Perce, killing men, women, and children. The Nez Perce counterattacked. Their warriors kept Gibbon's soldiers pinned down while the others escaped. Although they defended themselves well, they lost at least 60 people.

Reeling from these deaths, the Nez Perce passed into Yellowstone, where they ran into tourists from Radersburg, Montana, enjoying the "pleasuring-ground" created at the expense of Indians. The Nez Perce briefly held the tourists hostage, and then released them, but went on to kill two tourists in the park later in the month.

Moving east through the park, the tribe forded the Yellowstone River at a place still known as the Nez Perce Ford. Around the time they crossed the river, an elderly woman peeled away from the main column and stayed at an area known as Mud Volcano. She sat on a bison robe near a geyser and sang. When a U.S. scout approached her, she closed her eyes. "She seemed rather disappointed," John W. Redington, the scout, wrote, "when instead of shooting her I refilled her water bottle. She made signs that she had been forsaken by her people, and wanted to die." Ten minutes later, a Bannock scout for the Army obliged by striking her down and scalping her. One hundred and forty-three years later, my sons and daughter and I would stand on the same spot, wondering why there are so few places in the park where you can

learn about its bloody past. Viewed from the perspective of history, Yellowstone is a crime scene.

AMERICA'S NATIONAL PARKS comprise only a small fraction of the land stolen from Native Americans, but they loom large in the broader story of our dispossession. Most of the major national parks are in the western United States. So, too, are most Native American tribes, owing to the Indian Removal Act of 1830, which attempted to eject all tribes east of the Mississippi to what was then Indian Territory. The reservation period likewise began, for the most part, in the West, in the mid-19th century.

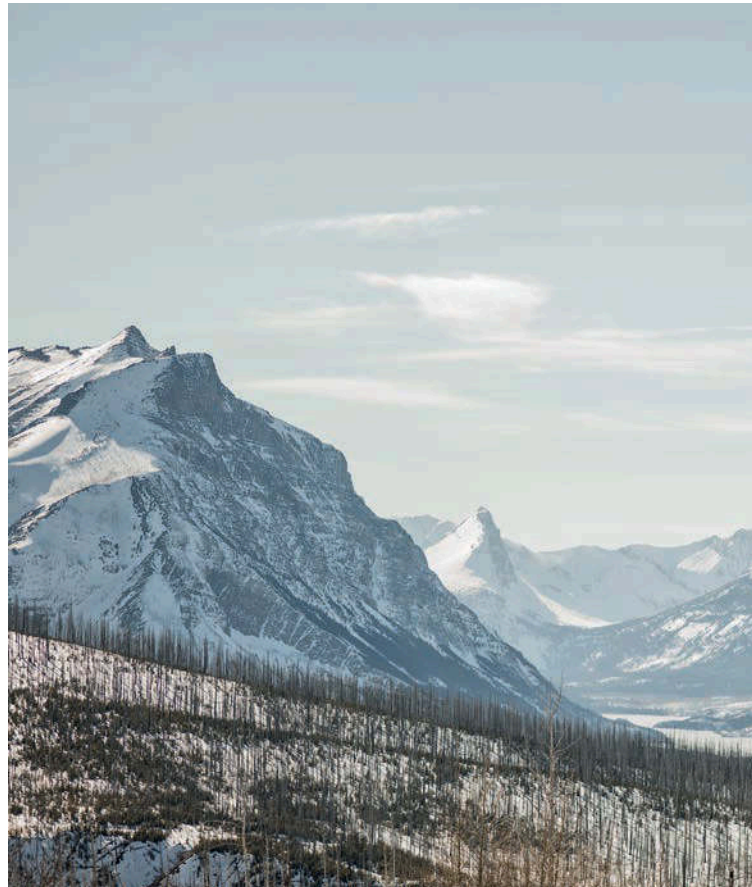
Even after we were relegated to reservations, the betrayals continued. Beginning in 1887, the Dawes Act (also known as the General Allotment Act) split much of the reservations up into small parcels of land to be granted to individual Indians, while the "surplus" communal land was opened for white settlement. In blunt terms, Thomas Morgan, the commissioner of Indian affairs, said in 1890 that the goal of federal policy at the time was "to break up reservations, destroy tribal relations, settle Indians upon their own homesteads, incorporate them into the national life, and deal with them not as nations or tribes or bands, but as individual citizens." This land grab bled at least another 90 million acres away from the tribes—roughly equivalent to the 85 million acres that comprise America's 423 national-park sites.

After Yellowstone was established and Indians were removed and in some cases excluded from its spaces, the same—and worse—happened elsewhere. The Blackfeet, living in three bands in northwestern Montana and southern Alberta, had long thought of the Rockies as their spiritual and physical homeland. They wouldn't have dreamt of ceding it at the treaty table,

but in the 1880s and '90s, they were forced to negotiate with the U.S. government. Weakened by a string of epidemics, seasons of starvation, and insatiable Americans bent on opening up their homelands to timber and mineral extraction, the Blackfeet had to make concession after concession. Some years, they had to give up land just to secure enough resources to last through the next winter.

Not long after a harsh winter that killed as many as 600 Blackfeet, the tribe signed away land that would become Glacier National Park. The deal was brokered by George Bird Grinnell, the naturalist founder of the Audubon Society of New York. Grinnell had joined George Armstrong Custer on his expedition into the Black Hills in 1874 in search of gold. The trip was in direct violation of the treaty guaranteeing that the Black Hills would remain in Native control. Grinnell was often called

VIEWED
FROM THE
PERSPECTIVE
OF HISTORY,
YELLOWSTONE
IS A CRIME
SCENE.



a “friend of the Indian,” but he once wrote that Natives have “the mind of a child in the body of an adult.” In 1911, a year after Congress approved the creation of Glacier, Montana ceded jurisdiction of the park to the U.S. government.

So many of the parks owe their existence to heists like these. Apostle Islands National Lakeshore, in Wisconsin, was created out of Ojibwe homelands; the Havasupai lost much of their land when Grand Canyon National Park was established; the creation of Olympic National Park, in Washington, prevented Quinault tribal members from exercising their treaty rights within its boundaries; and Everglades National Park was created on Seminole land that the tribe depended on for food. The list goes on.

I SET OUT on my trip through America’s national parks from my home, at Leech Lake Reservation, in Minnesota, on the southern fringe of the North American boreal forest. This forest is one of the largest stretches of woodland in the world: It spreads from the Aleutian Islands all the way to Newfoundland and from near the southern edge of Hudson Bay to northern Minnesota, Wisconsin, and Michigan. As I headed west for Theodore Roosevelt National Park, in North Dakota, the taiga gave way to grasslands and oak savanna near Detroit Lakes, Minnesota. By the time I crossed the Red River, I’d left the forest behind altogether. I felt the land dip, and looking west, I thought I could make out the horizon where the Great Plains begin.

As a boy, I would accompany my father on business trips through some of these same landscapes. In the car, he would narrate the history of our region, mostly without much emotional inflection: “Chief Little Crow fled this way to escape the military after the Dakota War in 1862.” We would pass many small towns—Hawley, Valley City, Medina, Steele—that seemed pleasant enough, until my father ruined them for me. The calm and order of them, their small houses and neatly kept yards, the Protestant ethic reflected in their organization—all of it infuriates me, because every single one of those towns exists at our expense.

Medora, North Dakota, is the southern gateway to Theodore Roosevelt National Park. (The Marquis de Morès named the town after his wife, Medora von Hoffman, though the romance of the gesture suffers when you consider that he established the town as a place to slaughter cattle to be sold at eastern markets.) Medora today is a fantasy of a time that never was. There is a statue of Roosevelt and a Rough Riders Hotel and, during the summer months, the Medora Musical. The show’s website really says it best when it promises “the rootin’-tootinest, boot-scootinest show in all the Midwest. There’s no other show quite like it. It’s an ode to patriotism, Theodore Roosevelt, and the Great American West!” When I was there it was an ode to COVID-19: According to a clerk at the convenience store, one of the cast members was spreading the virus from the stage.

I wanted to begin my journey at Theodore Roosevelt because no one embodies the tensions of the park system as it is currently



Left: Doug Fitzgerald on his grandfather's ranch on the Blackfeet Reservation. Center: Saint Mary Lake and surrounding mountains inside Glacier National Park. Right: Simarron Schildt, with her 3-year-old daughter, Rosie Robertson, on her family's property on the Blackfeet Reservation.



constituted like the 26th president. Contained in the person of Roosevelt was a wild love for natural vistas and a propensity for violent imperialism; an overwhelming desire for freedom and a readiness to take it away from other people. Much of the park named after him exists on top of Mandan, Hidatsa, and Arikara (MHA) land. The MHA lost that land in 1851, with the signing of the first Treaty of Fort Laramie. Executive orders in 1870 and 1880 seized still more of the tribes' homeland.

Roosevelt went to hunt bison in Dakota Territory in 1883. In 1884, when he was back home in New York, his wife gave birth to their daughter, Alice, but unbeknownst to her doctors, his wife had a kidney ailment, and died on Valentine's Day that year. Teddy's mother died the same day in the same house. After drawing a large X in his diary, Roosevelt wrote, "The light has gone out of my life." He returned to the West and built a ranch outside Medora, intent on letting nature soothe him. He didn't last long out there, and the West never became his permanent home, but it left a mark on him—and he, in turn, left his mark on it.

Roosevelt was familiar with Native Americans, having interacted with them when he was in Dakota Territory. "The

most vicious cowboy has more moral principle than the average Indian," he would say in an 1886 speech, during which he also famously declared: "I don't go so far as to think that the only good Indians are the dead Indians, but I believe nine out of every 10 are, and I shouldn't like to inquire too closely into the case of the tenth."

Roosevelt's attitude toward Indians is manifest in his treatment of the Apache leader Geronimo. Born in 1829, Geronimo lived the first three decades of his life in the peace and security of his Apache homelands, in what is now New Mexico and Arizona. In the second half of the 19th century, he rose to international fame for fighting the American and Mexican governments in an attempt to preserve his tribe's piece of the Southwest.

In 1858—the year of Roosevelt's birth—Geronimo joined a large trading party that left the Mogollon Mountains and entered Mexico. While he was in town conducting business, his band was attacked and slaughtered at camp. Among the dead were Geronimo's wife, mother, and three small children. He later recalled, "I did not pray, nor did I resolve to do anything in particular, for I had no purpose left." Life, for him, as recounted by Gilbert King in *Smithsonian* magazine, shaded from peace into a state of perpetual warfare, ending only with his capture by U.S. forces in 1886, around the time Roosevelt was mourning in Dakota Territory.

Geronimo was shipped east and spent the rest of his life in captivity, and his tribe's land was whittled away. Around the

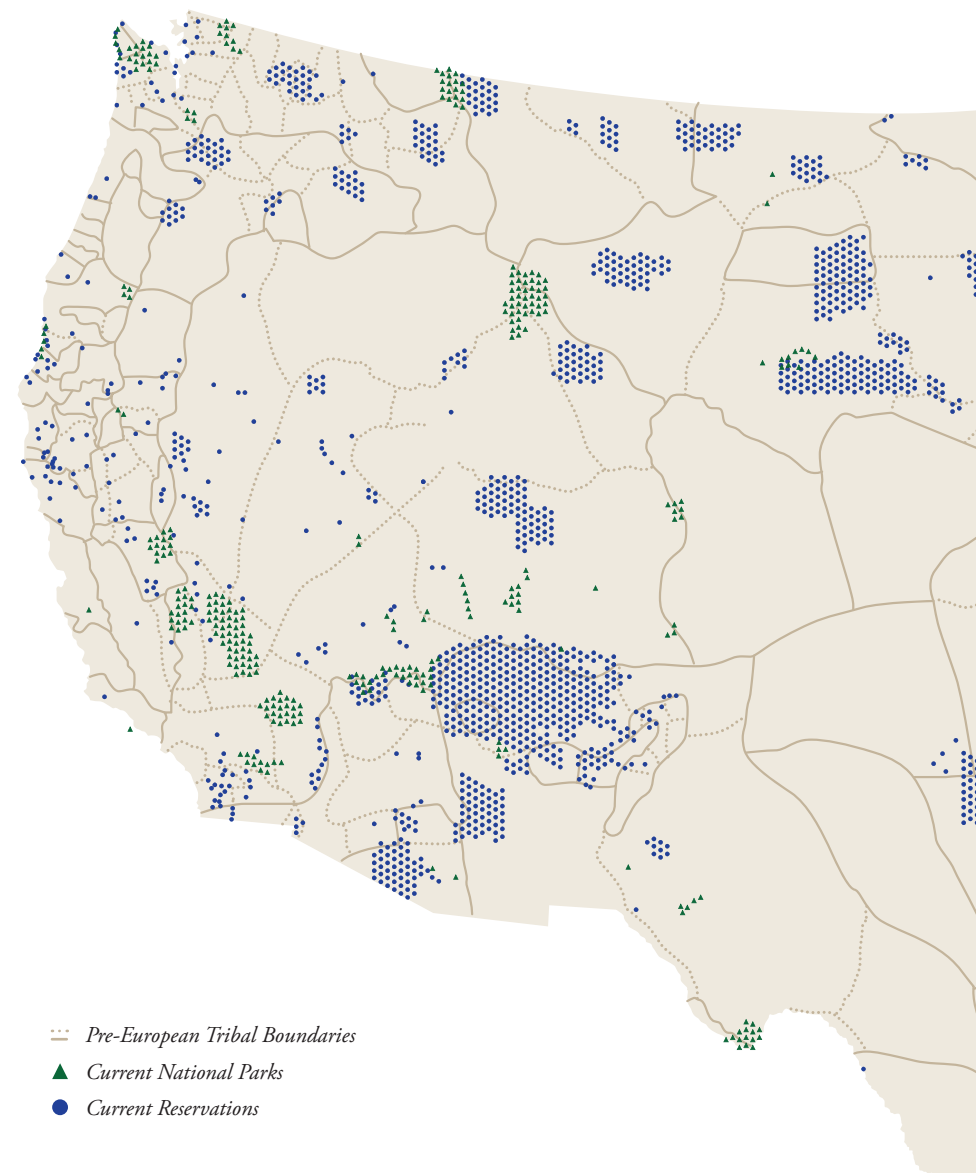
same time, Native children were also being shipped away from their homelands, to government-sponsored boarding schools—removed from their families and their culture so as to mainstream them. Attendance was sometimes mandated by law and sometimes coerced, but it was rarely strictly voluntary. For speaking in their own language, the children were sometimes beaten or had soap put in their mouths. Of the 112 Apache children from Geronimo's band sent to the Carlisle Indian Industrial School, in Pennsylvania, 36 died—most of them likely from tuberculosis—and were buried there.

For his part, Geronimo did get out (under guard) once in a while, including a stint in 1904 as part of the “Apache Village” at the St. Louis World's Fair, where he was made to play the role of the savage. In 1905, he and other Native leaders were asked to be part of Roosevelt's inaugural parade. It was a who's who of tribal leadership, including Quanah Parker (Comanche), Buckskin Charlie (Ute), Hollow Horn Bear (Brulé Lakota), American Horse (Oglala Lakota), and Little Plume (Piegan Blackfeet). They rode horses down Pennsylvania Avenue in regalia not entirely in step with their individual tribal traditions. America liked and still likes its Indians to function much like its nature: frozen in time; outside history; the antithesis, or at best the outer limit, of humanity and civilization.

Geronimo met with Roosevelt afterward. “Take the ropes from our hands,” he begged, in a desperate appeal to be allowed to return, along with other Apache prisoners, to his homeland. Roosevelt declined, telling him, “You killed many of my people; you burned villages.” Geronimo began to gesture and yell but was cut off. Four years later, he died in captivity at Fort Sill, Oklahoma.

In 1903, Roosevelt had let himself be drawn back west. In April of that year he embarked on a 14,000-mile train journey that took him through 24 states and territories in nine weeks. He traveled to Yellowstone, the Grand Canyon, and California, where he enjoyed a three-night camping trip with John Muir.

Along the way, Roosevelt gave speeches—at the Grand Canyon; at



Instead of describing one moment in time (for example, “Here’s what tribal boundaries looked like before Columbus reached America”), this map approximates the tribal boundaries that European settlers recorded as they traveled through the frontier—the western half of the map describes a later period than the eastern half does.

Yellowstone, where he laid the cornerstone for the Roosevelt Arch; near some redwoods in Santa Cruz. He said much about the majesty of nature. Regarding the Grand Canyon: “I want to ask you to do one thing in connection with it in your own interest and in the interest of the country—to keep this great wonder of nature as it now is ... I hope you will not have a building of any kind, not a summer cottage, a hotel or anything else, to mar the wonderful grandeur, the sublimity, the great loneliness and beauty of the canyon.” And Yellowstone: “The Yellowstone Park is something absolutely unique in the world, so far as I know ... The scheme of its preservation is noteworthy in its essential democracy ... This Park was created, and is now administered, for the benefit and enjoyment of the people.”

A. L. KROEBER, CULTURAL AND NATURAL AREAS OF NATIVE NORTH AMERICA; ENCYCLOPEDIA BRITANNICA; BUREAU OF INDIAN AFFAIRS

II.

The Future of the Tribes and the Parks

THE MHA NATION lives just north and a little east of Theodore Roosevelt National Park, but under drastically different circumstances than the people in and around Medora. Time and again, the MHA reservation was reduced by federal fiat and exploitative deals—from more than 12 million acres to less than 1 million. The dispossessions continued well into the 20th century: During construction of the Garrison Dam and Reservoir on the Missouri River in the 1940s and '50s, up to 80 percent of the reservation population was forced to relocate away from the fertile river bottoms that had given them life and defined them as a people for centuries.

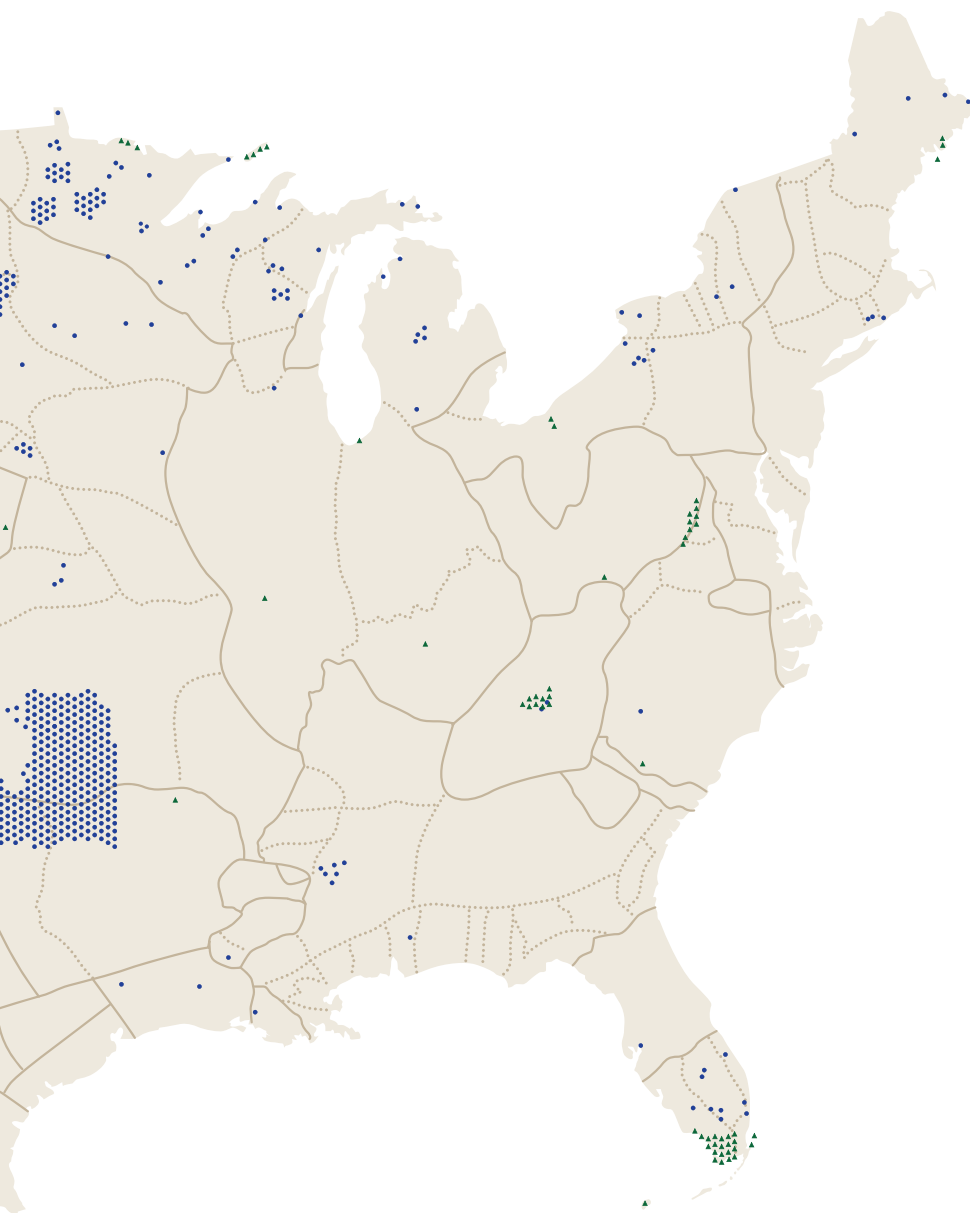
In the 1860s, long before the dam was built, the MHA had lived mostly at a place called Like-a-Fishhook Village, Royce Young Wolf, the collections manager at a new cultural center the MHA are building, told me. “It’s all under the lake now, flooded out,” she said. We were standing at Oxbow Overlook inside the park, looking down at the Little Missouri River as it wound lazily through acres of cottonwood and grassy clearings. “They were self-sufficient,” she said. “Each village had its own garden. Many families had sacred bundle-keepers.” The dam was planned without any meaningful consultation of the MHA Nation; after the Army Corps of Engineers threatened to confiscate the land it needed, citing eminent domain, the tribes had little choice but to come to the negotiating table and eventually cede territory. By 1949, they had received settlements totaling only \$12.6 million for the more than 150,000 acres that were taken.

“They moved us from where water was plentiful to where there wasn’t any,” Young Wolf said. “Our river bottoms were the most fertile in the whole state ... But when we were flooded, we were moved to areas where there’s poor soil and no water and we couldn’t sustain

Roosevelt translated his passions into policy. During his time in office, he created 150 national forests, 18 national monuments, five national parks, four national game preserves, and 51 bird “reservations.”

Like Geronimo, Roosevelt came of age during a pivotal 50-year stretch when the contiguous United States assumed its final dimensions. The last major armed conflict between a Native tribe and the U.S. government ended at Wounded Knee Creek with the massacre of as many as 300 men, women, and children of Spotted Elk’s band of Miniconjou. The frontier was pushed all the way to the Pacific and then was no more, and America’s truly wild space—land outside the embrace of “civilization”—was subsumed.

The American West began with war but concluded with parks.



large gardens.” The tribes’ rights to use the land on the reservoir’s shoreline—for hunting or fishing or plant-gathering—were denied.

In recent years, the MHA have been in the grip of rapid, violent, and remunerative fracking enterprises. As I drove north from the park, I saw land bearing scars—pipes, gas vents, and fracking pads dotting the hills. In 2014, the former tribal chair Tex Hall promised the tribes “sovereignty by the barrel,” and he wasn’t wrong: The tribes are wealthier than they have been since before the first Treaty of Fort Laramie. But by encouraging and facilitating oil extraction, they put themselves at odds with their own cultural legacy and connection to the land.

Native American nations such as the MHA are in a difficult position. They have endured state-sponsored assaults on their families, communities, land, and ways of life. Their traditional political structures and institutions have suffered under the paternalism of the Bureau of Indian Affairs, which controls Native land by holding it in trust.

On one hand, we are sovereign nations with our own laws and law enforcement, courts, and municipal infrastructures, all derived from those rights that we have managed to retain. Contrary to popular myth, neither casinos nor the right to gamble were “given” to tribes as a kind of pity payment or as the recognition of a debt owed us. The casino industry is the modern expression of a civil right to gamble that we had before white people came along, a right we have retained and that was affirmed by the Supreme Court.

On the other hand, without a strong tax base or much commerce—extractive industries, casino gambling, and tax-free cigarette sales are notable exceptions—we are dependent on federal support for education, health care, infrastructure, and our continued survival. We are, in the words of Chief Justice John Marshall, “domestic dependent nations,” and thus live in constant tension.

The MHA have had their struggles—with unemployment, substance abuse, a destructive marriage to the oil-and-gas industry, and intergenerational trauma inflicted by the U.S. government. But tribes are much more than the sum of their troubles. The MHA are also keenly protective of their heritage and culture. The cultural center they are constructing is a state-of-the-art facility in service to these ideals.

The MHA Interpretive Center is on Army Corps of Engineers land because that land is near the river, which is so essential to MHA history, Delphine Baker, the director of the Interpretive Center, told me. She was instantly recognizable to me as a kind of fierce, no-nonsense Native auntie. Government officials didn’t want the tribes to own that land, she said matter-of-factly—the tribes now hold a lease instead—out of a concern that the tribes would take control of recreation rights and not allow nontribal

members to have access. “The tribe never is interested in blocking access. But, you know, that’s a fear.”

The facility is gorgeous—swooping embankments and curving walks mirror the rolling hills and grasslands of the MHA tribal area. Inside is a partial replica of an earth lodge, the traditional dwelling of the three tribes, and gallery space that tells the story of the MHA. The Interpretive Center will be the home for hundreds, if not thousands, of artifacts taken from the tribes over the years. And it will not be merely a show-and-tell kind of endeavor. The center will cultivate traditional plants on a rooftop garden. A café will serve traditional foods. There is a recording studio for preserving tribal languages, and a research space where tribal members will be able to trace their lineage. For so many Native people who have been separated from their tribes because of federal meddling, reconnecting is an important

service the center can provide. To call this an Interpretive Center isn’t quite right. It is more like a cultural mothership.

“If you lose your culture, you lose your sovereignty and your tribe,” Baker told me. “And that’s what we’re fighting against.”

It is not the first such fight. During the early reservation period, a difficult and fractious time when the people at Like-a-Fishhook Village were trying to figure out a new way of living, a splinter group wanted to hunt and garden in the old communal ways. So they left, relocating outside the reservation, about 120 miles upriver. “That group became known as the Xoshga, and they were led by Crow Flies High and Bobtail Bull,” Young Wolf told me. “When they separated, they were taking a stand against assimilation and Christianity. They stayed away for over 20 years.” They revived ceremonies and songs and dances. They preserved knowledge of local plants. While they were gone, Young Wolf said, the community at Like-a-Fishhook Village suffered from being split apart into small plots of land.

But the Xoshga “kept our traditions safe while they were away. And it’s because of them we have many of our traditions today.”

In 1894, the government forced the Xoshga back to the reservation. They were treated badly at first by many of the MHA members who had stayed behind, Young Wolf told me. They were looked at as backward and savage. But now, to be Xoshga is to be connected to the land, to tradition, and to a spirit of resistance. The Xoshga were saved by the land, and their return to it saved their tribe.

THE AMERICAN WEST BEGAN WITH WAR BUT CONCLUDED WITH PARKS.

Opposite page: *Evan Thompson grew up on the Blackfeet Reservation. An attorney, he works on issues of tribal sovereignty, civil litigation, and general tribal advocacy throughout the Northwest.*



THE FIRST “PARK PERSON” I met on my trip was Grant Geis, then the chief ranger at Theodore Roosevelt National Park (he has since retired). Geis is tall and broad-shouldered, with a rugged face and large, strong hands. He’d been at the park since 1998, when he started as a seasonal employee. “As soon as I hit Painted Canyon ... I fell in love with it,” he told me, “and [I’ve] kind of been here ever since.”

Pretty much every person I talked with in the Park Service used the word *love* to describe the parks, the vistas, and their own roles as protectors of the land and its visitors. In my experience, that’s not a word most government employees use when talking about their job. I asked Geis about Teddy Roosevelt and his legacy. “He was a firm believer in the land of many uses, but at the same time trying to save something for future generations,” Geis replied. “It says something about his character when he was forward-thinking to that degree.” He also acknowledged Roosevelt’s imperfections and expressed support for cooperative relationships between parks and adjacent tribes.

The personal failings of people like Roosevelt are still codified in American policy. A lack of access to land—and the lack of power that such access would confer—undergirds the social ills that affect many Native peoples. But, at least in some places, American attitudes are changing. And in the parks, policies are changing too, albeit slowly, and in piecemeal fashion.

When I was a kid and my parents took my two siblings and me on our first trip out West, in the early ’80s, we stopped at Theodore Roosevelt, Custer Battlefield (now Little Bighorn), Yellowstone, and Grand Teton. Indians were barely mentioned on the signage, and I don’t remember meeting any Native rangers or even sensing that we existed as anything other than America’s past tense. But since the passage of the Native American Graves Protection and Repatriation Act, in 1990, tribes and parks (not to



mention museums, galleries, and private collections) have drawn closer together in their efforts to preserve Native spaces and objects. Many tribes now have historic-preservation officers, who work with the parks.

Land use itself is also changing within the parks, to some degree. For instance, the Park Service has made it easier for Native people to harvest plants for traditional purposes, though typically they first have to submit a written request. And some parks allow us to hunt or trap within their borders.

In some respects, ours is an era of Native resurgence. For all we have suffered, there remain 574 federally recognized

Top: Jade-Heather Hinman, a local small-business owner, pictured with five of her seven children in the sweetgrass hills at Camp Disappointment.

Bottom, left to right: Rick Rattler, a champion bronc rider and trainer, and his cousins Ty Rattler and Beau Spottedeagle saddling their horses on their family ranch on the reservation.

tribes in the United States. When the first national parks were created at the end of the 19th century, only about 250,000 Native people were left in the U.S. Now there are more than 5 million Native Americans throughout the country, roughly equal to the number of Jewish Americans and millions more than the number of Muslim Americans.

Our survival hasn't mattered only to us: As the efforts to assimilate us largely failed and we remained, mostly, in our homelands, Americans have gradually assimilated to *our* cultures, *our* worldview, and *our* modes of connecting to nature. The parks enshrine places, but they also emphasize and prioritize a particular way of interacting with the land. In the nation's mythic past, the wilderness may have been a dangerous environment, something to be tamed, plowed under, cut down. But that way of relating to the land is no longer in vogue. For many Americans, our wild spaces are a solace, a refuge—cathedrals indeed. America has succeeded in becoming more Indian over the past 245 years rather than the other way around.

IT TOOK ME a few days to hike the South Unit of Theodore Roosevelt. Unlike more congested parks such as Yellowstone and Yosemite, Roosevelt is quiet, so much so that it feels like a secret. I started in high, red, dusty hills, and descended through a series of washes and dry river bottoms. I keenly felt how far back in time I was traveling with each step. The trail rose past the petrified tree stumps of a swamp millions of years old and out onto a grassy plain, where the wind screamed through the grass, echinacea, aster, and goldenrod. I passed near cliffs where the tribes might once have funneled stampeding bison, causing them to fall to the hard earth below.

The day after I finished my hike, I had breakfast with Wendy Ross, the park superintendent, in Theodore's Dining Room at the Rough Riders Hotel. I asked her whether Native people should be able to use the park differently than non-Natives, considering our longer tenure on the land, which had originally been part of the MHA's tribal homeland. Why, I asked, couldn't the MHA hunt the bison in the park? Ross said it was something of a slippery slope. If the park allowed Native people to hunt bison, the rest of the residents of North Dakota would throw a fit and, more troubling, the efforts of hunting groups to open up parks across the country to sport hunting would be greatly encouraged.

"The problem," Ross said, is that "there are no protocols" nationally, and hence there's much confusion. "Here at Roosevelt, I've told all of my staff: We let anybody in who says they're coming in for ceremonial or spiritual purposes." I have no doubt this

is true. Ross seems to be a good leader and an ally to the tribes who live near Roosevelt. She spoke of reparations, of "providing what you can to people who used to use that area all the time, and then expanding that to other Native peoples." She has been attending tribal meetings. Superintendents like Ross are changing the parks to better meet the needs of Native nations, but they can do only so much. So far, reparations are partial, ad hoc, and tenuous—always subject to reversal.

Native people need permanent, unencumbered access to our homelands—in order to strengthen us and our communities, and to undo some of the damage of the preceding centuries. Being Native is not so much a disposition or having a certain amount of blood running through one's veins as it is a practice around which families and tribes are built. For a member of the Shoshone-Bannock Tribes, buying a bison burger at Whole Foods might satisfy their caloric needs, but being able to hunt and harvest bison, in keeping with their spiritual and cultural practices, feeds their culture and community. Native life was diminished when our land disappeared beneath our feet, and it is further diminished when the manner in which we access "public" lands is scripted by the government.

The preservation of these sublime places for future generations is of course crucially important, something Native Americans understand as deeply as anyone. But putting aside for a moment the interests of Native Americans—and notwithstanding the hard work and goodwill of many park employees—the parks show worrying signs of mismanagement. Myopic decisions have seemed to proliferate, and some protected natural spaces have become political footballs. Bears Ears National Monument, in southeast-

ern Utah, was signed into being by President Barack Obama before he left office. One year later, President Donald Trump reduced Bears Ears by 85 percent, from 1.4 million acres to just over 200,000. This move left archaeological and sacred sites at the mercy of mining operations and motor vehicles. And while it is likely to be reversed by the Biden administration, possibly quite soon, it augurs poorly for the future.

Although the Department of the Interior will soon benefit from the leadership of Deb Haaland, who recently became the first Native American Cabinet secretary, it has typically lacked for innovation in recent years. As Jeff Ruch, a director of the nonprofit Public Employees for Environmental Responsibility, has written, "most parks merely 'Xerox forward' old plans, adjusting

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as they go.” Most of this is done without fresh thinking on conservation, development, and access.

National parks are withering as a result of overcrowding, habitat loss, and what Ruch calls a “science deficit.” Even as attendance has increased, park staff has been shrinking, as has the influence of scientists within the Park Service. Ruch’s assessment doesn’t make the Park Service sound like the protective arm of a powerful government safeguarding its “best idea.”

Parks, as they’ve existed for 149 years, have done a decent job of preserving the past. But it’s not clear that today’s model of care and custodianship best meets the needs of the land, Native people, or the general public. Nor is it clear that the current system will adequately ensure the parks’ future. That’s something Indians are good at: pushing ahead while bringing the past along with us. We may be able to chart a better way forward.

ALL 85 MILLION ACRES of national-park sites should be turned over to a consortium of federally recognized tribes in the United States. (A few areas run by the National Park Service, such as the National Mall, would be excepted.) The total acreage would not quite make up for the General Allotment Act, which robbed us of 90 million acres, but it would ensure that we have unfettered access to our tribal homelands. And it would restore dignity that was rightfully ours. To be entrusted with the stewardship of America’s most precious landscapes would be a deeply meaningful form of restitution. Alongside the feelings of awe that Americans experience

while contemplating the god-rock of Yosemite and other places like it, we could take inspiration in having done right by one another.

Placing these lands under collective Native control would be good not just for Natives, but for the parks as well. In addition to our deep and abiding reverence for wild spaces, tribes have a long history of administering to widely dispersed holdings and dealing with layers of bureaucracy. Many reservations are checkerboarded: Large parcels of reservation land are scattered and separated from one another. And much of the land within reservation boundaries is owned by a number of different interests—private, nontribal citizens; corporations; states; the federal government—that tribal leadership balances and accommodates. Through hard practice—and in the face of centuries of legal, political, and physical struggle—Indian communities have become adept at the art of governance. And tribes have a hard-earned understanding of the ways in which land empowers the people it sustains.

Transferring the parks to the tribes would protect them from partisan back-and-forth in Washington. And the transfer should be subject to binding covenants guaranteeing a standard of conservation that is at least as stringent as what the park system enforces today, so that the parks’ ecological health would be preserved—and improved—long into the future. The federal government should continue to offer some financial support for park maintenance, in order to keep fees low for visitors, and the tribes would continue to allow universal access to the parks in perpetuity. Bikers and toddlers, Instagram models and Tony



Left: Michael Fast Buffalo Horse, a traditional artist and singer, at Camp Disappointment. Center: The Rattler family's ranch on the Blackfeet Reservation, looking out onto the mountains of Glacier National Park. Right: Robert Hall, who is active in the effort to preserve the Blackfeet language, pictured at Two Medicine Lake, one of the tribe's most sacred locations in Glacier National Park.



Hawk—all would be welcome. We would govern these beautiful places for ourselves, but also for all Americans.

There is precedent for this kind of transfer. The indigenous peoples of Australia and New Zealand now control some of those countries' most significant natural landmarks. For instance: Uluru, previously called Ayers Rock, was transferred to the Anangu decades ago. Thanks to legislation passed in 1976, nearly half of the Northern Territory of Australia has been returned to Aboriginal peoples. In 2017, New Zealand's Māori were granted a greater role in the conservation of the Whanganui River, on New Zealand's North Island. The public is still free to visit as before, but the Māori now have more oversight of the use of the river.

There is a precedent for this kind of transfer in America, too. In 1880, France began work on the Panama Canal, which the United States took over in 1904. Theodore Roosevelt (he keeps coming up) wanted to see it through, and so he worked out a deal with Panamanian nationalists, whereby the U.S. would receive the canal in exchange for help overthrowing the Colombian

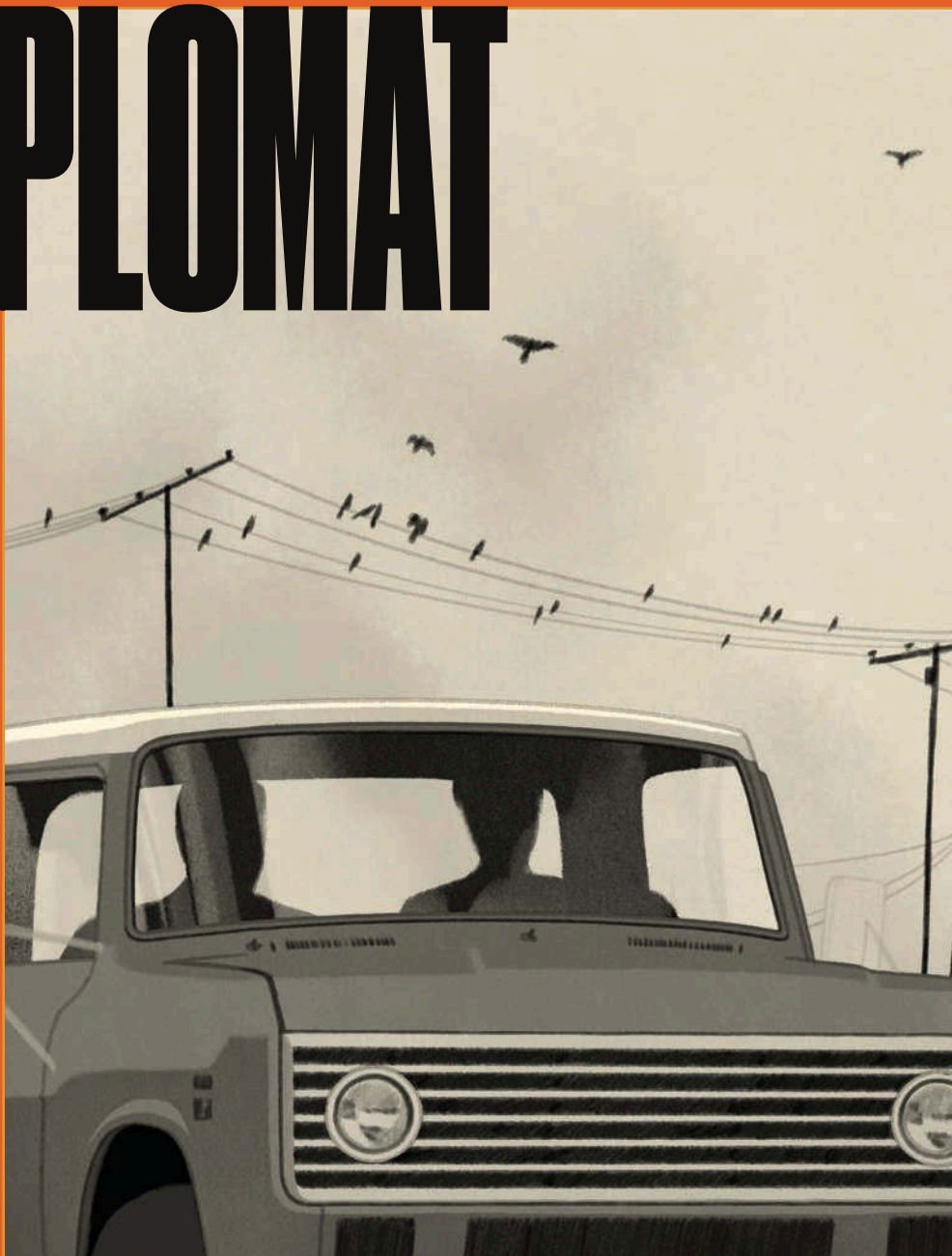
government. But in 1977, President Jimmy Carter and General Omar Torrijos of Panama signed an agreement that outlined the transfer of control of the canal to Panama. The canal was jointly managed by the two countries until 1999, when control reverted fully and finally to Panama. It doesn't happen often, but the United States has given things back.

In 1914, the historian Frederick Jackson Turner argued that American democracy was forged on the frontier. It was there that the uniquely American mixture of egalitarianism, self-reliance, and individualism commingled to form the nation and its character. "American democracy," he said, "was born of no theorist's dream ... It came out of the American forest, and it gained new strength each time it touched a new frontier."

Turner was almost right. It wasn't the frontier that made us as much as the land itself, land that has always been Native land but that has also come to be American. The national parks are the closest thing America has to sacred lands, and like the frontier of old, they can help forge our democracy anew. More than just America's "best idea," the parks are the best of America, the jewels of its landscape. It's time they were returned to America's original peoples. *A*

David Treuer is the author of The Heartbeat of Wounded Knee: Native America From 1890 to the Present.

THE DIPLOMAT



WHO DISAPPEARED



IN 1974, JOHN PATTERSON, AN AMERICAN DIPLOMAT ON HIS FIRST ASSIGNMENT ABROAD, WAS ABDUCTED BY THE PEOPLE'S LIBERATION ARMY OF MEXICO—A GROUP NO ONE HAD HEARD OF BEFORE. THE KIDNAPPERS WANTED \$500,000, AND INSISTED THAT PATTERSON'S WIFE DELIVER THE RANSOM.

BY BRENDAN I. KOERNER



The Motel El Encanto in Hermosillo, Mexico, served a lavish breakfast that John and Andra Patterson liked to eat on the tiled deck near their suite. The couple would discuss the day ahead over fresh pineapple and *pan dulces* while their 4-year-old daughter, Julia, watched the gray cat that skulked about the motel's Spanish arches.

On the morning of March 22, 1974, the Pattersons' breakfast chatter centered on their search for a permanent home. They were nearing their two-month anniversary of living in Hermosillo, where John was a junior diplomat at the American consulate, and the motel was feeling cramped.

After breakfast, Andra dropped John off at work. Because this was his first posting as a member of the United States Foreign Service, the 31-year-old Patterson had been given an unglamorous job: He was a vice consul responsible for promoting trade between the U.S. and Mexico, which on this particular Friday meant driving out to meet with a group of ranchers who hoped to improve their yield of beef.

At 11 a.m., Patterson grabbed the keys to a consular vehicle, a beige International Harvester truck, and headed downstairs. One of his co-workers, an administrative assistant named Luis Sánchez, saw him standing outside the building, chatting amicably with a mustached man in dark sunglasses and a blue suit. When Patterson got behind the wheel of the truck, his acquaintance climbed into the passenger seat.

An hour later, the clerk at the Motel El Encanto spotted the International Harvester traveling north on the broad boulevard that cuts through Hermosillo. He recognized Patterson as the driver: With his thick mop of sandy-brown hair and modish eyeglasses, the vice consul resembled an unkempt Warren Beatty. But the other man was unfamiliar to the clerk.

Around 2:30 p.m., Andra swung by the consulate to browse its library; she wanted to borrow some books before picking Julia up from school. She was immersed in that pleasant task when a secretary informed her that Elmer Yelton, the consul general, needed to see her right away.

Yelton told Andra that John had never shown up for his meeting with the ranchers. When the consulate reopened after its daily lunch break, the staff had discovered an envelope addressed to "Mr. Yelton" tucked beneath the front door. Inside was a two-page note scrawled on green stationery. The consul general showed this note to Andra, who could see that it was written in her husband's hand. The words, however, were clearly not John's own.

"I have evidently been taken hostage by the People's Liberation Army of Mexico," the note began, before segueing into a list of demands. The group wanted a \$500,000 ransom, to be hand-delivered by Andra in two installments. The first payment of \$250,000 was to be made at the Hotel Fray Marcos in Nogales, Mexico, two days later. Andra was then to fly to Mexico City, check into the airport Holiday Inn, and await instructions on how to make the second payment.

"Under no circumstances whatsoever is there to be any news release concerning my captivity before or after my release," the letter warned. If word got out, or if the authorities attempted to intervene in any way, the People's Liberation Army of Mexico would "execute 1 U.S. official each week or member of a U.S. official family."

Once she'd gotten past her initial shock, Andra thought back to a strange moment in New Orleans. The Pattersons had stopped in the city in January on their way from their former home in Virginia to Hermosillo. They'd hired a babysitter to watch Julia so they could catch a

movie. The film the couple had chosen was *State of Siege*, a thinly veiled account of the 1970 kidnapping and murder of Dan Mitrione, a USAID official who'd been teaching the Uruguayan police how to torture. During a scene in which the body of the Mitrione stand-in is found in an abandoned Cadillac, Andra had felt a jolt of anxiety. "Oh my God, that better not be you!" she'd blurted out to John, loud enough to startle other moviegoers.

John had done his best to wave off her concern. But both he and Andra knew that diplomacy had become a perilous line of work.

Word of the Patterson kidnapping

reached President Nixon that evening, while he was en route to Camp David after a long week spent tangling with Watergate investigators. The president and his advisers were by now accustomed to handling situations of this nature: Patterson was the sixth American diplomat to be abducted in a little over a year.

The first had been Clinton Knox, the ambassador to Haiti, who was ambushed near his Port-au-Prince home on January 23, 1973. His kidnappers forced him to call the American consul general in the city, Ward Christensen, who was then lured into captivity as well. A deputy undersecretary of state rushed to Port-au-Prince to help negotiate for the two men's lives. After 20 hours of talks, Knox and Christensen were set free in exchange for \$70,000 from the Haitian treasury and the release of a dozen imprisoned revolutionaries.

Six weeks later, commandos from Black September—the Palestinian group that had murdered 11 Israeli athletes and coaches at the Munich Olympics the year before—stormed the Saudi Arabian embassy in Khartoum. Among the hostages they seized were U.S. Ambassador Cleo Noel and the deputy chief of mission, George Curtis Moore, who'd been attending a dinner party. The kidnappers demanded the release of numerous prisoners, including Sirhan Sirhan, the convicted assassin of Robert F. Kennedy.

A State Department official was dispatched to Sudan to establish a dialogue with the diplomats' captors. But this was a higher-profile crisis than the one in

Port-au-Prince, and Nixon, who'd come to believe that terrorism posed an existential threat to American security, decided it was time to take the hardest possible line. On March 2, 1973, while the State Department's envoy was still in transit to Sudan, Nixon was asked about the Black September kidnappings at a White House press conference. The president improvised an answer that left his negotiator no wiggle room: "As far as the United States as a government giving in to blackmail demands, we cannot do so and we will not do so." Hours later, the terrorists in Khartoum allowed Noel and Moore to write last letters to their wives before executing them.

Now that blood had been spilled, the Nixon administration felt compelled to double down on the president's off-the-cuff remark and make it policy. The U.S. government would henceforth not negotiate with terrorists, even when the lives of American diplomats were at stake.

That stance was put to the test two months later, on May 4, 1973, when guerrillas kidnapped Terrence Leonhardy, the American consul general in the Mexican city of Guadalajara. Though the State Department publicly reiterated that it would not legitimize terrorists by giving in to extortion, it used diplomatic back channels to pressure Mexico to work toward Leonhardy's safe return. After three days in blindfolded captivity, the consul general was let go in exchange for the release of 30 prisoners allied with the Armed Revolutionary Forces of the People, one of the many leftist groups devoted to overthrowing President Luis Echeverría's authoritarian regime.

The White House chose to adopt a similar approach when confronting the Patterson affair. To maintain the optics of toughness—crucial to the president's political survival in the thick of Watergate—the Nixon administration would refuse to provide even a penny to the kidnappers. But the State Department would be permitted to lean on the

Mexican government to locate and liberate the vice consul, and it could offer to quietly assist the Patterson family should they wish to pay the ransom themselves.

This decision was relayed to Patterson's widowed mother, Ann, who lived on Philadelphia's Rittenhouse Square. She and her late husband, who'd been a successful supermarket executive, had powerful friends throughout the city, and Ann tore through her Rolodex in search of help. Within a few hours, she'd persuaded a department-store heiress to personally guarantee a \$250,000 bank loan. That sum would be enough for Andra to deliver the first payment to the kidnappers, and thus buy John a little time.

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WERE AT STAKE.***

A plan was made for Andra to fly to Arizona the next day to collect the ransom; she would then have ample time to make it to Nogales for her initial rendezvous with the People's Liberation Army of Mexico. Andra's stepfather, meanwhile, would travel to Hermosillo to pick up Julia.

Andra passed the sleepless night worrying about her husband, whom she'd known since college. The two had met in the fall of 1962 while spending their junior year abroad in France. On their first date, at an Aix-en-Provence café, John ordered them both espressos in perfect French and then drank his through a

sugar cube wedged between his teeth—a trick he said he'd learned from his brother-in-law in Rome. Nineteen-year-old Andra Sigerson was smitten.

That summer, John and Andra rode a Lambretta scooter across Europe. They basked on the verandas of seaside hotels, washed their clothes in the Mediterranean, and rescued a stray mutt from a swarm of bees on Mallorca. One day, as they whizzed down a mountain road toward Spain's Costa del Sol, Andra pressed her cheek between John's shoulder blades and thought, *I can die right now, because I've felt the highest high a person can ever feel.*

But the love affair faded once John and Andra returned to their respective midwestern universities, 400 miles apart. Andra was vexed by John's habit of canceling his weekend visits without notice, and by the awkward pauses on their phone calls. Days before graduation in 1964, John tried to salvage the relationship by proposing on a Wisconsin bluff. When Andra declined, she assumed she'd never see him again.

Six years later, Andra left an unhappy marriage to the man with whom she'd had Julia. She and her 1-year-old daughter relocated from eastern Washington State to Manhattan's Upper West Side, where she'd grown up. While adjusting to life as a single mother, she decided to find out what had become of John. She learned that he was now a student at Columbia Business School and arranged to meet him on the steps of St. Patrick's Cathedral. She watched him stroll down Fifth Avenue toward the church, his hair as wild and glorious as she remembered. Andra knew they would never part again.

Andra and Julia soon followed John to Washington, D.C., where he'd found work with the ad hoc commission that was implementing Nixon's emergency freeze on consumer prices. But the Beltway grind didn't suit the couple, who craved the sense of adventure they'd experienced aboard their Lambretta scooter a decade earlier. The escape plan that John

proposed was one he'd secretly been aching to pursue since adolescence: He would join the Foreign Service.

When he graduated from the Foreign Service's training program, in the summer of 1973, the State Department asked him to begin his career in Santiago, Chile. But after the country's Marxist president, Salvador Allende, was deposed in a bloody coup that September, John was reassigned to Hermosillo, a place assumed to be relatively safe for a rookie diplomat and his family.

Andra left Hermosillo at midday on March 23. Joining her on the Tucson-bound plane were two State Department veterans who'd flown up from Mexico City at dawn: Victor Dikeos, the supervisor for all of the American consulates in the country, and Keith Gwyn, a diplomatic-security agent. Neither man had ever met John, but they'd volunteered to serve as Andra's bodyguards because they considered the Foreign Service a sacred family.

Andra and her guardians went by car from Tucson to Nogales, Arizona, where they stopped at a motel near the crossing into Nogales, Mexico. Andra had been told to wait there to receive the ransom money, which was being couriered from a bank in Phoenix. As she bided her time,

a phalanx of FBI agents descended on the motel. They said they'd obtained the Mexican government's permission to cross the border with Andra and stake out the Hotel Fray Marcos, where the payoff was to take place. The agents hoped to identify and track whoever collected the cash.

This plan made Dikeos nervous. He worried the kidnappers would execute John immediately if they detected any hint of surveillance. He was not informed of the FBI's hunch that the person who showed up to take the money would not be a genuine terrorist, but rather someone with clandestine ties to John and Andra Patterson.

The ransom money, consisting of \$50 and \$20 bills stacked inside Girl Scout cookie boxes, arrived at the Arizona border motel well past dark on March 23. Andra took a taxi into Mexico and checked in at the Hotel Fray Marcos, a mere block away from American soil.

The next morning, Andra waited for the phone to ring; outside, more than two dozen FBI agents tried to remain incognito. Hours passed, yet no one came looking for the money. By lunchtime, the FBI and the State Department concluded that the payoff wasn't going to happen, and that Andra should return to Hermosillo by car at once.

When she arrived late that afternoon, Andra learned of an important discovery that had been made in her absence: The police had found the International Harvester truck that John had been driving on the morning of his disappearance. Someone had left it at a gas station on the edge of town; there were no signs of a struggle.

The next day, Secretary of State Henry Kissinger placed a call to Andra. He was in the midst of reeling off some sympathetic platitudes when Andra cut him off to ask the only question on her mind: "Do you have any money for me?" As Kissinger tried to explain why U.S. policy precluded the State Department from contributing any funds toward the ransom, Andra stopped listening and handed the phone to someone else.

Andra settled in to await further word from the People's Liberation Army of Mexico. The U.S. government, meanwhile, took pains to heed the ransom note's instructions and conceal John Patterson's abduction from the public. But at a March 27 press conference in Washington, a reporter asked Attorney General William Saxbe why he had abruptly canceled an upcoming trip to Mexico. Having apparently forgotten that he'd been sworn to secrecy, Saxbe replied that an American diplomat had been kidnapped in the country and that his own security was potentially at risk.



Within hours, reporters had uncovered key facts about the kidnapping: the identity of the victim, the amount of money at stake, the name of the terrorist group involved. “U.S. VICE CONSUL MISSING IN MEXICO,” blared the front-page headline in *The New York Times*.

Fearful of how the kidnappers might react, the diplomats in Hermosillo wrote an apologetic statement for Andra to deliver to the press. On March 29, she emerged from Elmer Yelton’s residence and faced a crowd of 30 journalists who’d assembled on the sidewalk out front. She fought back tears as she read from a note card into a bank of microphones:

I am here to appeal to the people who have my husband. I am deeply sorry that the news was made public. I will do everything in my power to ensure his welfare. Please let me know that he is well. Please contact me. And for my husband, if he could hear me ...

Aware that John and Andra were fond of speaking French to each other, and of the nicknames they liked to use, the statement’s authors had concluded it with the words *Giovanni, je t’aime* (“John, I love you”). But that phrase struck Andra as not quite right, so she improvised a final line more reflective of her yearning and her fortitude. *Giovanni, je t’attends*: “John, I am waiting for you.”

Two hundred Mexican police officers combed the desert beyond Hermosillo, hoping to find John Patterson. They discovered no sign of the vice consul, though they did arrest some members of the 23rd of September Communist League, a Marxist guerrilla group responsible for attacks throughout the state of Sonora. The authorities had recently killed one of the group’s leaders, and a rumor circulated that the Patterson abduction might be an attempt at revenge. Mexican police interrogated the captured insurgents, but their brutal style of questioning yielded no useful clues.

Patterson’s own government, meanwhile, doubted that Mexican revolutionaries had played any role in his disappearance. From day one, the FBI had suspected that it might be dealing with a “self-kidnapping”—an elaborate hoax engineered by the Pattersons to steal money from John’s family.

The bureau’s agents had found the kidnappers’ modus operandi odd, starting with the fact that no one had ever heard of the People’s Liberation Army of Mexico. Weirder still was the group’s stated aversion to publicity: Media coverage is

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the lifeblood of terrorism, the means by which small movements make their political aims known.

FBI investigators had also reviewed a sketch of the man who’d been spotted in John Patterson’s truck on the morning of March 22 and had decided he was likely a white American, based on his facial features and formal manner of dress. Agents combed through airplane passenger lists and the logs of rental-car agencies, searching for American citizens who might have been in Hermosillo when Patterson vanished. The list of potential suspects included a copper-mining executive, the landlord of a mobile-home park, and the owner of a Lake Tahoe ski resort, all of whom eventually cleared themselves with alibis.

FBI field offices from Seattle to Milwaukee to New York were ordered to dig into the Pattersons’ backgrounds. The agents assigned to this task documented the nature of the couple’s relationship, which had reignited while Andra was still technically married to her first husband, and which included a child who was not John’s own. They also noted Andra’s apparent affinity for leftist causes. She “admitted to participating in various ‘Rad-Lib’ demonstrations and was against the war in Vietnam and admitted participating in demonstrations against the war,” an

agent wrote in his summary of an interview with Andra. At an agency where J. Edgar Hoover’s reactionary politics still held sway, the Pattersons may have harbored too many progressive ideals to be trusted. The FBI’s leading theory was that the Pattersons had masterminded the whole affair.

That theory, shared by Mexican authorities, was soon leaked to newspapers on both sides of the border. “POLICE ASSURE THAT DISAPPEARANCE OF U.S. VICE CONSUL IS A SELF-KIDNAPPING,” one blunt headline stated. The Justice Department began to discuss how to prosecute the Pattersons once the scam had reached its end. “If it is determined to be a hoax, prosecutive action would most likely be in the Phoenix division,” the FBI director’s office

noted in an April 5 memo.

John’s alleged kidnappers were silent until April 10, when a man who spoke perfect English with a slight Texas twang called the consul general’s residence in Hermosillo and asked for Andra. Elmer Yelton’s wife, Jo, who had the poise of a woman with decades in the field, took the phone instead and said that Andra wasn’t there.

“I—they will give her a second chance,” the man said, referring to Andra. “She is to go to Rosarito in Baja ... We are both in Baja ... She is to stay at the Rosarito Beach Hotel ... She will be contacted there Friday ... John will—and I will be—released Sunday, if she does not cause trouble.”

Jo Yelton pressed the caller to furnish some proof that John was still alive. But

the man kept insisting that he was a hostage too, and could offer nothing beyond the message he'd been ordered to convey. "But please, ah, these people came very close to harming John and I because of this," he said. "And they are very serious."

The FBI had plenty of reasons to consider the call fishy, not least the fact that it traced back to a telephone exchange in San Diego. But Andra Patterson was adamant that she be given the chance to make the payment—this time without companions who might scare away her husband's captors. After taking a light plane to Tijuana with Victor Dikeos and Keith Gwyn, Andra drove alone to the Rosarito Beach Hotel.

Over the next few days, Andra sat by the hotel's pool, a McDonald's bag filled with cash always by her side. But as had happened in Nogales, no one ever came to take the money, and Andra left, dejected.

On May 6, an envelope addressed to Elmer Yelton arrived at the Hermosillo consulate; the postmark revealed that it had been mailed from California on April 30. The letter inside was written on the same green paper as the original ransom note, but the handwriting was not John's. "Two times we gave you chances to free him and two time [*sic*] you hoped to trap our fighters but we know what you do when you do it," the letter read. "Fail to do as we instruct and death is now his only release." The author directed Andra to return to the Rosarito Beach Hotel and check in under the name "West." If she had the \$250,000 payment, she would be taken to meet her husband.

There was a problem, however: The letter stated that Andra had to be back in Rosarito no later than May 3, a date now three days in the past. The slow delivery of the mail had apparently invalidated the kidnappers' offer before it could even be made.

For the second time, Andra felt she had to reach John's captors through the media. On May 17, she spoke to the press and stressed that she was willing to do whatever the kidnappers desired. "I ask only one thing first," she said. "For some proof or evidence that they indeed have my husband and that he is all right."

That proof would never come. As Andra was making her plea to the press,

the FBI was having a radical change of heart about the case. The bureau's agents in Southern California were beginning to zero in on a person of interest, a 40-year-old American who clearly hadn't conspired with the Pattersons—and who, just a year earlier, had been feted as a national hero at the White House.

On March 14, 1973, three C-141 cargo planes touched down in sequence at Clark Air Base, in the Philippines. The vessels carried 108 American prisoners of war, freed by North Vietnam as part of the Paris Peace Accords. Many of these men had spent years in captivity at Hỏa Lò Prison, better known as the Hanoi Hilton. Their homecoming was meant to be a moment of catharsis for a war-weary American public.

One by one, emaciated men in sky-blue work shirts emerged from the planes and saluted the ecstatic crowd from atop the boarding stairs. The loudest cheers were for Lieutenant Commander John McCain, the most famous of the freed prisoners, whose limp betrayed the horrors of the abuse he'd endured.

With the audience's attention focused on the heroes at the front of the plane, few noticed a lone figure exit through the rear door of the last C-141 to land. An unimposing man on the cusp of middle age, he hustled to a waiting bus without responding to any shouted questions from the press. Up until that moment, most everyone familiar with the story of Bobby Joe Keesee had assumed he was long dead.

Keesee hailed from a microscopic town in the Texas Panhandle. He dropped out of the eighth grade and, at the age of 17, enlisted in the Army just in time to be shipped off to the Korean War. Though he yearned to be a paratrooper, Keesee spent his nine months in combat as a standard infantryman. Upon his return to the U.S. in 1953, he decided to make the Army his career and spent the rest of the decade doing stints at bases in Japan, Germany, and Iceland as he attained the rank of sergeant. He earned his parachutist badge, qualified as a sharpshooter with an M-1 rifle, and learned how to operate the flight simulators used to train military pilots.

The most notable aspect of Keesee's Army career was the manner in which he

chose to quit. In January 1962, Keesee went AWOL from Fort Huachuca, in Arizona; stole a car; and embarked on a 13,000-mile road trip that took him as far north as Alaska. After two months on the lam, he wound up in Albuquerque, where he rented a Piper Comanche airplane. He told the owner that he needed to fly his wife to Carlsbad to visit an ailing relative, and that he'd be back by sunset. Every piece of that story was a lie.

Keesee flew east toward Florida, paying for fuel along the way with kited checks. His last stop in the U.S. was at Marathon, in the Keys, after which he made the short hop to Havana. Upon landing, he professed his desire to live in a socialist paradise and requested asylum.

Fidel Castro's secret police were unmoved by Keesee's pleas. They seized his plane, jailed him for 49 days, then put him on a flight to Miami. Keesee was arrested at the airport and extradited to Austin, Texas, where he faced a 153-count federal indictment that carried a possible life sentence.

At trial, Keesee mounted an unusual defense: He contended that he'd acted at the behest of the CIA, which had recruited him to carry out a mission to destabilize Castro's regime. "I was dumbfounded when they arrested me," Keesee said on the witness stand. (The CIA insisted that it had no records of Keesee.)

Keesee spouted other fictions too, with the apparent aim of appealing to the jury's sense of patriotism. He claimed, for example, to have earned a Purple Heart in Korea after suffering a grievous head wound in combat. (His lone war injury, to one of his arms, occurred during a pickup soccer game.) Keesee's lies seemed to have the intended effect. He was ultimately convicted of just a single count of theft and sentenced to a mere five years in prison; he was out in less than three.

After another stint behind bars, for stealing a shipment of parachutes from Fort Bliss, in Texas, in 1965, Keesee moved to Phoenix and found work as a cabinetmaker. But his dalliance with blue-collar normalcy did not last long.

In September 1970, Keesee turned up in northeastern Thailand. Masquerading as a movie producer, he chartered a small



plane with two pilots on the pretense of scouting film locations in the jungle. Twenty minutes into a flight near the Laotian border, Keesee brandished a pistol and ordered the pilots to take him to a beach near the North Vietnamese city of Đồng Hới. It seemed an absurd request given that the U.S. was mired in a long-running conflict with North Vietnam that had cost more than 50,000 American lives.

Once the plane came to rest on the white sand, Keesee jumped out holding a leather briefcase and walked toward a nearby row of huts. After dodging gunfire during takeoff, the pilots glanced back to see dozens of startled villagers encircling the doughy, bespectacled Keesee, the only American within a hundred miles.

The North Vietnamese villagers took Keesee prisoner and turned him over to the army, which understandably assumed that he was a spy. Interrogators used all manner of torture to get Keesee to cough up information about his mission: They knocked out his teeth and tore out his toenails. But since he was just a cabinetmaker afflicted with a pathological need to insert himself into global events—a need that blotted out all logic and reason—Keesee could provide nothing of value to satisfy his tormentors.

He wound up in solitary confinement as one of the Hanoi Hilton's few civilian inmates. Since the North Vietnamese never acknowledged that they had him in custody, both his family and the U.S. government thought he'd been killed soon after landing near Đồng Hới. His appearance alongside John McCain and the other released POWs in the Philippines was a shock to all who remembered his bizarre odyssey.

The Thai government made noise about extraditing Keesee so that he could stand trial for hijacking the plane he'd chartered in 1970. But it never made a formal request, to the relief of American officials, who opposed the move. Despite his muddled backstory, Keesee possessed the veneer of heroism by virtue of his proximity to more noble POWs. And in 1973, a defeated America was in desperate need of heroes.

Keesee was flown to Travis Air Force Base, in California, where he made a show of kissing the honor guard's American flag before receiving a \$1,792 payment from the government for his time in captivity. Two months later, he attended a welcome-home party at the White House. Inside a tent on the South Lawn, he quaffed

champagne and gorged on sirloin with the likes of Sammy Davis Jr., Phyllis Diller, and John Wayne. The highlight of the evening came when a well-oiled President Nixon made a toast and cracked a joke about having ended the Vietnam War so Bob Hope—also in attendance—could be home for the holidays. The president then joined Irving Berlin in a raucous rendition of “God Bless America.”

Keesee moved to Huntington Beach, California, where he rented an apartment, bought a yellow Ford Mustang, and obtained numerous lines of credit. He participated in parades and other civic functions where former POWs were in high demand. Eventually, though, he was forced to look for paid work. On his application to an Orange County cabinet shop, he listed his previous employer as “U.S. Govt” and his job description as “Classified.” He landed the job despite the obvious red flags.

But he once again soured on life as a working stiff. In early January 1974, he paid a visit to a co-worker named Greg Fielden, a 19-year-old with a decent command of Spanish. Keesee told the teenager that he needed his help pulling off a caper that would make them both rich. It involved a trip to Mexico.



Keesee and Fielden crossed the border in Keesee's Mustang on January 16, 1974. Their destination was Hermosillo, where Keesee's father had retired. Under the guise of being a cattle trader, Keesee had traveled there a few times in recent months to scout out the American consulate, even going so far as to introduce himself to a senior diplomat named Louis Villalovos. During their conversation, Villalovos mentioned that the consulate would soon be welcoming a new economics officer, a Columbia Business School graduate named John Patterson. Keesee told Fielden that they would lure the inexperienced Patterson out to the desert and hold him for ransom.

But their timing was off. When Keesee and Fielden asked for Patterson at the consulate, they were told he was still en route to Hermosillo and wouldn't be starting work for another week. The duo left the city without their would-be hostage.

Fielden told Keesee he didn't want to participate in any future kidnapping attempts, and Keesee decided to abandon the idea. But then a tragedy made him reconsider: On March 6, Keesee's father drowned while fishing near Hermosillo, and Keesee went to Mexico to arrange for the body's repatriation to Arizona. While sifting through his father's estate, he found a Remington 12-gauge shotgun.

On March 19, three days after burying his father in Phoenix, Keesee returned to Hermosillo and checked into the Hotel Gandara. He paid another visit to the American consulate, where he struck up a dialogue with John Patterson about the Sonoran cattle industry. On the morning of March 22, he called Patterson and talked his way into tagging along for the vice consul's meeting with the ranchers.

Patterson had been trained to be wary of people who looked like they might have ties to Mexican terrorists, not well-dressed Americans. As he climbed into the International Harvester with his genial new acquaintance, Patterson had no reason to think that anything was amiss.

Like so many criminals whose ambition exceeds their diligence, Keesee was undone by a careless error: When he'd checked into the Hotel Gandara, he'd done so under his own name. When the FBI belatedly got its hands on the hotel's registration cards, its agents naturally wondered why a convicted felon had been hanging around town.

The FBI approached Luis Sánchez, the administrative assistant who'd spotted Patterson's conversation partner on March 22, and showed him an array of photos of mustached white men. Sánchez picked out two and said that either could be the man he'd seen outside the consulate. Both photos were of Bobby Joe Keesee,

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taken years apart. The recording of the April 10 phone call to the consul general's residence proved useful too. The FBI played the tape for Keesee's older brother, who identified the voice as Bobby Joe's.

On the morning of May 28, the FBI arrested Keesee in Huntington Beach as he left his apartment to go to work. A search of his car turned up a pair of handcuffs and two shotgun shells.

Rather than claim total ignorance of the case, Keesee confessed that he was the person who'd written the April 30 letter that had instructed Andra to return to the Rosarito Beach Hotel. He insisted,

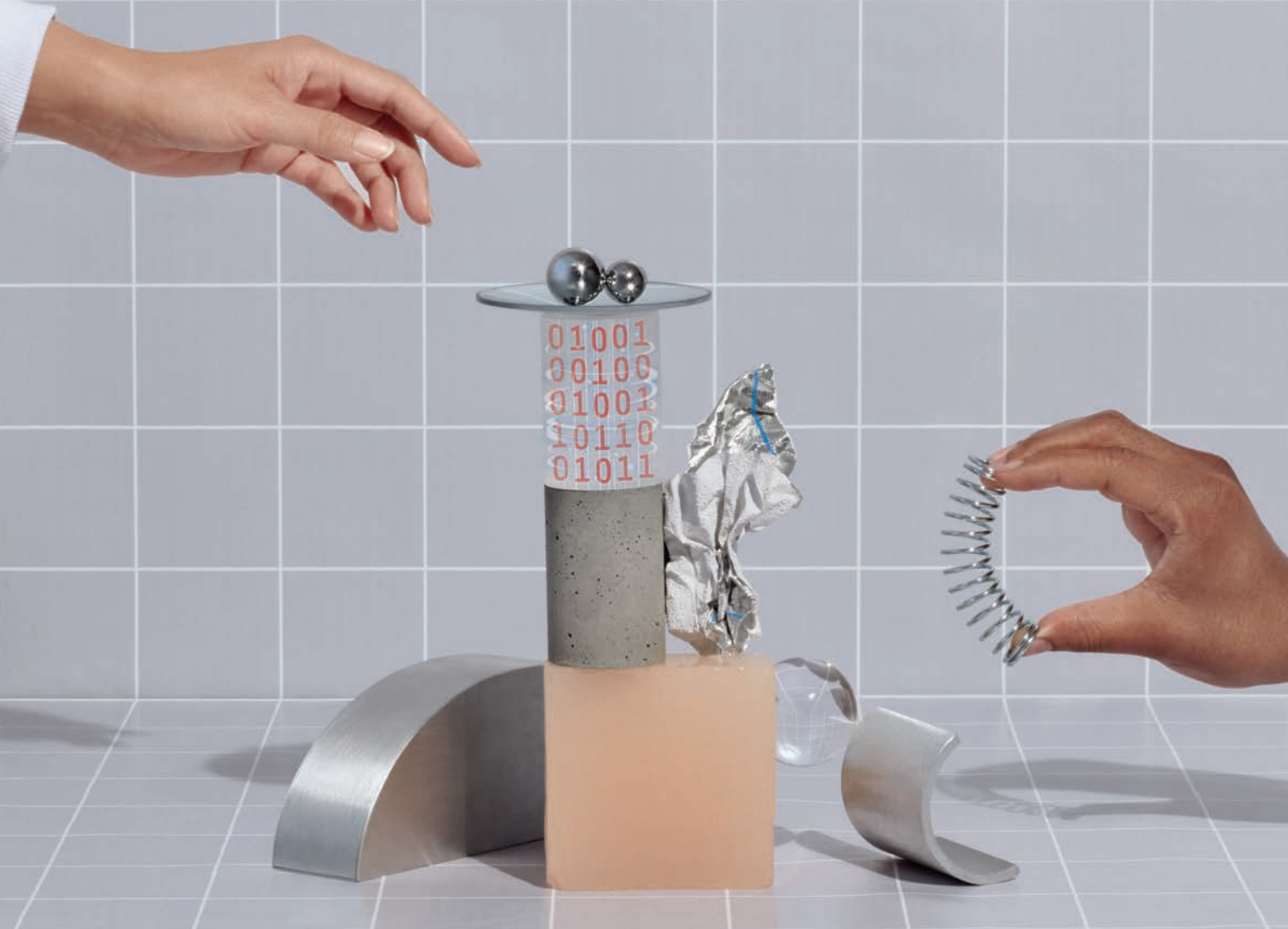
however, that he'd only sent the letter because he'd felt sorry for Andra and wanted to give her a shred of hope. He otherwise denied knowing anything about the kidnapping.

Andra was in New York retrieving Julia when she learned that her husband's alleged kidnapper was being held on \$100,000 bail. The news did not erode her faith in the inevitability of her husband's safe return. She and Julia traveled to Mexico City and became temporary guests of Victor Dikeos and his family, who occupied a plush villa with a trampoline in the backyard. While Julia began ballet classes, Andra devoted herself to apartment hunting. She vowed to friends that she was willing to grow old in Mexico if need be; she wouldn't leave the country without John.

On July 8, 1974, a peasant wandering in the scrublands north of Hermosillo noticed what looked like the carcass of a large animal. But when he pulled close to the mass of blood, bone, and skin, he realized that he'd stumbled upon a human body half-buried in the dirt—a male with a thick mop of sandy-brown hair.

The coroner in Hermosillo left no room for doubt that John Patterson had finally been found. He matched the body's teeth to dental records sent from Philadelphia. A gold wedding ring was found on the ground near the body, inscribed with the initials JSP and AMS, as well as the French words *Mon Destin*. The cause of death was blunt-force trauma to the head.

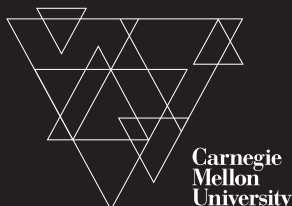
Henry Kissinger sent an Air Force jet to Hermosillo to transport Patterson's body to Washington, D.C., for burial. Andra accompanied her husband's flag-draped casket on the journey to Andrews Air Force Base. The honor guard on the tarmac, the funeral at Rock Creek Church, the awkward embraces from dignitaries she'd never met—all of it was a blur for Andra as she tried to reckon with the emptiness that lay ahead.



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Federal prosecutors added murder to the list of charges against Bobby Joe Keesee. They built a seemingly airtight case, the centerpiece of which was an affidavit from Greg Fielden in which he described the failed kidnapping plot from January. Investigators also tracked down the shotgun once owned by Keesee's father at a pawn shop. An analysis of the gun's stock revealed specks of human blood.

Prosecutors contended that once Keesee had had Patterson under his physical control, he'd realized that the vice consul would surely identify him if released. Keesee, the prosecutors wrote, had seen only one way out of his predicament:

It appears that Keesee handcuffed Patterson and marched him off into the desert. Patterson must have realized at this time that Keesee intended to kill him because all of the evidence points to a struggle. His broken glasses were discovered next to a bush about 100 feet from his grave ...

It must have been when Patterson began to struggle, that Keesee, with ten years' Army experience as a paratrooper and an expert in the use of arms, delivered the crippling butt stroke to Patterson's face which broke his glasses and knocked out his front teeth. After Patterson fell to the ground, Keesee must have then smashed in the back of his head and dragged his body into a small gully nearby.

In the midst of pretrial preparations, however, prosecutors seem to have suffered pangs of self-doubt. They lacked an eyewitness to the murder or physical evidence that tied Keesee to the crime scene. (The dried blood on the shotgun could not be definitively matched to Patterson.) The muddled nature of the kidnapping investigation also threatened to prove problematic: The defense might try to discredit the FBI by harping on the weeks it had spent focused on John and Andra as the plot's organizers.

Rather than risk the humiliation of losing at trial, the U.S. attorney's office in San Diego cut a deal. Keesee agreed to plead guilty to a single count of conspiracy to kidnap, specifically linked to



the extortion letter he'd mailed from San Diego on April 30, 1974. In exchange, the government dropped all the other charges, including murder.

In advance of sentencing, a court-appointed psychiatrist evaluated Keesee. The doctor described him as a sociopath who was "clever enough to surround himself with verbal smokescreens." Yet even the psychiatrist wound up bamboozled by his subject. "Mr. Keesee has a good deal on the positive side of the ledger—physique and physical health, intellect and engaging personality, and a versatile education largely obtained 'the hard way,'" he wrote in his report. "Society may be able to profit from his services in five to ten years."

At his sentencing hearing on April 28, 1975, Keesee was offered the customary opportunity to make a statement. The words he offered were superficially contrite yet oddly passive. "There's nothing more I can say," he declared. "I got involved in something that I realize was wrong." Moments later, the judge sentenced him to 20 years in prison. The Justice Department assured the Pattersons that Keesee would serve the maximum term possible. But it would not make good on that promise.

In late 1998, a champion powerboat racer named Harry Christensen placed

a classified ad in *Flying* magazine. Christensen, who also owned a boat-manufacturing company near Arizona's Lake Havasu, had recently purchased a new Piper Cheyenne turboprop, and he was looking to sell his old Cessna 340. The most promising response came from a man who called from Las Vegas. He introduced himself as a property developer named Bobby Joe Keesee.

Christensen flew to Las Vegas on January 5, 1999, to pick up the 64-year-old Keesee and take him to Lake Havasu City. The two men agreed to close the deal the next morning. Christensen's wife, Debbie, and his son, Jeff, expected to see him at work later that morning with Keesee's \$300,000 check in hand.

When the afternoon rolled around without any trace of him, they alerted the police and went looking for him at the airport. They were told the Cessna had taken off around 8 a.m. and had landed in Winslow, Arizona, to refuel. It was unclear where the plane had gone from there.

That evening, Debbie and Jeff received a call from the proprietor of Coronado Airport in northeast Albuquerque. The Cessna had landed there that afternoon and was now parked on the tarmac. The police searched the empty plane and found a pool of blood in the passenger



area, as well as a travel bag containing Keese's pilot's license and a .38-caliber pistol clip that was missing bullets.

The next day, Keese was arrested by FBI agents while driving on Interstate 25 near Las Cruces. His pockets contained Christensen's driver's license, which he'd altered by gluing on his own photograph, and a gold Rolex engraved with the initials HMC.

Keese had been paroled in January 1986, having supposedly proved his trustworthiness by working in a prison business office. Over the next dozen years, Keese had orchestrated a series of daring scams: He had set up a fake company to purchase \$634,000 worth of copper; he had posed as a Federal Emergency Management Agency official to steal 2,000 feet of gold wire; he had tricked a New Jersey aviation company into selling him a cargo plane that he'd hoped to offload to Mexican drug traffickers. Each con ended with his arrest. But Keese had never served more than a few years in prison for any of those crimes.

After his arrest near Las Cruces, Keese swore that Christensen had been alive when they'd parted ways. But on May 2, a rancher found Christensen's remains while grazing his cattle in a desolate patch off New Mexico's Route 44. An autopsy

revealed that Christensen had been shot twice in the chest and once in the head.

Even Keese couldn't talk his way out of trouble this time. To avoid the death penalty, he agreed to plead guilty to a range of charges including murder and air piracy. A sentence of life without parole meant that Keese's career—a case study in the incoherence of evil—had finally come to an end.

Andra Patterson barely survived her first year as a widow. She moved back to Virginia and lived under an assumed name, fearing that Keese might have associates who wished her and Julia harm. As she mourned her husband, she often took solace in a fantasy in which she spotted John and Keese driving through Hermosillo in the International Harvester. Andra envisioned herself racing out into the boulevard to pull John from the vehicle and spiriting him back to the safety of the Motel El Encanto. Whenever the reassuring power of that reverie wore off, a wave of crushing sadness followed.

Andra's grief, so staggering in the years right after Mexico, gradually receded into the background of her busy life. She worked at the State Department, where she edited an in-house newsletter, and she eventually remarried. She also became an accomplished painter;

her work was once displayed at the U.S. embassy in Kuala Lumpur.

I first contacted Andra through the website she maintains to showcase her art. A few months later, she agreed to meet me for coffee in New York. Less than a minute after we sat down, she cut off my feeble attempt at chitchat to say that she was reluctant to dredge up her most searing memories and share them with the world. She was worried not just about the psychic toll of opening up about the events in Hermosillo, but also about her personal safety. The last time she'd received any word about Keese, back in the mid-1990s, he was out of prison; what if he tracked her and Julia down after seeing one of his old crimes brought to light?

I told Andra about the murder of Harry Christensen, whose name she'd never heard before. And I was also able to assure her that Keese was no longer a threat to anyone: He had died of lung cancer in a prison hospital in December 2010. No one had claimed his body.

Andra eventually consented to a series of interviews at her home near Washington, D.C. During the first of these, she showed me a file box marked *THE CASE*, which had been sealed up in her attic. It contained a trove of artifacts that she had preserved: affidavits, telegrams, newspaper clippings, a letter of condolence from President Nixon, an annotated map from the European scooter trip with John. Andra told me she'd recently started sifting through the archive for the first time in 40 years. It was painful, of course, to be reminded of how her world had been smashed apart by a sociopath. But there was also joy to be had in reacquainting herself with the person she'd once been—a person who had not wilted in the face of the incomprehensible.

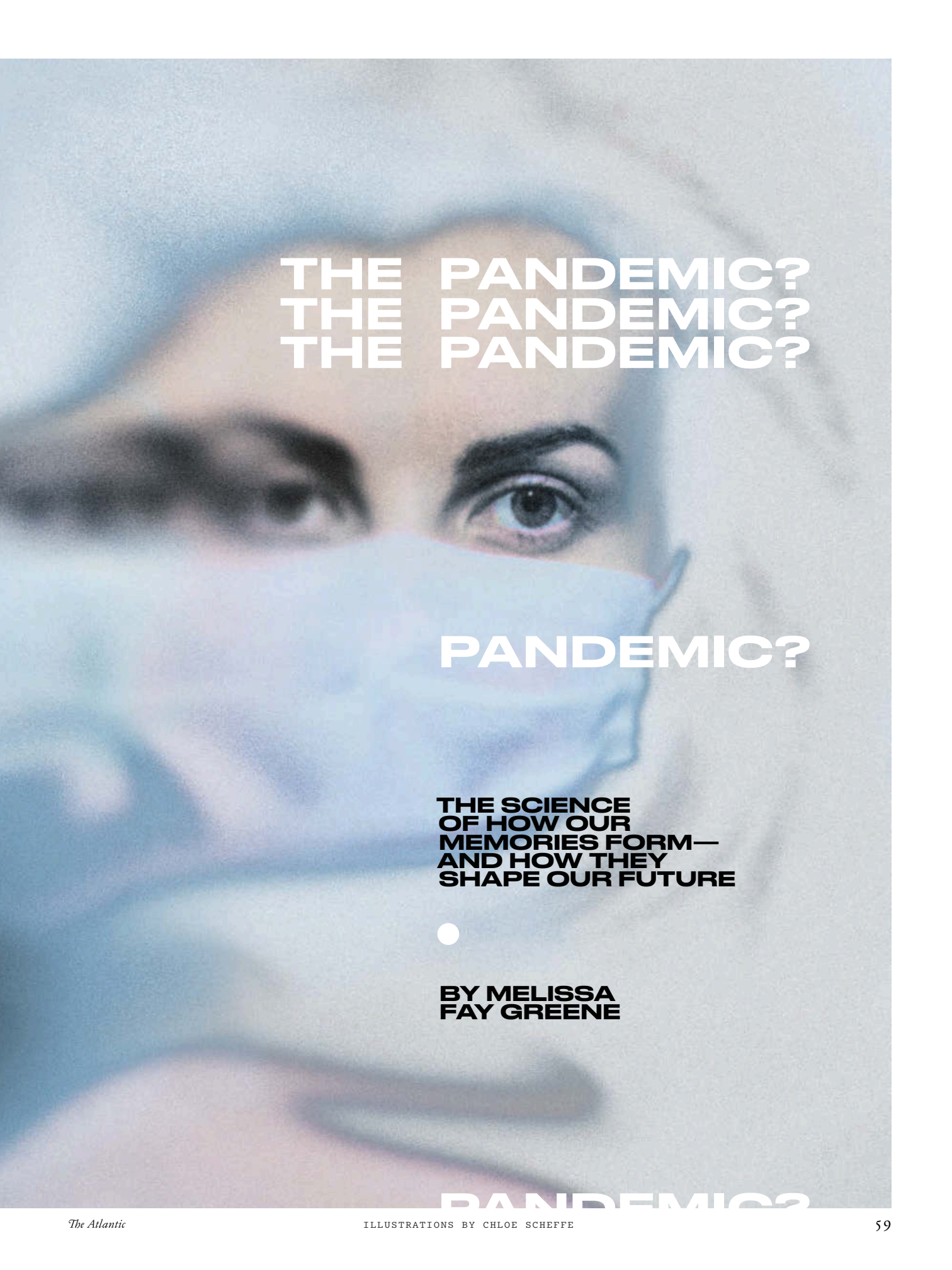
"That young 31-year-old woman, she acted with no help, no one to hold her; her best friend was missing," she said. "But she acted—I acted—completely honorably throughout that whole period. And I love her." *A*

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WILL WE
HOW WILL WE REMEMBER
REMEMBER

REMEMBER



**THE PANDEMIC?
THE PANDEMIC?
THE PANDEMIC?**

PANDEMIC?

**THE SCIENCE
OF HOW OUR
MEMORIES FORM—
AND HOW THEY
SHAPE OUR FUTURE**



**BY MELISSA
FAY GREENE**

PANDEMIC?

MY PLAGUE YEAR BEGAN ON

the evening of Wednesday, March 11, 2020, when I was compelled to cancel the Atlanta-to-Denver plane tickets my husband and I had purchased for the next day, for a long visit with our oldest son, daughter-in-law, and small grandson. I was all packed.

For the first half of the week, I'd tried to configure the increasingly ominous COVID-19 news in ways that wouldn't keep me separated from that curly-haired 3-year-old boy. Several of our adult kids had attempted to pierce my denial, calling and texting to say, "Mom, it doesn't feel safe." Wednesday night, when I saw the Denver family ringing me via FaceTime, my heart dropped. Upstairs, weeping, I unpacked the picture books and little wooden toys.

My husband, meanwhile, said that everyone was overreacting, even our son who works at the CDC. But that same night the NBA suspended its season. *Oh*, my husband thought, *this must be serious!* At that moment, his plague year began.

In the weeks that followed, as friends and neighbors recounted similar stories of when normal life stopped for them, I began to wonder about the tales we would someday tell of the pandemic. For the rest of my life, would my story begin with the cancellation of two Delta tickets for Flight 1355, ATL-DEN, scheduled for March 12, 2020? Would my husband eternally narrate the fact that, on March 11, 2020, the National Basketball Association suspended the 2019–20 season after Rudy Gobert, Utah Jazz center, tested positive for the coronavirus? And—bigger picture—what would we as a nation remember?

The pandemic has not been a single, traumatic "flashbulb" event like the assassination of John F. Kennedy, the fiery disintegration of the space shuttle Challenger, or 9/11. Instead, it's a life period in which everybody's memories will be embedded, more like the Great Depression or World War II, or My High-School Years or When I Was Married to Barbara. Starting in March 2020, hundreds of millions of Americans began forming their own impressions of it. As psychologists and anthropologists who study memory will tell you, we tend to lay out our anecdotes almost like short stories or screenplays to give our lives meaning; our plots (do they have silver linings? hopeful endings?) can reveal something about how we handle setbacks.

We're already shaping our future pandemic narratives—the stories we will tell as individuals, as communities, as societies, and

as nations about this epoch. The process of crafting these stories will help determine our resilience and well-being. How we tell our stories can transform how we move forward from hard times.

1.

WHAT WE REMEMBER—
AND WHAT WE FORGET

"There were so many unknowns at the beginning of the pandemic," Alex Enurah, an internal-medicine-trained hospitalist at the Medical Center of Aurora, in Colorado, told me when we spoke via Zoom recently. He had a dark beard of rich gloss and density, and maintained an expression of attentive listening and kind concern. "First, will it really cross the seas to the U.S.? How hard will it hit us? Who's going to get it?" As the virus ravaged Spain and Italy, the questions built, along with the foreboding sense "that something big was coming, with little time to prepare."

Born in 1986 in Moscow, the son of a Nigerian father and a Russian mother who met at university while completing doctorates in mathematics, Alex grew up in Baltimore. His wife, Lynn VanderWielen, a tall white woman from Wisconsin farm country, is an expert in public-health-program evaluation. Their three-bedroom brick ranch sits in the sort of landscaped Denver neighborhood whose trees look scrubby under the enormous skies of the Great Plains. Medicine isn't an easy path for a Black man. "When Alex enters a room, his patients sometimes think he's come to pick up their food tray," Lynn told me. "He says that's an important job, too, just not something a physician does. Black families are always happy to see him, though."

When his hospital asked for volunteers to see COVID-19 patients, Alex stepped up. "We constantly read updates and revised our practices to try to keep people safe," he said. "It was scary but also exciting, a rare chance to practice medicine at an historic moment. I wondered if this was like the early days of trying to get a handle on HIV/AIDS. As patients began arriving, it felt like we were taking off in a plane we hadn't finished building yet."

While reporting this story, I asked people via social media to tell me what had made the deepest impression on them so far about the pandemic and what they thought they'd remember. Memory experts then helped me assess the submissions—and what they indicate about how our minds work.

Many replies to my prompts and to my follow-up questions began with the moment a person learned the college dorm was closing, the performances were suspended, the restaurant was shutting down. The psychology professor Henry L. Roediger III and the anthropology professor James Wertsch, scholars of collective memory at Washington University in St. Louis, introduced me to the "primacy effect," one of the ways a memory gets "pinned" (as we say of tweets), to be easily retrievable.

In an experiment conducted in 1974, 1991, and 2009, whose results were published under the title "Forgetting the Presidents," Roediger and his co-author, K. A. DeSoto, asked people to recall



in five minutes all the presidents they could. The popularity of George Washington as a response exemplified the primacy effect, the tendency to remember firsts. The “recency effect”—another pin—was exemplified by participants easily naming contemporary White House occupants.

And the imprinting of dramatic story lines—which I’ll call the “narrative effect,” a very powerful pin—explains why Abraham Lincoln, JFK, and Richard Nixon live on in popular memory. A few decades hence, Roediger has noted, recent-ish presidents such as Harry Truman, Dwight Eisenhower, Lyndon B. Johnson, and Gerald Ford may very well have gone the way of 19th-century figures such as Millard Fillmore and Franklin Pierce—forgotten by most Americans. They weren’t the first and they’re no longer the most recent, nor were their terms in office remarkable for being action-packed.

These natural memory aids work whether we’re naming the Founding Fathers or recalling a turning point in our own life.

“I’ll never forget those first spooky, surreal days of shelter-in-place in the Bay Area,” wrote Kevin Simpson, an artist, in response to my prompts. “It’s one of the wealthiest and most technologically advanced places in the world, and yet we were scrounging stores for bread; paper towels; cleaning products; something, anything, to make a makeshift mask. Roads eerily silent, people crossing the street when you’d near each other on a sidewalk while walking a dog.”

“I’ll never forget the moment in March when a colleague at the local borough hall told me that we’d been asked to evacuate the building immediately because of the pandemic,” wrote Howard Fredrics, who runs a public-access television station in Park Ridge, New Jersey. “I grabbed my office computer and ran. I haven’t been back.”

“I don’t think people will ever forget March of 2020 and how the world changed in the matter of a week or so,” Dan P. McAdams, a psychology professor at Northwestern University

and an expert in narrative memory, told me. “I remember that week. I can tell you the days of the week.”

Someday, when this is all behind us, children may ask what it was like to live through a global pandemic. Given the primacy effect, we’ll probably start with the moment we realized something weird was afoot—my canceled Delta tickets, my sports-fan husband’s lost NBA season, and Alex Enurah’s sense of taking off in an unfinished plane.

THOUGH WE MAY vividly recall “how it began,” many of our pandemic memories will be hazier. I seem to remember a bright, clear morning in late March, when sheets of cool spring air billowed toward me on a walk, and I thought, *Okay, I can do this*. I made a few long-term plans (“long-term” in the sense of “in case lockdown lasts six weeks”): Shift my college classes to remote teaching, via Zoom. Read all of Charles Dickens, because if not now, when? Cultivate pollinator-friendly native plants in the backyard. But in truth, I can’t be sure if my early-pandemic plans were the thoughts of one bright, breezy morning or the thoughts of many such mornings. That’s typical, the memory experts told me.

“Most of our memories are in the form of generalities,” says Robyn Fivush, a psychology professor at Emory University.

Hans and I had one fun outing left: the car wash. I’d bring a juice box and snacks and we’d ride through, watching the bubbles. He always asks to go. My car has never been this clean on the outside.”

As Fivush had suggested, most of the submissions to my prompts took this form: “What life was like.” I assume my memories will do the same. I walked the dogs a lot. I read Dickens. I discovered that Zoom classes, Zoom Thanksgiving, and Zoom game nights were a far cry from actual gatherings, but far better than nothing. I hugged those of my family members who were part of my “pod” and desperately missed the ones who lived a plane ride away. My grandson turned 4.

FIVUSH IS INTRIGUED by which moments get tucked away in the slick curlicues of a person’s brain, and why those moments—rather than the tens of millions of others from a lifetime—are saved. We use our memory in part to create a continuous sense of self, she told me, “a ‘narrative identity’ through all of life’s ups and downs: *I am a person whose life has meaning and purpose. I’m more than the subject of brute forces. There’s a Story of Me.*”

What we tend to remember most specifically are high moments and low moments, which become “episodes” in our memory, invested with meaning. In April, Alex Enurah fell ill.

WE DON'T SHELVE A PRISTINE FIRST EDITION OF AN EXPERIENCE IN A DUST-FREE INNER SANCTUM; WE SLOPPILY PASS THE MEMORY AROUND, INVITING COMMENT.

Because most of life is routine and recurring, she told me, you remember what life was like. “I might tell you about my memories of childhood: ‘One of the most important things to me was having Shabbat dinner every Friday night with my family.’ You might ask: ‘Tell me about one of those family dinners.’ I’d say: ‘Oh gosh, I don’t think I can.’”

In Denver, in the Enurah-VanderWielen home, as Alex’s plague year began with the steep uptick in COVID-19 cases at his hospital, his wife was in the third trimester of a much-wanted pregnancy. The couple had previously lost two pregnancies, and Lynn had suffered a dangerous postpartum hemorrhage when their son, Hans, was born. Lynn began working remotely, but mostly hung out with Hans, a giggly 2-year-old. She’d already been anxious about childbirth; the fear that Alex could get sick now compounded it. “My memories of childbirth are *I lived because Alex took care of me*,” she said. “He wasn’t my medical provider, obviously, but he was the one who said, ‘Lynn’s in trouble.’ Being pregnant during COVID scared me for a lot of reasons, but mostly it was the thought *If I have to deliver the baby without Alex, will I survive it?*”

“Hans and I stopped going to the grocery store, stopped playing with other kids at the park. Our neighbors grocery-shopped for us.

“When I first felt a little tired,” Alex said, “I assumed it was from working long hours and trying to catch up on sleep in a house where a 2-year-old knows where to find you. I said, ‘My pelvis hurts,’ and my 36-weeks-pregnant wife gives me a *look*. My COVID test came back positive, so I isolated downstairs.”

“The baby’s due date was May 11, 2020, and Alex got sick in mid-April,” Lynn said. “I made him breakfast, lunch, and dinner; placed his dishes on the washer and dryer; and went back upstairs before he opened his door. I worried that if I got sick, it could affect the baby, or they’d take her away from me after birth.”

“Six or seven days in,” Alex said, “just really run-down and weak, sense of smell and taste gone, no appetite, talking by phone with colleagues every day. I kept track of my oxygen with a pulse oximeter, and initially I was like 96, 97, 98 percent. Then I noticed—like, day six—more like 90, 91 percent, which is a change for me, but still kind of normal. And finally, I started dipping down to, like, 88 percent just from standing up. When I was down to about 85 percent, my colleagues said: ‘Let’s bring you in.’”

But where to go? He didn’t want to be a burden on his colleagues. “In a different world or, like, if Alex were white, he could have gone to any hospital in town,” Lynn said, “but anywhere

other than the MCA, he'd be just an anonymous Black male admitted off the street."

"If there was anyone on Earth who could, you know, guarantee that I would get to meet the little girl Lynn was carrying," Alex said, choking up, "I felt it was my boss, Joseph Forrester," a pulmonologist. "I just really wanted to meet that little girl."

The chief medical officer, Philip Stahel, on a group phone call with Alex, said: "I'm sending an ambulance for you now."

Alex protested: "I can't do that to Lynn—she's very pregnant. That will scare her."

"All right," replied Chakradhar Kotaru, another pulmonologist on the call. "I'm coming myself."

"It was the middle of the night," Lynn said, "and his colleague walks in wearing a full hazmat suit. It scared the crap out of me. He went into the basement and helped Alex climb the stairs. I was shocked to see how much weight he'd lost in just a few days. Dr. Kotaru helped him get into the SUV, and they drove away."

TONY RAMOS, a graphic designer in Cleveland, was one of the people who responded to my request for stories of the pandemic. "2020 will be marked by my Easter evening sitting on the steps to the basement of my house, cellphone in hand, listening to my sister describe how the hospital in which her husband just died from COVID-19 would not let her into the building to be at his bedside," he wrote. "Instead, she had to sit in her car in their parking lot, alone. I will think about hospital parking lots differently for the rest of my life."

Trauma gouges deeply into our minds, engraving painful and long-lasting memories. "Whether they are rape victims, combat veterans, or earthquake survivors, people exposed to terrifying trauma typically retain vivid memories of the most central aspects of such experiences, often for the rest of their lives," Richard McNally, a psychology professor at Harvard, told me. "Although most people exposed to trauma do not develop post-traumatic stress disorder, they nevertheless seldom, if ever, forget their trauma." The evolutionary purpose is clear: Vivid memories of dangerous incidents may help us avoid them in the future. But that doesn't make these memories any less searing.

"Alex started out on a regular floor, but with fevers of 103, 104, he was moved to the ICU," Lynn told me. "They surrounded him with ice packs. We tried to FaceTime, but he was so out of it. His face looked shaved and gaunt. He looked like he was freezing, but said he was miserably hot. He wasn't eating. Our relationship is based on a lot of joking and messing around, and we tried to do that a tiny bit on the phone, but Alex would have coughing fits and couldn't get his breath."

"Code blues were going off all around me in the ICU," Alex said. "TVs were tuned to CNN, and I thought I heard them saying, 'Black and Hispanic COVID-19 patients are doing *particularly* poorly.' And I was like, *This is not going well*. I'd suspected that the poorer outcomes of Black and Hispanic patients were not all due to social determinants of health, that there might be other components that hadn't been quantified yet. Being Black, I was really scared at this point. I was breathing too quickly. I'd cough once or twice, and my oxygen level would fall into the

70s. I'd seen patients who'd had one, two, four liters of oxygen suddenly pass away, despite our best efforts. I started reviewing the choices I'd made in life to become a doctor. I also started to think, *Well, would this be a time to, you know—not write a letter; I didn't have the stamina for that. But should I record a video message to our unborn child, kind of telling her about her dad? I didn't want to tell Lynn that I was thinking about something like that, but I think she and I both knew this could end really badly.*"

Lynn said: "Mostly over the phone, when he could hardly talk at all, we just kept saying 'I love you. I love you so much.' Once, he said: 'I'm not sure I'm going to meet our baby.'"

2.

THE SHAPE WE GIVE TO OUR STORIES

"Even as we experience an event," Robyn Fivush has written, "we are already beginning to think about how to tell this event to another person at a later time." In a 2008 paper for the academic journal *Memory*, she and a co-author elaborated on the ideas of the 20th-century French sociologist Maurice Halbwachs, who developed the concept of collective memory: "Even when experiencing events for the first time, the traveller has in mind the reactions of others, which colour both his perception of the event and his recollection of it."

According to Halbwachs, we begin composing our memories in anticipation of sharing them. I've caught myself doing this (and the more confusing or stressful the event, the more likely I am to start framing it before it's over, picturing the friends and family I will entertain with my tale of woe and mishap). But I had no idea that everyone does it, nor did I know that retailing our memories into shareable stories is intrinsic to the art of remembering. "When something is going terribly wrong," Fivush confirmed, "you're already thinking, *When this is all over, if it ends well, it's going to be a great story.*"

Lynn spent a lot of time on the phone with her sister, sharing updates about Alex's condition and seeking support. "Hans occupied my mind most of the day," Lynn told me, "but when he went to bed at night and I was alone, I spiraled. Because then I could look at the news, read the articles, see what was happening with COVID. I called my sister in Wisconsin to ask, 'Should I just come home? What if Alex gets so sick that he's on a ventilator and that's when I go into labor? What if Alex doesn't make it? Am I going to raise two kids all alone?' Hans idolizes his dad ... I mean, anything Alex does, to Hans it's the most marvelous thing in the whole wide world."

"My sister tried to reassure me: 'He's going to be okay.'"

The work of Elizabeth Loftus, a cognitive psychologist at UC Irvine, and others has shown that, if we discuss a memory with listeners who remember it differently, we may unconsciously borrow a bit of their local color or scrap of dialogue for our own version. "Every time you bring a memory to mind, it's activated, then reconsolidated," Fivush told me. And we're open to accepting



other people's interpretation of our own memories. "We need to make sense of things," she continued. "During COVID, you call your friend to say, 'I'm so lonely,' and she says, 'I know, but Zooming with your family helps, doesn't it? I feel like I'm talking to my grown kids more than ever,' and you immediately start to think about your situation differently. You'll remember it differently."

We don't shelve a pristine first edition of an experience in a dust-free inner sanctum; we sloppily pass the memory around, inviting comment. The consolidated edition, with other people's fingerprints all over it, is what we put on the shelf of long-term memory, unaware that we've done so.

THE FOUNDER OF the field of cognitive psychology, Ulric Neisser, who died in 2012, was Fivush's mentor and colleague at Emory. On January 29, 1986, he distributed a brief questionnaire to his Psych 101 undergrads, asking for details about how they'd learned—the previous day—about the cataclysmic failure of the

Challenger. He collected answers from 106 students. In the fall of 1988, he tracked down 44 of the students and asked them to answer the same questions again. The results were striking: 25 percent of the subjects were wrong about everything, scoring zero. Half of the subjects scored two or less on a seven-point scale. Meanwhile, most of the students felt confident about their replies. "Our data leave no doubt that vivid and confident flashbulb recollections can be mistaken," Neisser concluded. "When this happens, the original memories seem to have disappeared entirely; none of our retrieval cues enabled the subjects to recover them."

In the process of remembering their Challenger stories, the Emory undergrads may have unwittingly borrowed parts of their friends' narratives. One student wrote, in 1986, "I was in my religion class and some people walked in and started talking about [it]." Two and a half years later, the same student wrote: "When I first heard about the explosion I was sitting in my freshman dorm room with my roommate and we were watching TV."



Whenever I've told people about this research, likening it to my generation's purported total recall of the afternoon of Friday, November 22, 1963, their response is invariably: "Sure, but I remember it perfectly," after which they tell me their particulars, thereby missing the point of Neisser's findings. (For the record, I'm also certain that I remember those minutes with molecular precision, including wondering whether the shooting—we hadn't yet learned that President Kennedy had died—meant that my Friday-afternoon piano lesson would be canceled.)

"No one ever says: 'Oh sure, I heard about 9/11, but it didn't really strike me,'" Fivush told me. "No, the story is: 'I *heard* the news, and I *ran* to the TV, and I *watched* the second tower come down, and I was *devastated*.' We probably didn't all do that, but a lot of us did. As we tell the story, it's not really false. To tell it is to become part of the community, to share the moment, to work together to understand an event that's difficult to grasp. If we recall and talk about something often enough, it will become

a 'cultural narrative.' Through multiple tellings, repetitions, and negotiations, it becomes the Story About X."

This plague year has left us feeling isolated. Each of us seems to dwell alone within a damp grotto of private thoughts. But we're already engaged in the crowdsourcing project of organizing collective memories. Americans self-sort into countless communities, which have very different experiences of the pandemic. There are health-care workers and scientists logging inhuman hours; frontline "essential workers" getting sick and going broke; parents trying to do their jobs while acting as their children's teachers; kids squirming in front of their Zoom screens; Black Lives Matter activists marching and seeing their numbers swell; folks working from home who are dazed by the sameness of their days; college students stalled in their childhood bedrooms. There are the evicted, the jobless, the sick, the bereaved.

In daily chitchat and in give-and-take on social media, we share with others how it started for us and how it's going. We instinctively compare and match what we've got to what they've got, like the Emory undergrads settling on a blended version of How I Learned About the Challenger Disaster. Within each community, for years to come, stories will be passed around, tweaked, and polished until a small number of gems come to represent *This is what it was like to live through the coronavirus pandemic*.

Narrative-memory experts call this "the social construction of autobiographical memory." It's possible that Lynn's late-night collaboration with her sister—who urged optimism—enabled Lynn to re-shelve the day's difficult hours in her memory with the lightest tincture of hope.

THE GREATEST MEMORY-KEEPERS invented by humankind are stories. "Facts are better remembered when interwoven in a narrative," Henry Roediger told me. Think about what you know of your early childhood. Stories told about you as a little kid are more accessible than a random Wednesday afternoon when you came in quietly from kindergarten and ate your lunch without complaint.

Inherent in the architecture of a story is its meaning. Narrative-memory experts believe that by manipulating the plot of an anecdote, we may be able to exert a bit of control over a memory, even a painful one.

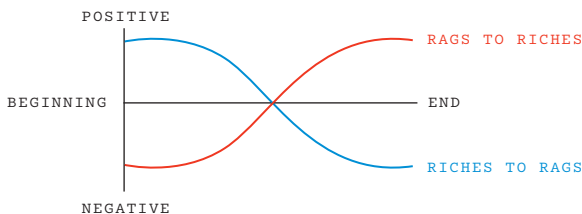
A story opens with a protagonist anchored in time and place, who has a goal and a motivation, but confronts obstacles and barriers on the journey to the goal. At the end of the story, something must have changed in the inner or outer life of the hero. That's the archetypal story arc in Western culture.

Throughout his life, beginning well before he won worldwide acclaim for his novels, Kurt Vonnegut ruminated about the form our stories take. "The shape of a given society's stories is at least as interesting as the shape of its pots or spearheads," he wrote in his autobiography, summarizing his master's thesis on "story shapes" for an anthropology degree at the University of Chicago. The department rejected his thesis, but he never forgot what he called his "prettiest contribution."

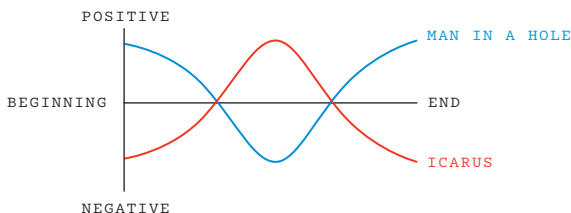
Years later, Vonnegut mused about how great it would be if artificial intelligence could graph the plots of stories. "There is no reason why the simple shapes of stories can't be fed into

computers,” he said in a famous lecture. “They are beautiful shapes.” In 2016, following up on the late novelist’s suggestion, data scientists at the University of Vermont and the University of Adelaide, in Australia, put 1,327 English-language works of fiction through statistical computations of “sentiment analysis.” They tracked the emotional valence of each story by counting previously identified “happy” words such as *laughter*, *excellent*, and *joy* and “unhappy” words such as *murder*, *cancer*, and *death*. The data analytics revealed that more than 1,000 fictional works could be captured in just six story arcs, which are easily grasped in three pairs.

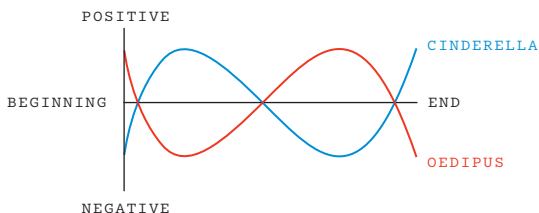
In the first pair, a curving line rises from the lower left to the upper right (the Rags-to-Riches story) or falls from the upper left to the lower right (Tragedy, or Riches to Rags):



The next two involve a change in trajectory: What seemed like a good idea at the time doesn’t pan out (rise then fall, as in the myth of Icarus), or triumph is snatched from defeat (fall then rise, nicknamed Man in a Hole).



The third set involves more complex stories that include two inflection points in the hero’s prospects: fall-rise-fall, as exemplified by Oedipus, and rise-fall-rise, nicknamed Cinderella.



Robyn Fivush and two Emory colleagues, Robert Thorstad and Matthew Graci, wondered whether our personal narratives might echo these same fictional story arcs. When weaving our little after-dinner stories, most of us probably try to offer a bit of drama, intuiting that a flat recitation of this-happened-then-this-happened will not captivate our listeners. Without revealing what they were looking for, the Emory researchers invited volunteers to

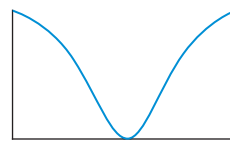
write down their “most positive experience” and “most traumatic experience.” They also solicited anonymous personal narratives online, enabling them to analyze 3,000 personal narratives from more than 500 subjects (each participant wrote multiple narratives).

“People shared really intimate things about themselves,” Thorstad, who is now a data scientist for *The Wall Street Journal*, told me. “Some contained physical or sexual violence; some conveyed strong tragedies. We didn’t tell the subjects we were interested in story shape. They didn’t have to tell a story. They could have just narrated—*This happened first and this happened next*—with no emotional shape, just a flat line.”

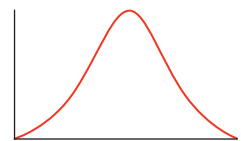
The researchers subjected the personal narratives to data-analytic techniques similar to those applied to fictional narratives. The same classic story arcs materialized. The large majority of personal narratives “were well characterized by the same 6 emotional arcs that emerged in a recent large-scale analysis of English-language cultural fiction,” they reported. Nonprofessional writers, sharing thousands of deeply personal accounts of key life episodes, instinctively chose those same six story shapes.

Within that discovery lay another: Everyday storytellers liked two of the arcs best. “I came into this study thinking that Rags to Riches and Tragedy were going to be common,” Thorstad said. “But people prefer story arcs with one emotional inflection point: Man in a Hole or Icarus.”

MAN IN A HOLE



ICARUS



While the researchers haven’t yet analyzed this preference, my hunch would be that these one-inflection-point story shapes offer greater drama than the simple uphill or downhill slopes of Rags to Riches and Tragedy, while the greater complexity of the two-inflection-point plots, Oedipus and Cinderella, exceed the casual skill set of most raconteurs. We can’t all be Sophocles. Or Walt Disney. Or Kurt Vonnegut.

3.

MEMORY AND RESILIENCE

“Shape,” Thorstad told me, “changes the overall sentiment of the story.”

That’s the essence of a body of research in the field of narrative psychology. “We study the arc within a given memory,” Dan McAdams, the Northwestern psychology professor, told me. “Let’s say a person describes a turning point, like: ‘I got fired from my first job, went into a depression, and couldn’t talk to anybody for three weeks. But I crawled out of it, and a year later,

I landed a fabulous position and haven't looked back.' We call that a 'redemptive' sequence."

That's Man in a Hole. "Somebody gets into trouble, gets out of it again" is how Vonnegut described it in his lecture. "People love that story. They never get sick of it."

Its opposite, the "contamination" sequence, describes a negative episode that ruins everything. "In a contamination sequence, everything is going beautifully at the start," McAdams said. "She was the love of my life. We were going to be together forever. We were happy. Then I woke up Monday morning and she was gone, and I'm never going to find love again."

"Every life story is filled with different sorts of scenes. We've found that people whose narratives include a lot of redemptive arcs tend to have higher psychological well-being. People whose life stories contain a higher density of contamination narratives tend to show higher levels of depression and lower levels of well-being."

Of course, some people face more painful setbacks and disasters in life than others. "Someone who's had a horribly difficult life could have a harder time framing redemptive sequences," McAdams said. "But we look at the interpretation: What kind of meaning does a person derive from difficult events? Some people tend to go through life interpreting things in a positive way, making redemption sequences where they can, even in difficult circumstances."

"I'm not convinced we *store* our memories as narratives," Fivush told me. "The neurobiology and neurochemistry of memory suggest that our memories are stored in dynamic, fluid pieces. When we are in the process of reassembling a memory, we have these story shapes also stored and available to us."

"The particular form we give a memory depends on the context," she said. "For example: When you're telling a sad story, most Americans will demand a redemptive end. They'll say, 'But you learned something about yourself, didn't you?'"

Vickie Scheer, 73, a retired educator in Atlanta, shared an episode of loneliness redeemed by kindness. Hating the social isolation of lockdown, she said, she sat on her front porch and called "Hi, neighbor!" to random passersby, including a couple walking their dog. "The woman had red hair on one side and a shaved head on the other, and they both were covered in tattoos. They always said hello back. I found out they were dog-walkers. One day I was taking out the trash just as they were passing by. They asked how I was that day. I burst into tears and said, 'Today not so good.' The woman said, 'You are grieving, I understand.' I told them their kindness made all the difference in the world to me. They promised to stop by every Monday to check on me."

Many folks, mid-pandemic, described still-unfolding situations. Fivush cautions that the final shape of a story we tell now might not be known yet. She categorizes narratives of events in progress simply as "unfinished."

As for my canceled trip to visit my grandson, I haven't seen him yet; still, I'll categorize my own story arc not as Icarus (that would make me too sad) but as "unfinished."

IN DENVER, Alex Enurah and Lynn VanderWielen's story began to take a turn for the better. As Alex told me, "One day, I noticed: *Well, it doesn't seem like things are actually getting worse right this*

minute. So that's good. They moved me out of ICU back to a regular floor. A few colleagues stopped by to visit, everyone fully geared up. They'd try not to make me laugh, because laughing made my oxygen shoot down ... After a few more days, they said I could quarantine at home."

"He was cleared on the first day of May, and I went into labor on May 4," Lynn said. "If you look at your whole lifetime, four days is so insignificant, but it was significant for us. We delivered Ida at 12:05 in the morning on the fifth of May, healthy, happy, screaming. She was wonderful from the first moment. And I did fine too."

"With the childbirth complications last time," Alex said, "and with my having recently come out of the hospital myself, I was just very ... on edge. It was a lot of emotion. You know, for the longest time I felt like I would not get to meet her, and then it's like, suddenly she's in the room and she's healthy. I had a lot of competing thoughts, including *Is this even real, or is this a dream?* Watching Lynn hold our baby, I honestly wondered if it was

STORIES WILL BE PASSED AROUND, TWEAKED, AND POLISHED UNTIL A SMALL NUMBER OF GEMS COME TO REPRESENT THIS IS WHAT IT WAS LIKE TO LIVE THROUGH THE CORONAVIRUS PANDEMIC.

possible that I had died and was somehow seeing this, you know, after ... It just took me a little bit of time to be able to process and appreciate everything."

"We didn't know if Alex would meet the baby," Lynn said. "And then here she was, healthy, and Hans was home asleep in his bed, so we were going to get to be a family again. Honestly, it was surreal, like this outcome hadn't been on the list of possible choices."

I asked Robert Thorstad what his research might allow him to predict about how we'll talk about our COVID-era memories in the future. "The obvious implication is that, whatever story we tell, it's not going to be a linear story from good to bad or from bad to good. It's not going to be: 'My life was great, and then COVID-19 ruined it.' It's going to have inflection points. And narrative psychologists tell us that the shape of story a person chooses can help lead to greater resilience and better outcomes."

"If you land well after a difficult incident," Fivush agreed, "you're more likely to give it a redemptive arc. And if you give a difficult episode a redemptive arc, you're more likely to land well. It's not tautological; it's transactional. They influence each other, like: *The better I cope, the more I can create positive meaning out of my experience* and *The more I can create positive meaning out of my experience, the better I cope*. This is why psychotherapy asks patients, 'What's a different way to think about this?'"

We're surviving an incredibly difficult period, many of us tucking brutal, sad, or frightening memories into long-term storage. But whether alone or with input from others, we may be able to flip over some of our Icarus "contamination" sequences into Man in a Hole "redemptive" sequences, giving ourselves a boost. "You can't just change your story by deciding to do it in a second," Fivush said. "For really difficult challenges, it takes time to rework your understanding. People might ask if you're over your grief after two months. No, it takes years. But it can be done."

IDA ENURAH IS a jolly baby, with a broad, smiley face like her dad's.

"It took a long time for Alex to sound like himself, even when he came home from the hospital," Lynn told me via Zoom. "Once he was home he told me they'd been really worried about him."

"I'd never been that sick, realizing how close I was to possibly dying," Alex told me. "Things are good now. But that experience put me in a very dark place for a long while. When I returned to work, I was afraid. There was a fear of being exposed to COVID again, wondering if I'd have a more severe reaction the second time and need to be intubated immediately. I had a hard time passing the ICU room I'd been in. It gave me a sick feeling. A visceral response. To this day I try to detour around that section. I'd never even been hospitalized before. It puts my work in a quite different light. It makes the conversations about death and dying with patients and families more difficult and more personal."

"But, I mean, we're home, we're healthy," Lynn said. "We have two healthy kids. I feel like I'm—I don't know if *proud* is the right word, but I feel like I did a good job."

There are overlapping narrative arcs in this family's story: two protagonists with the same goal, that everyone should survive, but different battles to fight. Alex was fighting for his life. Lynn feared that labor and delivery would throw her into another fight for her life and that COVID-19 could threaten the life of her unborn child, while she did her best to keep 2-year-old Hans's life stable.

"I see a redemptive arc in Lynn's story," Fivush told me. "Ida was born, she's happy and healthy; we're nesting, everything's great. Some redemption stories are just a return to homeostasis: *I got through it and normal life has been restored*. Alex says he is still processing; his story may be different in another year or two, depending upon how the nation emerges from the pandemic. His narrative is unfinished."

"WE ALL KNOW in our bones that this plague year is an epic year," Dan McAdams told me. "Not a day goes by without the proliferation of redemptive stories about the coronavirus.

Some are dramatic stories of recovery, starring nurses and first responders who minister to the victims, and starring those victims who manage to come back from the precipice. Others find unexpected benefits in the shutdowns: Families are eating dinners together now, the skies are less polluted, communities pull together. In the United States, progressives may imagine that the crisis will ultimately usher in universal health care or a Green New Deal. They invoke the story of America's overcoming the adversity of the Great Depression and World War II to emerge as a stronger and more egalitarian society.

"But not everyone will be able to tell a redemptive narrative," he continued. "The suffering is too great. It might be a year where more people are inspired to take the path of Albert Camus' protagonist in *The Plague*, Dr. Bernard Rieux. He wasn't able to save many people, and he couldn't begin to say what it all meant, and the loss of thousands of people didn't appear to be pointing a way to a better life for the survivors. By the end of *The Plague*, you come to believe, with Rieux, that at least it meant something for him to bear witness; he bore witness to suffering. Not every story is redemptive—there are other kinds of great stories in the world, and bearing witness is an important one. It's possible that's the best most of us can do this year. Sometimes you just have to come to terms with the world as it is, and to human beings as they are, rather than how we wish the world and people were."

Perhaps Dr. Enurah's role is like Dr. Rieux's: to bear witness. He has seen the worst of COVID-19 from beside hospital beds, and then in them. He did his best to help preserve life, even to the point of nearly losing his own.

I asked him whether there was anything else he thought he might remember about the pandemic, and he instantly offered this episode: "My colleague Dr. Timothy Bedient was the one who admitted me to the ICU. He was doing the history and physical, asking me questions about my past and all that. I felt like I had the plague; people suited up before entering my room; at home I hadn't been able to hold Hans or get close to my wife. But at the end of our conversation—it was a very brief gesture—Tim put his hand on my shoulder. He said, 'Alex, we are going to figure this out. I think this is going to be okay.' And to me, that was the most meaningful moment of that whole time—the fact that he put his hand on my shoulder meant the world to me. I was feeling nothing but fear, and it felt like he crossed a barrier to be with me."

It's a representative moment of the pandemic era, of a type that might emerge as a theme in many of our tales: that, in the worst of times, even as many people surprised us with their indifference, ignorance, racism, and aggression, other people—some of them friends and colleagues, some total strangers—managed to cross barriers and offer us kindness, compassion, alliance, and strength. *A*

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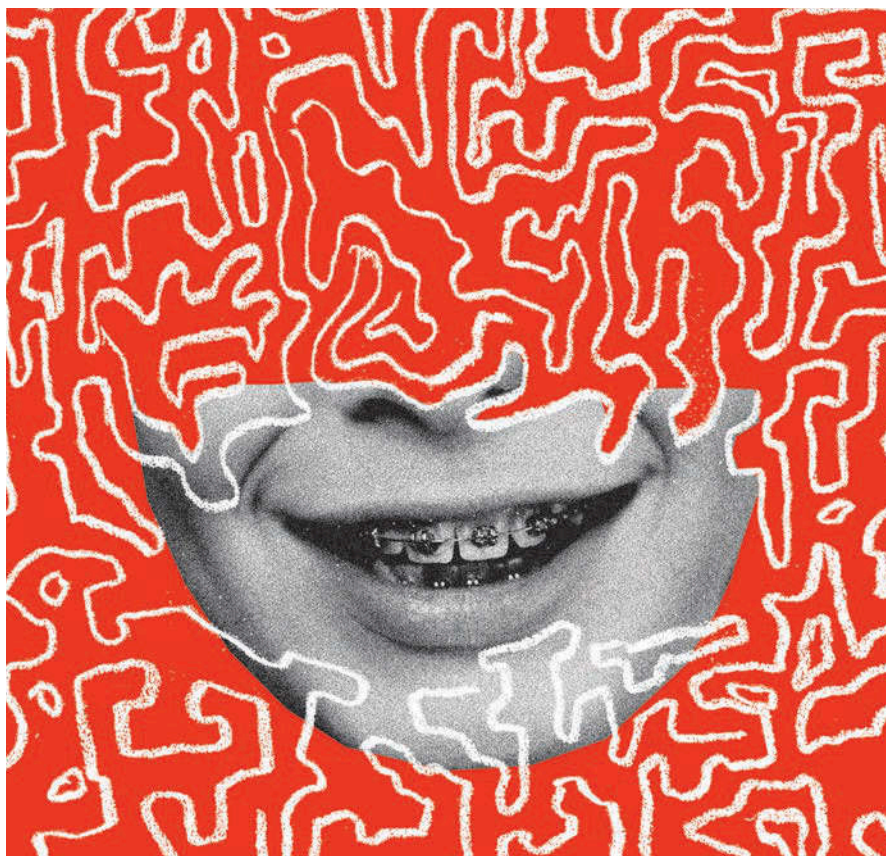
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Culture & Critics



OMNIVORE

Hormone Monsters

Television turns to magical realism to explore the trials of early adolescence.

By Megan Garber

Embarrassment makes for rich literature, but few fictions I can think of capture humiliation with the brute efficiency of “Traumarama.” The series, which ran for a time in *Seventeen* magazine, offered true stories written by, and for, teenagers—three or so lines, poetic in their brevity, about unruly bodies and unforgiving worlds. Crushes were a common topic. So were pimples and periods. White pants, in the world of “Traumarama,” were Chekhov’s gun.

The series was silly. As a kid, I loved it anyway. It offered commiseration and catharsis. Its mini-melodramas were tales of embarrassment that, in the end, defied embarrassment: How mortifying should any of this be, if so many others were living through it, too?

Newly in need of balm during topsy-turvy years, I’ve found it in television shows that have been asking the same question—in particular, a crop of current series that bring exuberant candor to their depictions of growing up. *PEN15*, the critical darling now in its second season on Hulu, chronicles the victories and humiliations of two best friends as they start seventh grade in the year 2000. *Stranger Things*, the Netflix smash hit set in and celebrating the 1980s, makes use of genres well suited to examining the out-of-body quality of puberty: science fiction, mystery, horror. *Big Mouth*, also on Netflix, follows the fortunes of a group of present-day middle schoolers. A crucial element of that show’s success—it recently completed Season 4 of a run that will span at least six seasons—is that it focuses, with Traumaramic intensity, on the turmoils of early adolescence.

CHRISTINE SCHNEIDER / BRIGITTE SPORER / GETTY

Exploring a time of life that ends but never leaves, the shows are wonderfully weird, even cartoonish (*Big Mouth* is an actual cartoon). But they are deeply earnest, too. They understand that this phase, to those who are living through it, can feel like a chronic emergency. And they have arrived, in their considerations of coming of age, at a singular conclusion: The best way to capture puberty's reality, it turns out, is to embrace its surrealism.

"YOU GUYS, STOP. This is, like, so mean. Just tell her." It's the first day of seventh grade, and Maya Ishii-Peters has spent a few blissful hours thinking that her status in school, and therefore in life, is changing for the better: Brandt, a popular kid, is rumored to like her. So, for that matter, is his friend. All around Trailview Middle School, hand-lettered signs have been popping up: BRANDT LOVES MAYA. DUSTIN LOVES MAYA. She and her best friend, Anna Kone, discuss the news, thrilled. Then the guys materialize. "UGIS!" Dustin shouts at Maya. Brandt joins in. "UGIS!" The girls are confused—*Yoojiss?*—until Becca, a mean girl who thinks herself kind, volunteers an explanation.

"Oh, honey, don't you know?" she says to Maya. "It means 'ugliest girl in school.'"

PEN15's camera focuses tightly on Maya's face as she registers this information. Time, in the show's world, stops. Taunts of "UGIS!" echo, in sneering slo-mo, in the distance. You feel, through the screen, the pain that is lodging itself inside this very young person—pain that will likely remain for a long time to come. She's trying so hard not to cry.

"It's cool," Maya says finally, as the tears well up anyway. "Yeah, yeah, yeah. No, that's really funny. Thanks for telling me, Becca."

This is not the kind of moment you might expect from a show that bills itself as a wacky comedy. But it's precisely the kind that makes *PEN15* so compelling. Childhood and adulthood, humor and tragedy, maelstrom and magic—they collide with barely controlled chaos. *PEN15*'s primary gag is that Maya and Anna are played by two of the show's creators, Maya Erskine and Anna Konkle, who are in their 30s, while most of their classmates are played by age-appropriate actors. It's a gimmick that comes to read as an insight: Rarely has the feeling of not fitting in, and of being awkward at your core, been so neatly visualized.

PEN15 delights in recalling the specific indignities of the early aughts (the cargo pants, the screech of the dial-up modem, the brief ubiquity of NSYNC). Its focus, though, is puberty's more generalized insult. Here you'll be treated to intermittent close-ups of braces and zits and female shins covered

You'll be treated to intermittent close-ups of braces and zits and female shins covered in yeti-thick fur.

in yeti-thick fur, images exaggerated into demented Dadaism. You'll find bodies made whimsically alien. Maya removes her retainer; you hear the sucking sound of saliva against the plastic. Anna has her first kiss, and the milestone is portrayed through a montage of body parts: the boy's slurping tongue; Anna's shock-widened eyes; the back of her hand, when it's all over, wiping away the wetness.

The effect of the scene is, to be clear, horrifying; I have a pretty high tolerance for gross-out humor, and even I found myself covering my eyes. But awkwardness, in *PEN15*, operates as an ethic. American culture, when it's not tricking them into growing up too quickly, often treats girls around Anna and Maya's age as objects of mystery and mockery. (The term *tween* is its own reason to cringe.) *PEN15*'s audacities are, in that sense, corrective. The show offers its young characters the elemental dignity of seeing them as they are. It understands how possible it is, at their age or any other, for the surreal to be profoundly true.

And so *PEN15* feels the girls' feelings along with them. It swings its moods on their behalf. It lives within their whiplash. Maya throws a tantrum in one moment and gets her period in another. Anna plays with dolls and then gossips, with a practiced indifference, about sex. Both girls want nothing more than to fit in, right until they want nothing more than to stand out. You can't help but feel tenderness for them. But their show will remind you that tenderness itself has a double valence: love, yes, but also pain. *Thanks for telling me, Becca.*

IF DOUBLENESS is a theme of *PEN15*, it is, in Matt and Ross Duffer's ode to early adolescence, a geography. *Stranger Things* gives us Hawkins, Indiana, a fictional town where a group of delightfully nerdy preteens ride their bikes and listen to cassette tapes and play Dungeons & Dragons. But lurking underneath their sleepy suburbia, they soon discover, is an anti-world—a darkly detailed inversion of home. The Upside Down, as the kids come to call it, is an apt metaphor for puberty precisely because it's such a visceral one. This is a place of muscly monsters, rancid odors, and, it must be noted, quite a lot of ooze. It is a place where children, if the monsters have their way, go to die.

It is a place, consequently, of profound disorientation. Will, a soft-eyed boy who has traveled to the Upside Down, tries to describe to his best friend, Mike, how it feels to be back. "You know how on a View-Master," Will says, "when it gets, like ..."

"Caught between two slides?" Mike asks.

"Yeah," Will replies. "Yeah, like that."

Big Mouth has monsters too. But they roam places even more unsettling than viscous anti-worlds: the

bodies of the kids at Bridgeton Middle School. The show's Hormone Monsters are molecules made manifest: Hirsute and humanoid, and also vaguely bovine, they cause puberty and then coach kids through it. One of them, voiced by Maya Rudolph, is named Connie. Another is named Maurice. As Andrew, Jessi, Missy, Nick, and their peers venture further into seventh grade and beyond, the monsters act as both mentors and menaces. And they are joined, as episodes unfold, by other embodiments of adolescent agita: the Depression Kitty, the Anxiety Mosquito, the Shame Wizard (a specter with a British accent and a dour demeanor who appears at inopportune moments to remind the kids of their "fundamental otherness").

Did I mention that *Big Mouth* is extremely weird? This is puberty rendered as magical realism. But *Big Mouth*'s surreality, as in the other shows, is a way of seeing. So is the series' bawdiness: Animation offers the freedom to go gonzo. *Big Mouth* is, quite often, filthy. It discusses—and depicts, in graphic if parodic detail—periods and pubic hair and erections and masturbation. It is blunt about bodies in a way that is mostly refreshing and occasionally disgusting.

But there is grace in the grossness. *Big Mouth*, for all its antics, is abidingly protective of its kids. Warmth is woven into its conception. Nick, always anxious that he's falling behind in the race to grow up, is a version of *Big Mouth*'s co-creator Nick Kroll. (Kroll also voices the character.) Andrew is based on another co-creator, Andrew Goldberg. The show features many other such blurrings of fact and fiction, among them an episode in which Maya and Anna leap over from the *PEN15* universe to voice *Big Mouth* versions of themselves. The Duffer brothers do not star in *Stranger Things*; they have suggested, however, that the show's fluorescent nostalgia is an outgrowth of what their lives were like when the Hormone Monsters came for them.

The creators of these shows are compassionate toward the kids because, in a direct sense, they are those kids. The magic here is human, and humane; everyone, on some level, is the child they once were. Everyone can be upended in an addled world. Everyone deserves some tenderness. These cathartic comedies came to life in a moment of deep anxiety about empathy itself—a moment of cruelties and rumors, loneliness and fear, Beccas and Brandts. The shows have instructed, and warned. To watch them is to feel once again the great hope of young adolescence: *Please let this just be a phase.* *A*

Megan Garber is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

The Beautiful Things By Elizabeth Spires

*As long as one knows the appeal of the qin,
what is the need for the sound of the strings?*

— Attributed to Tao Yuanming, 365–427

In the museum, I looked at
the beautiful things, one after another,
so many I could not take them all in.
Then I sat in the inner pavilion, clouds
moving overhead, the pages of my book blank.

Because I could not see as I wanted to see.
I was beyond beauty. I was beyond seeing.
What is the point of a museum?
What is the point of being?
To believe only that I disbelieve?

*Elizabeth Spires's most recent collection is
A Memory of the Future (2018).*

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BOOKS

The Power of the First Lady

How Lady Bird Johnson and Nancy Reagan advanced their husbands' ambitions—and their own

By Liza Mundy

Of the many images that lingered after the January inauguration of President Joe Biden—the twinkling hand gestures of the poet Amanda Gorman, the rakish eyebrow-waggling of the second daughter, Ella Emhoff—one of the more subtly significant was the scene of Doug Emhoff trying to figure out which side of his wife, Vice President Kamala Harris, to stand on. As the first and second couples moved to ascend the Capitol steps, Emhoff stood to her left; changed his mind and dashed to her right; then sort of bobbled, hesitating, before settling at her left. In an otherwise scripted and sober ceremony, the shuffle injected a spontaneous note as the second gentleman sought his place—not sure quite what that place was.

Welcome to the club, any number of women might have told him. Emhoff joined a long line of female political spouses who have struggled, in a larger sense, to figure out where they should be and what they should do. With a key difference: For wives, the choices have almost always elicited harrumphing from some quarter or another—as the ruckus over Dr. Jill Biden's use of her well-earned honorific served to remind us. Emhoff's little side step of uncertainty got raves. “It's just so cute!” exclaimed Jessica Jones, a viewer who entertainingly narrated the viral moment on TikTok. And she's right—it was.

As our vision of high-level political partnership gets a reboot (the first-ever first lady who's not giving up her career, the first-ever second gentleman), it seems a good time to recall just how undefined the role of unelected spouse has been. We tend to date a modern shift to 1992, when Bill Clinton proposed a two-for-the-price-of-one presidency with Hillary. But the unpaid

behind-the-scenes partner has been with us a long time, and the deal has never been straightforwardly feminist, as two new biographies of first ladies reveal.

In *Lady Bird Johnson: Hiding in Plain Sight*, Julia Sweig argues that for all her mid-century Betty Crocker flip curls, Bird (as her husband called her) had a “disarmingly modern” partnership with the president. She worked hard to be a “fully engaged participant” in Lyndon B. Johnson's career, and while his biographers have rarely emphasized her centrality, Johnson himself certainly did. As did she: “Our presidency,” Lady Bird called it. In *The Triumph of Nancy Reagan*, the *Washington Post* columnist Karen Tumulty likewise invokes a teammate without whom her spouse would never have been governor of California, much less president of the United States. Tumulty makes the case that over the course of Ronald's political career, Nancy “grew to understand her power.” Wielding their clout, the two first ladies could hardly be a greater study in contrasts—even as they shared a priority: vigilantly protecting their spouse above all, but also their own access and influence.

BORN IN 1912 and 1921, respectively, Lady Bird and Nancy both belonged to a generation sandwiched between two feminist movements. Both had lively, unconventional mothers who supported women's suffrage—and yet both girls grew up during a time when second billing (or none) was a wife's lot, even in the most collaborative marital enterprises. Young Claudia Alta Taylor, nicknamed Lady Bird by a nanny (or playmate—exactly who isn't certain), was 5 when she lost her mother. The adventurous and well-read Minnie





Taylor died after a fall while pregnant. Lady Bird—the youngest child and only daughter of a wealthy East Texas businessman—took refuge, Sweig writes, in a rich “inner life that taught her how to take emotional sustenance from nature and books.” An excellent student, she earned a history degree in 1933 from the University of Texas at Austin, in an era when only a small percentage of women graduated from college; she then spent a year completing a journalism degree. Lyndon Johnson, an up-and-coming congressional staffer, instantly sized her up as the sort of smart, capable partner who would push him and expand his prospects. He proposed at the end of their first date, then launched a full-court press until she yielded after 10 weeks. “The wife, your wife, is the most important asset you’ll have,” he declared.

For her part, Lady Bird discovered that marriage promised her broader horizons than the teaching job she had envisioned. With her family’s money as a seed investment, she helped build an empire of Texas media and business holdings. She also used her inheritance to finance Lyndon’s successful bid for a House seat in 1937 and, in the years following, helped cultivate what she termed “our political machine.” During World War II, when LBJ was on active duty in the Pacific, she ran his congressional office. After he ascended to the Senate in 1948, she became a force in the Senate Wives Club, a group of spouses who exercised a sort of soft power in postwar Washington’s political life. The city was well stocked with influential women. At a time when the National Press Club barred female reporters, the Women’s National Press Club provided a home for the city’s contingent. An extraordinary group of Black women helped propel the civil-rights movement. In this busy milieu, Lady Bird was, she said, “so happy being the wife of the senator from Texas.”

So happy was she—and so aware of how her husband would chafe at a subordinate role—that when John F. Kennedy drafted LBJ as his running mate in 1960, she made the case for not accepting. But like his other advisers, she bowed to the inevitability of saying yes and fully entered into the campaign. The former majority leader’s power shrank while Lady Bird’s official ambit expanded to include public appearances, both on the campaign trail, where she stood in for a pregnant Jackie Kennedy, and as second lady. In the stunned aftermath of the Kennedy assassination, she sought out Jackie: “I tried to express something of how we felt. I said, ‘Oh, Mrs. Kennedy, you know we never even wanted to be Vice President and now, dear God, it’s come to this.’”

It is startling to realize that, for the 14 months from November 1963 to January 1965, Lady Bird Johnson effectively *was* the vice president. LBJ, serving out JFK’s term, did not have a VP. Both Johnsons knew they had to “seize the momentum of the

national tragedy” and rapidly push through a progressive agenda, which soon became known as the Great Society. Particularly involved in the War on Poverty, Lady Bird braved the consequences of the entire mission: The first presidential wife to act as a true surrogate, she made a whistle-stop tour of the South during the 1964 contest—not just his advocate, but his protector. “Let me take the tough ones,” she said, shouldering what was “arguably the hardest, most thankless, and personally riskiest task” of the campaign, Sweig writes, given the hate and outrage among many white southerners after the passage of the Civil Rights Act.

Still, tandem toil was one thing; staking out too much terrain for herself was another. In her East Wing policy shop, Lady Bird began to build a portfolio of environmental policies, working with Interior Secretary Stewart Udall. She brought Jane Jacobs to the White House, and conferred with other urban planners and environmental thinkers. But forswearing potentially polarizing talk of urban renewal and land stewardship, Lady Bird spoke of “beautification,” though she had mixed feelings about the word. “I’ll never forgive Lyndon’s boys for turning my environmental agenda into a beautification project,” she said. “But I went ahead and talked about wildflowers so as not to scare anybody, because I knew if the people came to love wildflowers they’d have to eventually care about the land that grew ’em.”

And behind her rightful insistence on *we* lay a more painful bargain. Lyndon Johnson belonged to a generation of men who regarded sex as a perk of power. Like any number of female Kennedys, like Coretta Scott King, like the *Washington Post* publisher Katharine Graham, and like others then (and since), Lady Bird suffered the humiliation of her husband’s flagrant infidelity. Sweig posits that she coped with the insecurity by making herself “increasingly indispensable.” LBJ struggled with depression—Lady Bird called it the “Valley of the Black Pig,” quoting Yeats—and more so as the Vietnam War took an immense psychological toll. She shored up his self-doubt and rallied his spirits—and her own. (Who else was going to take care of her? So she swam laps and hiked.) She listened, and she empathized with his agonized decisions. She shared his belief in American exceptionalism and defended his policies, digging in as protesters challenged the escalation of the war.

FOR NANCY REAGAN, *we* meant a combative us-against-them partnership that betrayed a different kind of insecurity, Tumulty’s biography suggests. Nancy’s mother, Edie Davis, was a stage actor whose glamorous social life included Spencer Tracy and Mary Martin. Worldly and colorful, even late in life, Edie was not above using a word like *cocksucker* (in this

case, to describe Barry Goldwater). She and Nancy’s feckless biological father had effectively separated before their daughter was born; in early girlhood, Nancy was lodged with an aunt and uncle while her mother sought gigs. Nancy longed for a more conventional home life. “I always wanted someone to take care of me, someone I could take care of,” she said, a yearning fulfilled when she met Ronnie, in 1949. “I had a career when I got married and very gladly gave it up,” she later explained, referring to her own brief foray into acting. “I think a woman’s real happiness and fulfillment is found in her home.”

But Nancy had no appetite for cozy calm in the White House. Unlike her conflict-averse husband, she played the ruthless enforcer, conducting feuds and engineering firings. Her motivation was not to expand her own portfolio: She wanted only to promote her husband’s “well-being and success,” ferociously tending him and his image. Tumulty calls theirs an “epic love” story, an observation confirmed by the eyewitness accounts of many. But one might also diagnose a codependent partnership between two people

For the 14 months from November 1963 to January 1965, Lady Bird Johnson effectively was the vice president.



Previous page: Lady Bird Johnson on the campaign trail with LBJ in 1960. Above: Nancy Reagan on the stump with her husband days before the November 1980 election.

who felt abandoned in childhood—Reagan’s father was an alcoholic—and formed a profoundly anxious attachment. They hated to spend nights apart, and famously (or infamously) called each other Mommie and Daddy. Ronnie affirmed her through flirtatious quips and love letters; her love language was acts of service, chief among them the act of protection.

For all her devotion (including, or especially, when he developed Alzheimer’s disease), Nancy emerges in the biography as a disruptive force, to put it mildly, in the political life they shared, particularly on staffing matters. She was quick to suspect that aides might be serving their own interests before his—and she wasn’t always wrong. When she called his campaign office early on, one operator said, “The bitch is on the phone again.” In the margins of my copy, I began tracking all the people she set herself against. “She doesn’t really like dealing with women,” White House Deputy Chief of Staff Michael Deaver noted, in an understatement. My marginalia included “NR v Helene von Damm” (Reagan’s secretary in California, who rose to become a diplomat and considered Nancy a “schemer”), “NR v Betty Ford,” “NR v Barbara Bush,” “NR v Raisa Gorbachev” (“an instant loathing”), “NR v Barbara Sinatra.” Then again, she didn’t really like dealing with many men: “NR v Ed Meese,” “NR v William Clark,” “NR v James Watt,” “NR v Al Haig,” “NR v Pat Buchanan.” At varying times, she clashed with Ronnie’s children from his first marriage—Michael and Maureen—and with theirs, Patti and Ron. (“You had to be wary of her,” Ron said.) Some staffers, like James Baker, understood her influence and made a point of getting along. Deaver did, too—as deputy chief of staff in the governor’s office, he had been tasked with what his colleagues called the “Mommy Watch,” charged with keeping her away from others.

And then there was “NR v Donald Regan,” the White House chief of staff she managed to oust after much mutual combat. He exacted revenge with a bombshell memoir revealing the extent to which the White House schedule was dictated by astrology. Regan, it emerged, had been obliged to devise a color-coded calendar signaling “good days” (green) and “bad ones” (red) for trips and meetings—based on consultations Nancy conducted with a San Francisco stargazer. (There was also yellow, for “iffy” ones.) Astrology was a compulsion, and the attempted assassination of her husband traumatized her, understandably, leading to even more hypervigilance. “I’m so scared,” she said. “I cringe every time we step out of a car.” The irony, as Tumulty points out, is that in allowing the president’s schedule to be determined by an unseen stranger who would know his movements, she left him more exposed, not less.

Nancy’s wary nature did have its upsides, which Tumulty emphasizes. During Reagan’s second term,

she saw the peril posed by the Iran-Contra scandal and hectored a stubbornly resistant Ronnie until, in a crucial speech to the American public, he admitted to the arms-for-hostages deal, and to his own mistake. Like Lady Bird, Nancy served as a mood regulator: She knew how well Reagan could perform when confident and relaxed, and her presence improved his performance. Tumulty credits her with appreciating the full potential of his powers of persuasion, and pushing him to negotiate with Mikhail Gorbachev to end the Cold War. As *The Washington Post’s* White House correspondent during the Reagan years, Lou Cannon, notes in a biography of the president, for all her talent for turmoil, Nancy “became a force for peace within the White House.”

TUMULTY WRITES about the “power that comes with intimacy”—the influence of the companion who is there in moments public and private, high and low—and some of the most arresting scenes in both books capture drama unfolding in pajamas, or not even. On Election Night 1980, Nancy was taking a bath, not expecting the race to be called before the polls closed in California. Suddenly, it was. She wrapped a towel around herself and got Ronnie out of the shower; dripping, they both stood watching TV as the news sank in that he had won in a landslide. During the Vietnam War, Lady Bird woke to hear President Johnson talking to himself in the early-morning darkness. She recalled his sleepless musings in her diary: “I don’t want to get in a war and I don’t see any way out of it. I’ve got to call up 6,000 boys, make them leave their homes and their families.” She doubted that others understood “the depth of his pain.”

For all their differences, what Lady Bird and Nancy shared—and Michelle Obama later struck the same note—was an abiding concern for the president’s well-being and very life. They witnessed the mortal pressures on what Nancy called the “flesh-and-blood person.” Both kept close watch on sleep, diet, and mental and emotional states—a wifely role, you could say, but is it? Someday, a first gentleman will be called upon to match that care and dedication. The woman who becomes president will bear the usual burdens of the office, plus an added weight: In public life, men are not the lightning rod women are. They just aren’t. So let the man use his privilege to shield and protect the woman, an old role deployed for a modern purpose. If the current second gentleman, or a future first one, wants advice on how to do it, and how not to, he has plenty of history to consult. *A*

Liza Mundy is the author, most recently, of Code Girls: The Untold Story of the American Women Code Breakers of World War II.

LADY BIRD
JOHNSON:
HIDING IN
PLAIN SIGHT

Julia Sweig

RANDOM HOUSE

THE
TRIUMPH
OF NANCY
REAGAN

Karen Tumulty

SIMON & SCHUSTER



The Human Side of Fracking

Living with the allure and danger of a lucrative, dirty industry

By Sarah Smarsh

In January, President Joe Biden canceled the Keystone XL pipeline and ordered a drilling moratorium on federal land. The following month, a historic cold snap and a failed power grid turned Texas into a disaster zone. Even as policy debates about events like these unfold, each one serves as a wake-up call. Our reliance on the fossil-fuel industry is by now so old and deep that overdue regulations, while crucial, will not stop consequences already set in motion. The man-made, carbon-wrought transformation of our climate is here.

As we grapple with this reality, rather than fixating on abstract concepts and quantitative measures—energy prices, geopolitics, emissions rates, climate-science projections—we would do well to zoom in, way in, on those doing and allowing the drilling. Their stories contain a common promise: *You'll make a lot of money*. Yet many lose, as do we all, in other ways before the bargain is closed. We can learn a lot from their ground-level wisdom about the human motives and exploitative economies that got us into this mess, as well as about the dangerous and toxic business of siphoning oil and gas from the earth below.

Two new books take us there. In *The Good Hand: A Memoir of Work, Brotherhood, and Transformation in an American Boomtown*, Michael Patrick F. Smith finds his checking account and personal demons intertwined with the oil industry. At the height of the Bakken

Formation oil boom, in 2013, Smith left Brooklyn seeking what he imagined would be challenging but lucrative work in the oil fields. A playwright and musician raised amid poverty and domestic abuse in rural Maryland, he never quite felt at home in gentrified Brooklyn or at his Midtown Manhattan office job that paid the bills. This identity crisis, combined with a penchant for self-punishment previously pursued through drugs and sex, sent him west to see whether he might finally make a man of himself at 36.

What he found in the now-infamous boomtown of Williston, North Dakota, was a cast of characters with even rougher pasts than his own. Smith's memoir is about these men, who showed up from across the country and beyond to risk their lives on a windswept plain where the temperature might be 38 degrees below zero and the pay might be \$20 an hour.

During his tenure in the oil patch, Smith worked as a truck driver's assistant, or swamper, for a rig-moving company. His face grew chapped and his body toughened as he threw chains beneath the immense North Dakota sky, but the question that looms over the narrative is whether his sense of self would be transformed. He was smaller and older than most of the men doing his low-ranking job; could he earn the respect of his supervisors—grizzled bastards who pegged him for a wuss and tried to run him off? Would he, in the parlance of those workers, make a good hand?

Smith stayed on for nine months, a fair bit longer than the proverbial journalistic parachute jump, and his pre-Trump-era mission was more personal than anthropological. Still, his most important contributions are not musings about what the experience meant to him but vivid descriptions of the experience itself. *The Good Hand's* scenes in "the patch" are beautiful, funny, and harrowing, constructed with metal hooks, workplace lingo, poetic profanity, and the author's palpable fear. (From 2008 through 2017, more than 1,500 oil-and-gas workers died from injuries sustained on the job, according to a report by the Center for Public Integrity. That amounts to, roughly, a death every other day.) As someone whose immediate family bears the scars of physical labor in another Great Plains state, and who rarely sees her native class convincingly portrayed, I relished these anecdotes and the validation they provide.

Smith's dangerous toil on the job mirrored a dangerous life outside work among the same hard men, some of whom were attracted to the area by the possibility of good pay with no background checks. (When Smith arrived at a flophouse, his highly common name—Mike Smith—alarmed the slumlord, who worried that he was another fugitive with an alias looking for a room.) Smith weaves in heartbreaking stories from his upbringing, and from the pasts of the men he came to

Top: An oil-rig crewmember at work in 2012, during the Bakken Formation oil boom in North Dakota. Middle: A pumpjack near Williston, North Dakota. Bottom: An oil worker.

know, implicitly making a compelling argument that busted men are tasked with busting the earth.

They all looked the same to Smith when he arrived, and trading stories of violent fathers was a standard icebreaker. “The conversation,” Smith writes, “can be boiled down to two short sentences: ‘What kind of work you do? Man, my dad whipped my ass!’ I come to think of it as The Williston Hello.” But soon he found the workers he met there to be as distinct as his artsy friends back in Williamsburg. One stood in a “perpetual wrestling stance,” feet planted wide and muscles on alert. Another recalled being struck by a heavy object with such force that his intestines were forced out of his anus. These workers—mostly white men, like Smith, but some Indigenous men and men of color as well—were at once deeply exhausted and wired on chewing tobacco and energy drinks. They had a brother in prison, or a brother who’d died in Iraq. They went by handles like “Smash” and “Big Country.”

In such an environment, bravado is a survival tool, and Smith played the part while quietly detecting fellow sensitives, including a big 21-year-old named Huck with whom he formed a bond. Such glimpses of male intimacy flowering in harsh conditions are moving. Not every tough guy has a soft side, though, and Williston was rife with bad actors. Smith was troubled by the long rap sheets of some of his new friends—but not troubled enough to skip bar and strip-club outings with them.

Women flit in and out of the story mostly as objects of fantasy or passing references—the young bartender at a local dive, his landlord’s girlfriend in another state, sex workers, strangers at the coffee shop where Smith wrote his experiences in real time. He admits that he knew little about these women, and their flatness in a book about a male world perhaps should not be faulted. A lack of context is sometimes problematic, though. The crisis of missing and murdered Indigenous women—an old problem receiving new attention, thanks to Interior Secretary Deb Haaland and others—has been linked to “man camps” populated by transient workers in the fossil-fuel industry. Reports of rape around Williston multiplied during the boom, Smith learned later, yet his few mentions of the term mostly concern fear of man-on-man rape. *The Good Hand*, as the subtitle suggests, is not just about labor but about masculinity—and it is often the toxic sort.

In one instance, Smith’s former landlord described a line of men on the stairs of his house “running a train on” a severely intoxicated woman within. In another, an erstwhile co-worker told Smith, over whiskey and cokes, about trying to persuade a sexual partner to let him prostitute her; she was, he said before offering Smith a cellphone recording of her giving him fellatio, “this close to letting me sell her ass.” Smith laughed

THE GOOD
HAND: A MEMOIR
OF WORK,
BROTHERHOOD,
AND TRANSFORMA-
TION IN
AN AMERICAN
BOOMTOWN

Michael
Patrick F. Smith

VIKING

UP TO HEAVEN
AND DOWN TO
HELL: FRACKING,
FREEDOM, AND
COMMUNITY
IN AN AMERICAN
TOWN

Colin Jerolmack

PRINCETON
UNIVERSITY PRESS

that his friend was “always saying some funny crazy shit,” and declined to watch the video. With the age and consent of the female in this anecdote unknown, and in a book about a place brimming with sex traffickers, I did not laugh with him.

Apparently knowing that the exchange was foul, Smith got a sick feeling, but soon he and the friend were goofing around taking pictures in the bar parking lot with Huck. By contrast, on the occasions when Smith witnessed racism, he named it, agonized over his closeness to it, phoned his brother to talk about how to handle it. Calling out damaging male behavior toward women was clearly a source of greater discomfort. Smith is in rare company, though, for daring to describe the behavior at all. One wishes for similar testimonies from other socioeconomic strata. The soft-handed men, say, who acquire the oil-drilling leases and decide in boardrooms that the pipeline will be laid alongside the reservation—where are their memoirs describing the sins of their sex, their race? The worker at the bottom is the most honest because he has the least to lose.

THE LANDOWNERS who happen to live atop fossil-fuel deposits occupy a world quite apart from that of transient laborers. It is, however, similarly fraught. To get to know that world, Colin Jerolmack, a professor of sociology and environmental studies at NYU, spent eight months in 2013 living in the fracking epicenter of Williamsport, Pennsylvania, population about 28,000. In *Up to Heaven and Down to Hell: Fracking, Freedom, and Community in an American Town*, which also reflects six years of follow-up research, he investigates individual and community values among those who have seen the United States’ quest for energy independence play out in their own backyard. Jerolmack wanted to understand how people weigh personal decisions—in this case, whether to permit drilling by gas companies—that ultimately affect neighbors, ecosystems, and even future generations.

In the U.S., real-estate ownership historically includes not just the surface of the land but its sub-surface, as well as the air above it. (The book’s title refers to the medieval Roman dictum said to mark the idea’s legal origins.) Governments elsewhere around the world wield much greater sway over mineral rights and other matters of public consequence on private land. Jerolmack’s many kitchen-table conversations with inhabitants of the formerly idyllic area of greater Williamsport—or “Billtown,” as it is called, best known as the host of the Little League World Series—reveal the tensions and trade-offs that follow from America’s liberty-loving ways.

In deciding whether to lease their land to natural-gas companies, Jerolmack learned, area residents

heard front-door sales pitches from landmen brokering mineral rights, attended contentious local-government meetings, and organized collective-bargaining efforts with their neighbors. Ultimately, most of them leaned on a conservative worldview: The two acres, or 200 acres, belonged to them, and they'd do as they damn well pleased. But for a true understanding of their hearts and minds, political frameworks prove inadequate.

Economic considerations were paramount, of course. For financially strapped homeowners, monthly royalty checks enabled a modest nest egg, a nice pickup, a new roof, their first dishwasher. Leasing allowed some to hold on to the family farm. One man poignantly described his wish to fund a college education for his granddaughter.

Those dreams came with a price, though, often concurrent with the royalty checks. Even adamant supporters of drilling admitted that it had wreaked havoc on their lives. The very things that had attracted them to the area—natural beauty, peace and quiet, dark skies full of stars—were stripped away once fracking moved in. For some, their immediate shelter suffered, too. Big rigs and earthmovers rattled one house until the chimney collapsed. In others, tap water turned cloudy. “Fracking is intimate,” Jerolmack writes. Some of the transgressed ended up silenced by nondisclosure agreements after reaching settlement deals. “They have us by the balls,” one such resident told Jerolmack.

Yet the judgmental “fractivism” of outsiders—Yoko Ono is among the many who have traveled from New York City to advocate for fracking bans in rural Pennsylvania—provoked understandable resentment. Natural gas, Jerolmack notes, powers more New York homes than any other energy source, and much of it comes from places like Billtown.

Jerolmack met just one person, he writes with admiration, “who regularly traversed the political, economic, and cultural divides” of Williamsport: Ralph Kisberg, who co-founded a local organization called the Responsible Drilling Alliance. He was the quintessential centrist, critical of fracking but more interested in efforts to mitigate its ill effects than in the far-off goal of ending it. Kisberg went to nearly every permit meeting, drove back roads to chat up landowners, compiled his findings in the group’s newsletter. This approach, an information blitz devoid of judgment, was the opposite of a bumper sticker and fostered constructive discussion where many an argument along national party lines breaks down.

Those party lines did not always predict gas-drilling decisions in Billtown. One area resident, Cindy Bower—a former schoolteacher who belonged to Kisberg’s anti-fracking advocacy group, held signs on the first Earth Day, in 1970; drove a Prius; and was married to a wealthy hotelier—shook Jerolmack’s assumptions.

*“New York
benefits from
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ever will.”*

She and her husband, who lived on 150 acres of hilly woods and fields with a big pond, had refused leasing pitches for three years. But as everyone around them leased, often for financial reasons that Bower did not begrudge, industry moved in and their quality of life deteriorated. In the end, Bower and her husband leased their land. She told Jerolmack with some sorrow that holding out had accomplished nothing, and the money was at least some compensation for what they had lost.

Jerolmack warns eco-conscious readers against feeling superior to either liberal Bower or her conservative neighbors. “To the extent that most of us continue to uncritically organize our lives around carbon-intensive energy sources,” he writes, “we are coconspirators.” To be spared the dire environmental impacts of our species is a privilege.

Environmental hazards of extractive industry impose a disproportionate burden on Indigenous people, people of color, and the poor: the radiation of a uranium mine, the smells of a refinery, the sometimes predatory men whom oil-drilling companies hire because a felon with no other job prospects is a loyal employee. Jerolmack’s own excrement, as he points out, might have moved from New York City on “poop trains” that traveled to Alabama landfills, fouling the air for small towns along its route.

One of the most memorable passages of *The Good Hand* offers a related insight. On a visit to New York, carousing with friends and “holding court, dazzling them with my oil field talk,” Smith suddenly saw anew the cabs, the streetlights, the petroleum-derived subway seats, the laminated menus:

New York benefits from the oil boom far more than Williston ever will. No one here realizes that. Nobody even considers it. Here in this West Village gastropub. Look at them. Everything they enjoy. Every. Single. Thing. They get it from me. They get it from me and a group of the toughest, meanest motherfuckers I have met in my life. Men they wouldn’t like, men they look down on, invisible men they will never see in a state they dismiss as flyover. They owe it all to the hands. All of it.

This is the age-old problem of hierarchy: Most people with the power to address social troubles—in this case, the destructive and unsustainable fossil-fuel industry—know very little about the toll they take at ground level. *A*

Sarah Smarsh is the author of Heartland: A Memoir of Working Hard and Being Broke in the Richest Country on Earth and She Come by It Natural: Dolly Parton and the Women Who Lived Her Songs.

BOOKS

The Awful Wisdom of the Hostage

What a new memoir reveals about endurance—and extreme remorse

By Graeme Wood



In October 2012, in the second year of the Syrian civil war, a 44-year-old freelance journalist named Theo Padnos crossed from Turkey into Syria with two young men he thought were his friends. Padnos made friends easily and indiscriminately: In 2006, he was in Yemen researching a book about foreign converts on the path of jihad, and he showed me around when I arrived in the country. Six years later, he remained gregarious and trusting. He made his way through the barbed wire into the war zone with these men he barely knew and a small backpack containing a notebook; a copy of *Dark Star Safari*, by Paul Theroux; and a can of Efes, the Budweiser of Turkey. He drank the beer alone and looked forward to the freedom of the open road in rebel territory. “Bliss was it in that dawn to be alive,” he thought to himself, channeling Wordsworth.

The next day, his guides announced that they were members of the local chapter of al-Qaeda and beat him senseless. Soon Padnos was soaked in blood and undergoing a regimen of physical and psychological torture that lasted nearly two years. (David G. Bradley, then *The Atlantic*’s sole owner and now the owner of a minority interest in the magazine, devoted considerable personal resources to the search for Padnos and several other Americans held hostage in Syria.)

Few who survive a long hostage ordeal can resist writing a book about it. Being gagged for years makes one voluble, and readers want to know what it’s like to live under the sword of Damocles. In books by hostages taken in the 1980s by Hezbollah and Islamic Jihad in Lebanon, certain themes emerge: the solace of religion, for Terry Waite and Terry Anderson, held from 1987 to 1991 and 1985 to 1991, respectively; the sanity-preserving humor and comradeship of fellow hostages, for Brian Keenan (1986 to 1990); and regret about choices the hostages had made in their lives before, as husbands and fathers, and sometimes just as humans on whom freedom was wasted while they had it. Most of us feel regret—but

not like this. No one would endure this intensity of introspection voluntarily. To read their books is to explore our failings and trot a few miles of their ultramarathon of remorse alongside them.

Padnos's memoir, *Blindfold: A Memoir of Capture, Torture, and Enlightenment*, is particularly grueling because its author courted risk so nonchalantly. In two previous books—the one about Yemen, and a memoir about teaching in a Vermont jail—he wrote about his acquaintance with wayward violent youth. (In each case he gets close but not too close, like a kid at the zoo in front of the tiger cage.) His happy-go-lucky curiosity led him to Syria. Raw material for that most self-indulgent modern cultural product, a personal essay about the experience of misery in a foreign land, was “the butterfly I had chased over the precipice,” he writes.

His abuse over the following two years is also a process of disabuse—a conversion from a bumbling, sunny aesthete into a nearly destroyed man who peered into an existential abyss and was shoved in headfirst. Real understanding of Syria, he had imagined, would come from living among Syrians, partaking in their poverty and privations. He'd fantasized about meeting journalistic “phonies”—the kind who covered the country without ever really knowing it—perhaps “in a sandwich shop ... or a collective taxi.” There he would deride them with his superior vernacular knowledge of the “chaotic but beautiful upending of the social order sweeping through the country.”

WHAT ENSUES is gory and disturbing, conveyed in prose that is simple, thoughtful, and unpretentious. His captors beat him and listed the sins for which they were repaying him. One of them screamed at him about “Guantánamo,” “Iraq,” “drones in Yemen,” and, less predictably but no less rationally, the genocide of the “Plains Indians.” First Padnos felt pain, then dissociation, then, ironically, more of the same curiosity that led him to Syria in the first place. *Why? And why me?* (Primo Levi wrote something similar about his first experience of being beaten by Nazi soldiers, en route to Auschwitz: Instead of pain, he felt bafflement and “profound amazement” at the sadism.) “How quickly one's fate presents itself,” Padnos thought to himself.

The group shifted him from prison to prison. His captors tortured him, took his bank-card PIN, and plotted ransom schemes. A typical torture session was a Syrian riff on an old technique called *bastinado*: Put the victim's knees through the middle of an old tire. Lock them in place with a stick, then flip him prone, with the soles of the feet pointing up—then thwack at them with steel cables until he confesses. Padnos's nominal crime was working for the CIA. Eventually he lied and confessed. The beating continued, and each confession proved only that another more

damning confession was just a few lashes away. Padnos spent hours chasing and squashing the bloodsucking insects that infested his clothes. He fondled a blindfold, perhaps a woman's veil, that his captors gave him. It was the only object he associated with tenderness or humanity. “It was long enough,” he writes, “when rolled into a rope, to work as a noose.”

What was the point? Torture is work, and hostages require care and feeding. He concluded that they wanted him to bear witness to this land haunted by terror, “to reckon with the spirit of the times.” Unlike most Western hostages, Padnos speaks Arabic and could understand the conversations of his captors. He learned that they loved both death and poverty, because both strip life to the raw. “The worse things are, the better. Hardship is meant to draw the nation closer to the Koran.” Al-Qaeda, he surmised, wanted a human archive, someone who could not deny or forget its handiwork if he tried. “Could I not see how powerful they had become?” he wondered. His captors' thoughts were invading his own. “Why would they have gone to such trouble if they weren't trying to make me see?”

I detect in his miserable confusion a version of theodicy—an attempt to justify the ways of these thugs who exerted quasi-divine authority over him. They tortured him as capriciously as God tortured Job. The indignities and cruelties were heaped upon him, and with them came even crueler ironies. Foreign correspondents are enjoined to speak the local languages and study the cultures they cover. Padnos's languages made him look like a spy and doomed him. “He will lie to you in five different languages,” one captor said. Padnos believes that one of his interrogators, a spitting madman who dug the edge of a knife into his throat, was none other than Abu Muhammad al-Adnani, the spokesperson and chief terrorist of the Islamic State. He asked why Padnos knew so much about Islam. “I wanted my captors to see my respect for their religion,” Padnos writes. “I rambled about medieval philosophy, the origins of Salafism, the Muslim Brotherhood, my struggles with Arabic grammar, and my interest in learning to recite the Koran.” Sometimes knowledge can get you killed. “In the midst of my speech, it occurred to me that I was establishing myself as a CIA specialist in extremist thought.”

The indignities were not always intentional—just wicked tricks of chance. Three months in, his captors threw into his cell a Long Island miscreant named Matthew Schrier, who had done time in the United States and come to Syria as a photojournalist. (Al-Qaeda believed that he was a photojournalist, not a spy, because unlike Padnos, Schrier had a business card identifying himself as a member of the press. Note to self: Order more business cards.) Padnos, bloody and lice-ridden, must have longed for companionship.

First Padnos felt pain, then dissociation, then, ironically, more of the same curiosity that led him to Syria in the first place.

Readers of the memoirs written after captivity in Lebanon will understand why. The Northern Irishman Brian Keenan's *An Evil Cradling* (probably the one most worth revisiting today) details movingly his situational friendship with fellow hostage John McCarthy, a British national.

Schrier and Padnos achieved no such rapport. Instead their relationship was existential torture. They rapidly found out just how different two men can be. Padnos, a cultured polyglot, had packed his middle-aged head with poetry. Schrier, by contrast, had memorized more than a dozen of his own violent, unproduced screenplays, and acted them out, one by one, for Padnos. "They were full of people being beaten and shot," Padnos writes. "I couldn't bear to listen. As he recited, I stuffed my fingers in my ears." (Schrier has written a hostage memoir too—the only one I have read that is almost wholly lacking introspection. It is filled with hate for Padnos, and gleefully vulgar. He describes meeting Padnos: "Are you a fag?" Schrier asks, as an attempt to "break the ice.")

No punishment delivered to Padnos matched those inflicted on the Syrian soldiers jailed communally with him. Periodically the al-Qaeda jailers escorted the soldiers out, probably to be murdered. During the period when he was kept in the basement of an eye hospital in Aleppo, Padnos heard "inhuman screaming, as if from beasts in a slaughterhouse ... Could this be the sound a human makes when his insides were being ripped apart?" The *Washington Post* correspondent Liz Sly visited the hospital (she didn't know Padnos was there) and wrote about al-Qaeda's attempt to run the city. Padnos is incredulous. It was no makeshift city hall, he says. "In fact, the authorities here meant to put heretics to the rack." Most journalists consider bombing hospitals a war crime. Last year Padnos tweeted, "During my six months as a prisoner in the Aleppo Eye Hospital, I came to feel that if I truly hoped for the best for the civilian population of this city, I could not also hope that the hospital in which I was living would not be bombed away."

THE SADNESS of this book is indescribable, even at the end, when his conditions improved and al-Qaeda groomed him for release. Qatar, an alleged sponsor of jihadist groups, mediated his release, and some speculate that Qatar paid millions in ransom, which Qatar denies. (After nine months, Schrier escaped through a window in their shared cell and made it to Turkey. He says he couldn't have pulled Padnos up after him. Padnos says Schrier left him behind to be tortured and possibly killed when the jailers discovered the escape. In any case, Padnos experienced his departure as a relief.) It has taken six years to produce this memoir—longer than the gestation of any of the

other hostage memoirs—and the care shows. It is the best of the genre, profound, poetic, and sorrowful.

Nearly all hostage memoirs lack a convincing finale. Coming home is a process that never ends. If you have a partner or children, you cannot just hop back into your marital bed or kiss those little strangers and expect them to kiss you back. Lessons are learned—chiefly the lesson that life before the hostage experience was a farce. But what does one replace that life with? Padnos answers enigmatically: "In a prison cell, at the very end of your allotment of days, you are in a little eagles' nest, a thousand feet above the surface of the earth." The view is a panorama of folly and regret. All the things worth doing went neglected; all that is pointless was lavished with care. "You can see everything. Why do the living struggle and sweat, you wonder, when all they really need to do is to live?" One gets the sense that he has traveled to a faraway planet, acquired at great personal cost the extraterrestrial knowledge found there, and then returned transfigured or transmogrified, in ways the rest of us are lucky we will never fully understand.

His memoir reminds me less of the other hostage memoirs than of the most sublime of Anton Chekhov's short stories, a parable titled "The Bet" (1889). In it a foolish young man bets a rich banker that he can endure 15 years' solitary confinement in the banker's garden lodge. The young man can request books and food in "any quantity," and if he stays the full 15 years, he will win a fortune from the banker. Chekhov narrates the story from the perspective of the banker, who for 15 years knows nothing of his prisoner except what he can deduce from the man's reading requests and the sound of occasional weeping. After 15 years, the no-longer-young man emerges in the middle of the night and runs off, forsaking his fortune. He declares in a letter:

I despise your books, I despise wisdom and the blessings of this world. It is all worthless, fleeting, illusory, and deceptive, like a mirage. You may be proud, wise, and fine, but death will wipe you off the face of the earth as though you were no more than mice burrowing under the floor, and your posterity, your history, your immortal geniuses will burn or freeze together with the earthly globe.

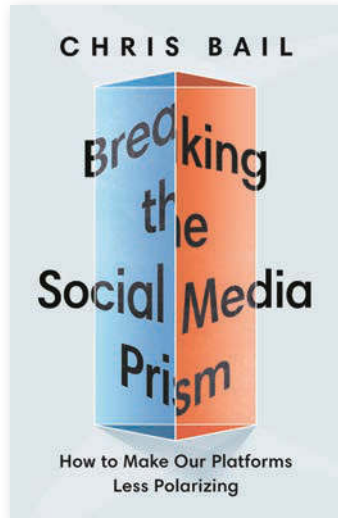
One is not entirely sure one wants to possess mad wisdom like this. Padnos was force-fed it, and we should be grateful to taste a bitter morsel—and no more. *A*

Graeme Wood is a staff writer at The Atlantic and the author of The Way of the Strangers: Encounters With the Islamic State.

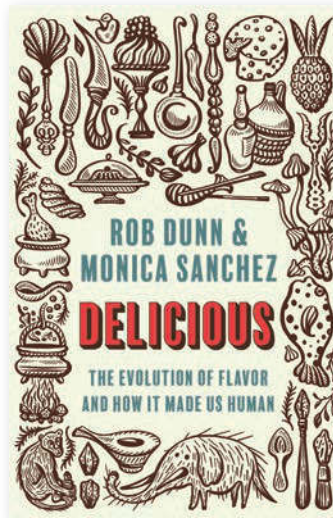
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A MEMOIR
OF CAPTURE,
TORTURE, AND
ENLIGHTENMENT

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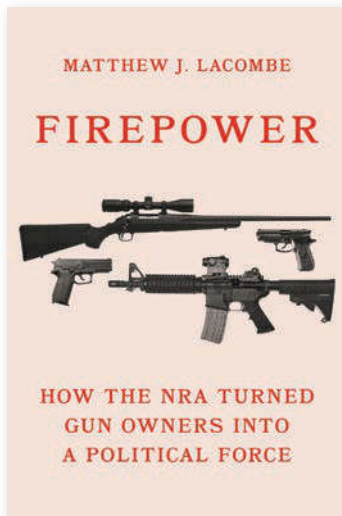
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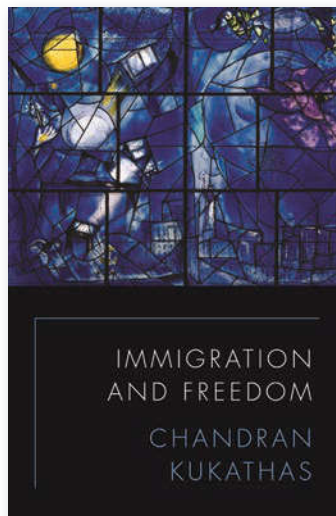
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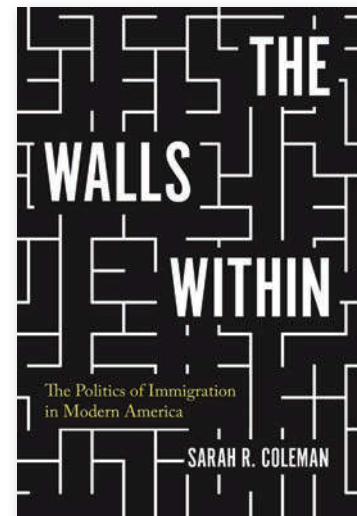
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Three Worlds of Relief

ESSAY

The Western Rides Again

*A new cohort of
directors, all women,
is exploring
the death wish that
infuses the genre—
and proposing visions
of repair.*

By Jordan Kisner

I grew up in San Diego, which resembles the backdrop of *High Noon* or *Unforgiven* not at all but is extremely *west*, geographically speaking. Maybe this is what disposed me to feel that the Western as a film genre was trite and foolish, dangerously sentimental about horizons and stoicism and men shooting each other for no good reason. I know these are fighting words. But the notion of the western



frontier offering limitless opportunity to colonize—framed as limitless freedom, resources, and promise of transformation—is less attractive when you are raised at its terminus. “San Diego is the extreme southwest town of the United States; and since our real westward expansion has come to a standstill, it has become a veritable jumping-off place,” Edmund Wilson wrote in a 1931 essay about the strangely high rate of suicides in the city at that time.

You seem to see the last blind feeble futile effervescence of the great burst of the American adventure. Here this people, so long told to “go West” to escape from poverty, ill health, maladjustment, industrialism and oppression, discover that, having come West, their problems and diseases still remain and that there is no further to go.

Wilson describes San Diego as the place where manifest destiny, the animating dream of the Western, curdles; here the endless land ends and there are no more American horizons on which to pin hopes or ambition—only high, unstable cliffs at the ocean’s edge to hurl yourself off.

I love where I am from, and I love the landscapes of the American West in general—and so I am skeptical of the mythos of the American West, which has often been used as an excuse to annihilate the land itself, and the people living on it. Almost a decade ago, I drove from San Diego up to Owens Valley, in Inyo County, which was where many classic Westerns of the 20th century, including *Hopalong Cassidy*, *Westward Ho*, and the original Lone Ranger film, were shot. (The proprietor of the motel I stayed in proudly told me that his grandmother had been John Wayne’s local girl of choice.) In the early 1900s, California drained Owens Lake to supply water to Los Angeles, so thoroughly desiccating the area’s lush environment that it became a giant dust bowl. Arsenic-laced dust storms howled through. This reality—people romancing the land while laying waste to it—soured me on the Western, which seemed to ennoble or obscure that devastation. This paradox “is the West yesterday, today, and forever,” the historian Bernard DeVoto wrote in his 1947 essay

“The West Against Itself,” which took aim at industries, like mining, that depended on the area’s natural resources while plundering them. “It is the Western mind stripped to the basic split. The West as its own worst enemy. The West committing suicide.”

So my ears perked up when, maybe two-thirds of the way through watching Chloé Zhao’s third film, *Nomadland*, my partner, sitting next to me on the couch, suddenly said aloud, as if in recognition, “Oh, right! The Western is always about suicide.”

You might not immediately think of *Nomadland* as a Western: Zhao supplies

*Fern is a cowboy
par excellence,
an arch and
solitary figure, a
straight-backed
and stiff-legged
protagonist driven
from the safety
of “civilization”
toward a different
kind of existence.*

no horses, no guns, no cattle, no holdups. The film’s setting is the present day, and instead of John Wayne there is Frances McDormand playing Fern, a woman who has lost her husband, her job, and her home. She never had children, and the town where she lived with her husband before he died has vanished, shriveled to nothing after the mining factory where she worked closed. Now she lives in a white van she has named “Vanguard,” driving around the West to wherever jobs are available: at

campgrounds, in an Amazon warehouse, on a farm during harvest season. Fern has unintentionally joined a growing subculture: “workampers,” or people whose economic circumstances have deteriorated such that they lead itinerant lives, following temporary work. According to the non-fiction book by Jessica Bruder on which the film is based, these transient “nomads,” as they call themselves, likely number in the thousands. (Except for McDormand and David Strathairn, the nomads in *Nomadland* are played by people genuinely living that life.) A lot of them are of retirement age, like Fern—people who were employed by industries that collapsed and didn’t rebound, and whose savings evaporated in the financial crash of 2008.

Nomadland, with its scenes of Amazon-warehouse work and RVs and aging women in sandals, is not the archetypal cowboy movie. Nor does it subscribe to the idea of the West as a vast, exploitable space. The land Fern wanders has been ravaged by now-depleted manufacturing and extraction industries, and is ruled by corporations that plunder a new endless resource: cheap labor. And yet Fern is a cowboy par excellence, an arch and solitary figure, a straight-backed and stiff-legged protagonist driven from the safety of “civilization” toward a different kind of existence, one set against the dusty expanse of the American West. She wears the hell out of a men’s coat, smoking cigarettes broodily in the sunset.

ZHAO, WHOSE DEBUT FILM, *Songs My Brothers Taught Me*, came out in 2015, is part of a convergence of auteurs who are redrawing the boundaries of the genre and tapping into an anti-triumphalist impulse that has hovered somewhere beneath its surface. Kelly Reichardt (whose *First Cow*, released last year, followed *Certain Women* and *Meek’s Cutoff*) and Debra Granik (her most recent film, 2018’s *Leave No Trace*, was preceded by *Stray Dog* and *Winter’s Bone*) have been at work for more than a decade. Anna Kerrigan’s first full-length feature, *Cowboys*, was released this year. Each has different interests and signatures: Reichardt has made period Westerns, while the others have turned to contemporary settings. Zhao works almost exclusively with nonactors. Granik’s first

experimentation with the genre's conventions was set in the Ozarks, not usually a terrain included in the Western, and her recent films portray veterans with PTSD. Kerrigan's debut features one trans protagonist and another struggling with mental illness. But as this quartet of women filmmakers make new contributions to a very old genre, they're united by an interest in probing the isolation and alienation of people on the American "frontier"—and in critiquing the frontier illusion itself, the fantasy that fleeing toward the next horizon offers riches as well as freedom from the waste and damage left behind.

As Quentin Tarantino remarked in 2013, "One of the things that's interesting about Westerns in particular is there's no other genre that reflects the decade that they were made or the morals and the feelings of Americans" so well. "Westerns are always a magnifying glass." (His own film *Django Unchained*—featuring a formerly enslaved Black cowboy—had just stirred up racial controversy.) Behind these new films lies a recent interest in scrutinizing the colonial vision of the American West, especially the adversarial attitude driving it—cowboys versus Indians, man versus nature. At the heart of the allegory of the frontier, the mid-century film critic Jim Kitses suggested, was a stark conflict between wilderness and civilization that encompassed a host of other values seen as battling it out in the nation's expansionist mission. "The Wilderness" was associated with individualism and supposedly masculine values like freedom, purity, honor, integrity, solipsism, and brutality, he wrote. "Civilization" represented the safety of society (culture, humanity, institutions, refinement, "the feminine") as well as its failures and disappointments (corruption, compromise, restriction). Westerns dramatized the tension between these two polarized worlds.

Yet a hallmark of the genre at its best has been a recurrent need to complicate these oppositions—above all in the figure of the cowboy, who has tended to subtly betray the illogic of this binary mentality. Often on the run from the injustices or constraints of society, he was the paradigmatic masculine hero and "conqueror" of the wilderness; at the same time, his presence in the landscape spelled the arrival

of the society he mistrusted. This was his predicament: striving for absolute rugged individualism, while entangled in the civilization that plagued or misunderstood him.

These recent entries into the canon reflect a desire to more explicitly question the wisdom of pitting wilderness against civilization, individual against community, masculine against feminine. The far-from-triumphant results of manifest destiny have become ever more obvious: the displacement or extermination of Native

populations, the devastation of ecosystems, the faltering of the industries that promised prosperity. The films' directors examine the consequences, and experiment with alternatives. They ask whether a cowboy who isn't solitary, isn't brutal, isn't fatalistic, isn't hungering for the next horizon, isn't even male might do less damage—and might survive.

As *Nomadland* demonstrates, the conventions of the Western lend themselves well to evoking present-day alienation. Zhao's nomads—like members of other



Top: In addition to the actor Frances McDormand, Chloë Zhao works in *Nomadland* with a cast that includes people actually living the nomad life.

Bottom: McDormand's character, Fern, drives around the West in a van that she has named "Vanguard," taking jobs where she can find them.

outcast subcultures in American history—wander the landscape of the West because they have nowhere else to go. Yet they recast (or reclaim) that wandering as freedom, self-reliance, and self-knowledge—an opportunity to achieve a purer, less mediated experience of the natural world than they had back in their old houses or jobs. Like the Lone Ranger, Fern is deeply isolated, which is partly because of her circumstances (the Lone Ranger, too, had lost almost everyone close to him) but also seems innate to her personality. When offered the opportunity to be in a relationship with a kind man (Strathairn), she declines, uncomfortable with intimacy and domesticity. When her sister invites her to stay, she demurs, itching to be back on the road. “It’s always what’s *out there* that’s more interesting,” her sister says, hurt. In classic cowboy fashion, Fern can only move forward, toward the unknown horizon, even when turning back or staying put would raise her odds of survival.

Death haunts the film. At various points, the danger looms that Fern will freeze to death while sleeping in her camper in extreme cold; be attacked by people at rest stops; break down in the middle of nowhere and die of exposure or dehydration. She does in fact get a flat tire in the Arizona desert right after one of the annual gatherings of van-living nomads, on terrain where she’s unlikely to encounter anyone else. She’s lucky, though: One last nomad has yet to depart, a woman named Swankie, who grumpily drives her to town and scolds her. “You can die out here. You’re out in the wilderness, far away from anybody. You can *die* out here, don’t you understand that?” Swankie herself carries a book by Jack Keovorkian (“Dr. Death”) as insurance; she has terminal cancer, but intends to take her life before being forced to go back “indoors.”

We are acutely aware that Fern may, in some real sense, wish to die. At the very least, the likelihood of violence or death on the road seems preferable to what is behind her—a lost beloved, the home they shared now hollowed out and sitting silently in a whole town of abandoned houses. Even the pitying offers of help from former friends propel Fern toward what looks like the bleakest fate.



Top: *The Lone Ranger*, played by Clayton Moore in the 1956 feature film as well as in the television series, has lost almost everyone close to him. Middle: *The title character in Shane (1953) comes to the aid of homesteaders, but then resumes his solitary life.* Bottom: *In High Noon, a retiring marshal stubbornly insists on facing a group of outlaws alone.*



Top: Michelle Williams plays a pioneer in Meek's Cutoff, Kelly Reichardt's unromantic portrayal of a journey westward in the 1840s. Middle: In Oregon's remote forests, the protagonists of Debra Granik's *Leave No Trace* struggle to sustain a family bond. Bottom: In Anna Kerrigan's *Cowboys*, a trans boy and his father find that an escape into the wilds of Montana isn't the liberating adventure they hoped for.

This is the trope of the Western to which my partner was referring. At the genre's darkest, cowboys are driven to violence, alienation, isolation, and even a kind of nihilism. The cowboy often knows that he must die, or is fleeing into the frontier void from something equally annihilating. Think of Butch and Sundance in flight, an inescapable bounty on their heads. They hurl themselves off a cliff, rob and kill from Wyoming all the way to Bolivia, and then, once caught, step with grim cheer in front of a firing line in the movie's final frame. Or think of Thelma and Louise on the run from law enforcement, sure they will be convicted of murder for shooting Thelma's attempted rapist. Finally cornered, they decide to "keep going," sailing their Ford Thunderbird straight over the precipice into the Grand Canyon.

When he is not enforcing some self-devised sense of "law" over the "wilderness," the cowboy is frequently an outlaw, running not only from death in the abstract but from a death sentence that is mandated and will be enforced by an unjust or uncomprehending "society." Anything is possible—and any violence justifiable—for this misunderstood person with no connections to tether him and nothing left to lose. Whether the Lone Ranger, Shane, or William Munty in *Unforgiven*, the cowboy enacts that alienation and makes it thrilling, heroic—the moral stance of a maverick. But this feature of the genre isn't necessarily darkly heroic; sometimes it's simply dark, and tragic, a razor's edge that *Nomadland* traces. If the Western, writ large, tells the story of a whole country driving itself to a "jumping-off place"—socially, economically, environmentally, culturally—its current practitioners raise the question of whether it's too late to back away.

IN DIFFERENT WAYS, Reichardt, Granik, and Kerrigan make this violent alienation a primary subject—and find within the form of the Western itself opportunities for intervention and repair. In *Cowboys*, Kerrigan casts the classic on-the-run tale in contemporary terms: Joe is an 11-year-old transgender boy living in western Montana whose mother insists that he keep his hair long, wear

hyperfeminine clothing, and play like the “other little girls.” Cowboys, to him, are the pinnacle of masculinity, and he sneaks into flannel shirts, blue jeans, belts with shiny buckles, and boots every chance he gets, only to be punished for it. Feeling as if he can’t survive much longer if forced to live as a girl, he asks for help from his father, who is estranged from Joe’s mother and coming to terms with a diagnosis of bipolar disorder. They take off into the forests of Montana (on a white horse, no less), hoping that if they can make it to Canada, Joe can live as he must—as he is.

The existential threat that Joe is running from feels acute—and the notion that he might be able to live with integrity and truth only outside and cut off from others is compelling. The terrain the pair ride through is breathtaking. And yet Joe’s turn as a lone ranger isn’t freeing; it’s bloody and terrifying. His father, whose medication is swept away in some rapids (in which Joe nearly drowns), grows manic and grandiose. Joe accidentally shoots someone. Eventually they are the subject of a manhunt so large, it seems clear that father and son will die if they press onward. Joe winds up clutching a rifle, surrounded by snipers on all sides, a frail child exposed in an indifferent landscape. His choice is clear, and classic: put down the gun and step back from the brink—or jump off. Unlike Butch and Sundance, he isn’t glib or accepting; he’s traumatized.

In *Leave No Trace*, Granik also portrays a father and child who have uneasy relationships to society. Will is a veteran with PTSD who can no longer stand living in civilization. Instead, he camps in remote areas of Oregon’s forests with his 13-year-old daughter. Like *Cowboys*, the film explores the fallout of failed community—broken trust between an individual and the society that made him; broken trust between a struggling parent and a lonely child; a society’s skepticism toward anyone who rejects it; a longing for rootedness overridden by trauma. When Tom, Will’s daughter, begs him to stay in the small trailer community where they’ve found friendship and shelter, his refusal is presented not as heroic or noble, but as deeply tragic. Even if it ruptures their relationship, he has to *keep going*.

Reichardt, too, is drawn to uncovering the vulnerability buried within the Western. Her 2010 film, *Meek’s Cutoff*, depicts the pioneer journey west in the 1840s as anything but a tale of excitement, romance, and individualism; instead, it is a collective, near-fatal, and profoundly monotonous undertaking. It features an ensemble cast—three couples are traveling together for protection. The movie mostly shows them silently walking next to their oxen, for miles and miles, punctuated by scenes of the women lighting fires, beating

If the Western, writ large, tells the story of a country driving itself to a “jumping-off place,” its current practitioners raise the question of whether it’s too late to back away.

laundry, and knitting. The cowboy in the movie, Meek, is a guide who claims he can get them safely to their destination in Oregon, and bluffs and brags about his solitary mastery of the terrain and his experience shooting “savage” Native people for fun. Meek is transparently lost and leading the travelers to their deaths. He insists that he alone knows the way, but the farther they follow him, the more lost they get.

Reichardt’s new film, *First Cow*, offers cowboys who are gentle and relational. Its subject is the partnership between two men trying to survive in a fur-trapping outpost in Oregon Territory in the 1820s.

Cookie Figowitz is a traveling cook working for a group of fur trappers, a shy man with a talent for baking. King-Lu is a Chinese immigrant on the run for killing a man in a fight. Both are alienated from (and endangered by) the violent culture of the frontier location they occupy, yet they form a tentative, and then tender, friendship. When King-Lu invites Cookie to his shack, Cookie sweeps it, beats out the rug, and picks some wildflowers to make it homey.

The film is a cowboy domestic drama: Reichardt’s plot, while staying squarely in the genre of a frontier Western, turns on Cookie’s baking, and its power to offer nostalgia, pleasure, and sweetness to men starved for them. The two men are deeply attached, and not in the manner of Butch and Sundance, say, whose friendship thrives on complementary talents for outlaw life and a shared death warrant. Cookie and King-Lu are outlaws (they steal milk from the one cow in the outpost), but their bond is rooted in a kind of mutual care that is oriented toward survival and connection. They cannot actually survive—their ambition leads them to take risks that mean they eventually run afoul of the wealthy, authoritarian British expat in charge of the outpost—but when they die, they are lying side by side.

THERE’S USUALLY a moment in Westerns when the cowboy has an opportunity to turn back, to seek help, to admit pain and weakness, to ask for another way out. The desperate situation usually has an alternative, if only the lone ranger would tolerate his own vulnerability and fallibility. Consider *High Noon*, the plot of which hinges on retiring Marshal Will Kane’s vain effort to rally a posse to confront an outlaw who he learns is headed into town. His wife—a pacifist—tries to talk him out of it, his former co-workers refuse to join in, and townspeople ask why Kane is insisting on vigilante justice when they pay taxes to support local law enforcement. “This is crazy,” he admits, but Kane—unwilling to lose face or admit to the impossibility of confronting the outlaw and his gang alone—stubbornly insists on continuing with the plan, grimly writing out his will before stepping forth, alone, to face the group of armed men.

He is shot, of course. (Thanks to the intervention of his wife, he doesn't die—"that isn't my idea of a good Western sheriff," the director Howard Hawks scoffed, irked by a marshal begging for help, and then being saved by a woman.) But what if, in the moments before stepping out into the dusty street, he had just ... turned around?

I keep returning to Zhao's 2017 film, *The Rider*, which tells the story of a wounded cowboy. Brady Jandreau plays a version of himself named Brady Blackburn, a gifted rodeo cowboy and horse tamer. (Like *Songs My Brothers Taught Me*, this story is set on the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation, in South Dakota, and stars members of the Lakota Sioux Tribe.) "I'm a cowboy *and* an Indian," Jandreau said in an interview after the film was released. The movie begins as Brady is recovering from a catastrophic injury sustained in a fall during a rodeo. The horse stomped on his head, crushing his skull and putting him into a coma. Brady has a zipper of gruesome stitches crowning his shaved head, as well as brain damage, and he's been forbidden by doctors from ever riding horses or competing in a rodeo again.

Yet riding horses through the South Dakota landscape where he and his family live is more than Brady's livelihood. "God gives each of us a purpose," he tells his sister. He is tortured and isolated, unwilling and unable to accept the constricted reality that is taking shape before him. We see Brady pushing against it—riding short distances, breaking a wild horse for a neighbor—and suffering the results: He vomits and has seizures that twist his hand into a stiff claw.

Brady isn't alone, a fact at the core of the film. In a moving scene, Brady visits his best friend, Lane, in a long-term rehab facility. Lane, we understand, also suffered a rodeo accident, only he wasn't as lucky as Brady: He suffered profound brain damage and can no longer speak or walk. (Lane is played by Lane Scott, Jandreau's real-life friend and a rising rodeo star injured in a car accident.) Brady and Lane talk (Lane

finger-spelling with one hand) and watch old YouTube videos of Lane's good rides. "Sit up and look at me," Brady says gently when Lane begins to slump over. "Pick your head up, brother."

The film's crisis arrives when Brady, who can't endure the idea of living if he can't be a cowboy, signs up to compete in a rodeo, even though his seizures are getting worse and his doctor has told him that he can't afford another fall. He is vibrating with rage and desperation when he tells his father (played by Brady's real father, Tim Jandreau) why he's putting his saddle in the truck. "I'm gonna ride. I figured you were coming to watch," he says. His father refuses, and then poses a question that feels like a challenge to the Western, the West, the viewer, the cowboy himself: "What the fuck would I want to come for? Watch you kill yourself?" Brady has no answer.

But his father does come to the rodeo—knowing perhaps that witnessing Brady's pain is a form of solidarity and care. He brings Brady's younger sister, Lilly (played by Lilly Jandreau). They stand a ways off, looking on while Brady prepares for the ride. Seeing them, he pauses. He paces; looks at the horse, already in the chute; and looks again at them. Brady approaches the chute and then stops, turns around, and walks away from the pen and back toward his father. We see them hug in the distance, Brady's back to the rodeo, as they prepare to go home together.

This gesture (turning around, admitting pain and fear, apologizing, asking for help) has been rare in the Western, and yet it is a motif in these films. Although Fern continues living and traveling alone in her van, she also survives on intermittent moments of connection with other nomads, who understand her desire to balance solitude and community, to live mostly alone in nature while bound by human ties. Fern never reintegrates into the world she left, never revisits the offers to live again in a family home—and yet we see her at her most alive in the moments when she finds

communion on the road, helping a fellow nomad or being helped. After Swankie dies, Fern joins a gathering of nomads in throwing rocks into a campfire in her memory. Kerrigan's cowboys, too, find healing, repair, and survival not alone in the woods but after returning to the people who hurt them—and to the family they hurt by fleeing. In *Leave No Trace*, Tom's greatest act of courage is deciding to stay among the neighbors and friends she has found, knowing that her father will depart alone. Though they can't be together, she hangs a food pack in the woods for him to find when he passes back near her.

Like *The Rider*, these films offer an alternative to the solitary individual who is too committed to his own self-mythology to save himself. They dismantle the notion that individuals achieve self-realization, integrity, and freedom alone and in opposition to (or rejection of) their community. The vision isn't a sentimental one: Human connections, in these movies, are precarious and take arduous work to sustain, and the survival they enable isn't triumphal. Brady's story doesn't end in either heroism or death—instead, he just *lives*, with his years of rehab ahead of him, his loving and flawed family, his maimed and precious body.

Soon after he chooses to walk away from the rodeo, Brady is back in Lane's room at the rehab center. He starts a game we've seen them play before: They pretend Lane is riding a horse. Brady offers Lane his hands. "Grab your reins," he tells him. "Wheel him around to the left." Lane tugs Brady's hands. "All right, now to the right ... Back him up. You're on big ole Gus again ... Remember that wind on your face?" Brady says, and Lane smiles slightly. The two wounded cowboys continue on for a while that way, with their pretend horse, riding together. *A*

Jordan Kisner is the author of Thin Places: Essays From In Between.

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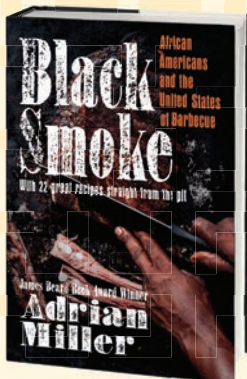
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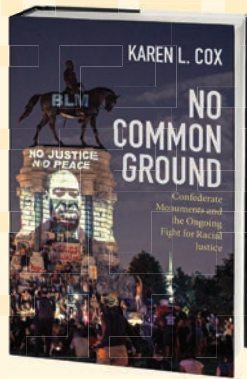
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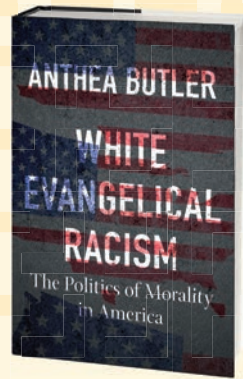
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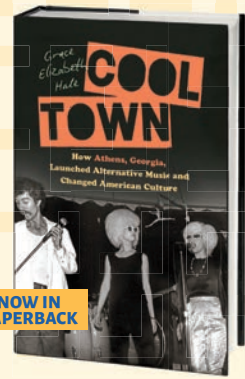
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I raised the drumstick,

brought it down, and a dream-world opened beneath me.

A dreamworld, to be clear, of incompetence. A dream-world of crapness and debility. A slump in tempo, an abyss. I was sitting at my practice drum kit, attempting one of the signature moves of the late John “Bonzo” Bonham, of Led Zeppelin: triplets with a left-hand lead. Done properly, with the correct dosage of taste and power in each stroke, left-handed triplets will conjure an extraordinary kind of jazzy thunder. Done improperly, they sound like a wardrobe falling down stairs. When I lead with my right hand, my triplets are okay. Not Bonhamesque, not Bonzoid, but okay. But when I switch to the *left* ...

Being human, reader, you know exactly what I’m talking about. Righty or lefty, you know that if you lead with your nondominant hand, whether you’re brushing your teeth or

dismantling an unexploded bomb, the clichés of maladroitness will swarm you: the fists of ham, the fingers of butter, the multiplicity of thumbs.

Why this built-in asymmetry, this out-of-whack distribution of motor skills? The biology of handedness is complex. But the psychology, it seems to me, is pretty straightforward. It goes like this: Inside your nervous system lives a shadow person, a shadow you, shy and clumsy, dislocated, light-fearing, not nearly as good at things as you are. An underachiever who would very much like to be left alone. And you get in touch with this person, immediately and directly, by using your weaker hand.

Work the left, say the sports coaches. Learn how to catch a ball, throw a punch, make a shot with your weaker hand. Shouldn’t the life coaches say it too? By summoning your gauche self, the muzzy and foot-dragging character who rises and sleeps with you, you’re doubling your capacities. Treat this character with a stern kindness, with a reproving warmth. Insist on discipline. Marvel, humbly, at the slowness of the progress.

And if you—which is to say, I—can eventually pull off the sweet Bonzoid clatter of a clean left-handed triplet, then maybe, who knows, never say die, I can one day tackle the unfinished novel currently jutting out of my psyche like a lump of the Acropolis. They lurk on the shadow side, these possibilities. In the murk of the as-yet-untrained. In the cunning of the weaker hand. *A*

James Parker is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

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— to —

THE LEFT HAND

By James Parker



A close-up, high-angle shot of a woman's face, looking slightly upwards and to the right. She is wearing a black headset with a microphone. Her expression is pleasant, with a slight smile. The lighting is warm and soft, highlighting her features.

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I AM COURTNEY THOMPSON

Executive Director, Global Sustainable Finance

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